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COMPARATIVE POLITICS

Rationality, Culture, and Structure

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For
Faye
and
Roberta

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PREFACE AND ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Comparative politics, the field whose intellectual forebears include Karl Marx, Max Weber, Emile Durkheim, Gaetano Mosca, Roberto Michels, and Vilfredo Pareto, has lost its way. The promise offered by the founders of the modern study of comparative politics three decades ago, Harry Eckstein, David Apter, Robert Dahl, Karl Deutsch, Gabriel Almond, and Sidney Verba, has not been fulfilled. Too few studies are nomothetic, creatively combining theory and cases and developing general propositions. Too many studies are idiographic, offering no more than a wave to the systematic development and assessment of powerful explanatory arguments. Unlike students of American politics, comparativists do not draw upon methodological advances to power their scholarship. Unlike students of international politics, comparativists do not debate grand questions of theory. A field established by the founders of social thought and reinvented by some of the most important political scientists of the postwar era needs to be discovered yet again.

The coeditors discussed these ideas at the Meetings of the American Political Science Association in 1994. Puzzled by the slow growth of theories in comparative politics and dismayed by the lack of systematic attention to the field's research traditions, we first lamented the decline of this subdiscipline and then resolved to do something about it. Since we view research schools, especially rational choice theory, culturalist analyses, and structuralist approaches, to be at the center of the development of theory, we asked several of the field's senior scholars to join us in an effort to return attention in comparative politics to the analysis of the research communities and traditions that have historically shaped our field. Their agreement, made concrete in the essays found in this volume, and the encouragement of Alex Holzman, our editor at Cambridge University Press, has enabled us to turn our lament and resolve into a book that we hope orients future theory and research in comparative politics.

1

RESEARCH TRADITIONS AND THEORY IN COMPARATIVE POLITICS: AN INTRODUCTION

Mark I. Lichbach
Alan S. Zuckerman

THE COMMON HERITAGE OF COMPARATIVE POLITICS

Comparativists inherit their dream of theorizing about politics from the founders of social theory. Their intellectual forebears represent the pantheon of Western thought. In the classic survey of the field's intellectual origins, Harry Eckstein (1963) highlights the past masters.

> Comparative politics ... has a particular right to claim Aristotle as an ancestor because of the primacy that he assigned to politics among the sciences and because the problems he raised and the methods he used are similar to those still current in political studies (Eckstein 1963: 3).

Machiavelli and Montesquieu, Hobbes and Smith are the progenitors who lived during the Renaissance and the Enlightenment. The classic theorists of social science – Karl Marx, Max Weber, Emile Durkheim, Vilfredo Pareto, Gaetano Mosca, and Roberto Michels – established the field's research agenda, mode of analysis, and contrasting theoretical visions. Several seminal theorists of contemporary political science – Harry Eckstein, David Apter, Robert Dahl, Seymour Lipset, Karl Deutsch, Gabriel Almond, and Sidney Verba – drew on this heritage to rebuild and reinvigorate the field of comparative politics. A shared, grand intellectual vision motivates comparativists.

1) Comparativists want to understand the critical events of the day, a position that ensures that dreams of theory address the political world as it exists, not for-

mal abstractions or utopias. Just as Marx and Weber responded to the fundamental transformations associated with the rise of capitalism, just as Marx developed a general strategy for a socialist revolution and Weber grappled with the theoretical and normative demands of the bureaucratic state, and just as Mosca, Pareto, and Michels strove to understand the possibilities and limits of democratic rule, students of comparative politics examine pressing questions in the context of their immediate political agenda. The contemporary study of comparative politics therefore blossomed in response to the political problems that followed World War II. New forms of conflict emerged: Communist threats; peasant rebellions and revolutions; social movements, urban riots, student upheavals, military coups, and national liberation struggles swept the world. Government decisions replaced markets as foci for economic development. New states followed the disintegration of colonial empires, and the worldwide movement toward democratic rule seemed to resume after the fascist tragedies. The challenges of the current era – domestic conflict, state-building, the political bases of economic growth, and democratization, to note but a few – stand at the center of today's research, indicating that the need to respond to contemporary issues guides the field.

Comparative politics therefore asserts an ambitious scope of inquiry. No political phenomenon is foreign to it; no level of analysis is irrelevant, and no time period beyond its reach. Civil war in Afghanistan; voting decisions in Britain; ethnic conflict in Quebec, Bosnia, and Burundi; policy interactions among the bureaucracies of the European Union in Brussels, government agencies in Rome, regional offices in Basilicata, and local powers in Potenza; the religious bases of political action in Iran, Israel, and the United States; the formation of democracies in Eastern Europe and the collapse of regimes in Africa; and global economic patterns are part of the array of contemporary issues that stand before the field. Questions about the origins of capitalism; the formation of European states; the rise of fascism and the collapse of interwar democracies; and the transition to independence after colonial rule are some of the themes of past eras that still command our attention.

Second, comparativists assert an ambitious intellectual vision in that they approach these substantive concerns with general questions in mind. Anyone who studies the politics of a particular country – whether Germany or Ghana, the United Arab Emirates or the United States of America – so as to address abstract issues, does comparative politics. Anyone who is interested in who comes to power, how, and why – the names, places, and dates of politics in any one place or other – in order to say something about the politics of succession or the determinants of vote choice, is a comparativist. In other words, students of comparative politics examine a case to reveal what it tells us about a larger set of political phenomena, or they relate the particulars of politics to more general theoretical ideas about politics.

Comparativists therefore insist that analysis requires explicit comparisons. Because events of global historical significance affect so many countries in so short a period of time, studies of single countries and abstract theorizing are woefully inadequate to capture epoch-shaping developments. More than three decades ago, when the founders of the contemporary field of comparative politics

initiated the most recent effort to merge theory and data in the study of politics, they therefore established another of the field's guiding principles: The proper study of politics requires systematic comparisons.[1]

Finally, comparativists assert a grand intellectual vision in that their generalizations are situated in the context of the Big Questions of social thought: Who rules? How are interests represented? Who wins and who loses? How is authority challenged? Why are some nations "developed"? These questions have produced much contemporary theorizing about the connections among social order, the state, civil society, and social change, especially in democracies. Comparativists engage the basic issues that inform social and political thought.

In sum, comparative politics follows the lead of the grand masters in their approach to substantive issues, to the scope of inquiry, to the nature of theory-building, and to the enduring problems of social thought. As comparativists address politically significant matters, explore a range of political phenomena, propose general explanatory propositions based on systematic evidence from multiple cases, and address Big Questions, they move along a path first marked by the founders of social science.

THE COMPETING TRADITIONS IN COMPARATIVE POLITICS

In spite of this shared dream, long-standing disagreements separated the field's forebears and contrasting research schools characterize current efforts to build theories in comparative politics. When many of today's senior scholars were graduate students, their training included courses that compared psychological and culturalist approaches, institutional studies of political organizations, structural–functional and systems analyses, cybernetics and modes of information theory, pluralist, elitist, and Marxist analyses, modernization theory and its alternatives of dependency and world-systems theories, and rational choice theory, to name the most obvious. Most of these perspectives have disappeared and some have formed new combinations. Today, rational choice theories, culturalist approaches, and structural analyses stand as the principal competing theoretical schools in comparative politics. Rational choice theorists follow a path laid out by Hobbes, Smith, and Pareto; culturalists continue work begun by Montesquieu and developed by Weber and Mosca; and structuralists build on Marx's foundations and add to Weber's edifice. The themes and debates of contemporary comparative politics are therefore rooted in the enduring questions of social thought. They continue to lie at the center of work in all the social sciences.

[1]Classic works that appeared to herald the emergence of comparative politics as a subdiscipline of political science include Almond and Coleman (1960), Almond and Verba (1963), Beer and Ulam (1958), Dahl (1966; 1971), Eckstein and Apter (1963), Holt and Turner (1970), Huntington (1968), La Palombara and Weiner (1966), Lipset and Rokkan (1967), Moore (1966), Przeworski and Teune (1970); Pye and Verba (1965), Riker (1962), and Sartori (1970). At the same time, two journals, *Comparative Politics* and *Comparative Political Studies,* appeared, helping to institutionalize the subfield.

Rationalists begin with assumptions about actors who act deliberately to maximize their advantage. This research school uses the power of mathematical reasoning to elaborate explanations with impressive scope. Analysis begins at the level of the individual and culminates in questions about collective actions, choices, and institutions. Following the path first charted by Downs (1957), Olson (1968), and Riker (1962), rational choice theory has spread to address diverse problems: from electoral choice to revolutionary movements, from coalitions to political economy, and from institution formation to state-building. Here, the clarity of mathematical reasoning takes pride of place; powerful abstract logics facilitate a shared understanding among the members of the research school.

As comparativists engage in fieldwork in diverse societies, they grapple with the need to understand varied ways of life, systems of meaning, and values. As students who cut their teeth on the abstractions of modernization and dependency theory encounter the realities of particular villages, political parties, and legislatures, they seek to ground their observations in the politics that is being analyzed. Following the lead of social and cultural anthropologists, many comparativists adhere to Geertz's (1973) admonition to provide "thick descriptions." Culturalists therefore provide nuanced and detailed readings of particular cases, frequently drawn from fieldwork, as they seek to understand the phenomena being studied. This stance usually joins strong doubts about both the ability to generalize to abstract categories and the ability to provide explanations that apply to more than the case at hand.

Structuralists draw together long-standing interests in political and social institutions. Many emphasize the formal organizations of governments; some retain Marx's concern with class relations; some study political parties and interest groups; some combine these into analyses of how states and societies interact; and some emphasize the themes of political economy. Although these scholars display diverse patterns of reasoning, from mathematical models to verbal arguments, and many modes of organizing empirical evidence, they continue to follow Marx's and Weber's contention that theory and data guide social analysis.

As Alan Zuckerman's essay indicates, these research traditions take strong positions on the methodological issues that divide comparativists.[2] Rational

[2]There is also a long-standing debate in comparative politics about methodology. As comparativists propose explanations that cover sets of cases, perhaps based on causal accounts, they grapple with questions that relate to theory-building, concept formation, and case selection: How do concepts carry across cases? What is the value of treating concepts as variables that are measured by indicators? What is the proper use of case-specific information in theories that cover many cases? How does the choice of cases affect the general propositions offered? Are there requirements that define the number of cases that need to be included in an analysis? What is the relevance of single case studies to the development of theory? How can single case studies be used to speak to general sets of phenomena? Is it possible or desirable to include all relevant instances in the analysis? Is it possible to devise an adequate methodology that permits powerful generalizations based on the observation of a small number of cases? These questions raise problems of external validity, the ability to generalize beyond the case being observed.

Nearly thirty years ago, Sartori (1970) drew attention to fundamental questions of concept formation. At that same time, Lijphart (1971) and Przeworski and Teune (1970) initiated a controversy about

choice theorists seek to maximize the ability to provide universal laws that may be used in nomothetic explanations. They consider problems of reliability – the concern with the evidence required to support generalizations from the particular to sets of cases – as a challenge to research design. Cultural interpreters maximize the importance of reliability as they describe the constellations of particular cases and minimize the value of generalist research expectations. They interpret particular events, decisions, and patterns, eschewing any need to tie explanations to general principles. Structural analysts who follow Marx offer universal theories that include causal accounts. At the same time, they struggle to tie reliable descriptions into powerful generalizations; they grapple self-consciously with the requirements of case selection and how best to move from the particular analysis to the set of cases about which they seek to theorize. Comparativists' long-standing debates over method thus reappear in the three research traditions.

However, as Mark Lichbach's essay indicates, the dispute among the schools goes beyond the ideographic–nomothetic divide. The traditions differ with respect to ontology: Rationalists study how actors employ reason to satisfy their interests, culturalists study rules that constitute individual and group identities, and structuralists explore relations among actors in an institutional context. Reasons, rules, and relations are the various starting points of inquiry. The traditions also differ with respect to explanatory strategy: Rationalists perform comparative static experiments, culturalists produce interpretive understandings, and structuralists study the historical dynamics of real social types. Positivism, interpretivism, and realism are the possible philosophies of social science.

Moreover, as both Zuckerman and Lichbach indicate, no school displays a rigid and uniform orthodoxy. Rationalists debate the utility of relaxing the core assumption that defines individuals as maximizers of their self-interest. They differ as well over the proper form of explanation, some seeking covering laws and others proposing causal accounts, as they debate the necessity of transforming formal models into accounts of events. Continuing the debate initiated by Marx and Weber, structuralists differ over the ontological status of their concepts: Are social class, ethnicity, state, and other concepts that characterize this research school natural types? Are political processes best seen as determined and closed-ended or probabilistic and open-ended processes? Structuralists differ as well over

the proper methodology of comparative research, in which Eckstein (1975), Ragin (1987), Ragin and Becker (1992), and Skocpol and Somers (1980) have offered significant alternative positions (see Collier 1993 for a review of this literature). Most recently, Collier and Mahon (1993), Collier (1993), and Sartori (1994) illustrate further developments concerning the proper formation of concepts, and King, Keohane, and Verba (1994; 1995) initiated a productive debate over issues of research design in comparative politics. On the latter, see especially Bartels (1995), Brady (1995), Caporaso (1995), Collier (1995), Laitin (1995), Mohr (1996), Rogowski (1995), and Tarrow (1995). There is a natural affinity between studies of research design and comparative method that is frequently overlooked. King, Keohane, and Verba (1994; 1995) argue that there is only one scientific method. Hence, their strictures resemble those proposed by Cook and Campbell (1979).

the utility of nomothetic and causal explanations. Culturalists disagree over the theoretical importance of generalizations drawn from their fieldwork. May one derive or test general propositions from the analysis of a particular village? Do public opinion surveys provide an adequate picture of people's goals, values, and identities? They differ over the nature of explanation in comparative politics as well. Some culturalists reject any form of covering law or causal accounts, offering only interpretations of political life in particular places; others move toward the mainstream of comparative politics, incorporating values and systems of meaning into theories that adhere to the standard forms of explanation. In short, as Lichbach makes clear in his essay, ideal-type rationalists, culturalists, and structuralists need to be identified so that we may recognize how practicing comparativists employ a battery of ideal-type strategies in their concrete empirical work.

Comparative politics is dominated today by rationalist, culturalist, and structuralist approaches. What explains the imperialist expansion of these schools and the disappearance of earlier approaches? As Lichbach's and Zuckerman's essays in this volume demonstrate, these schools share an ontological and epistemological symmetry. They offer – indeed force – choices along the same dimensions. Furthermore, at a more fundamental level, the themes of the research schools rest at the heart of the human sciences. Reason, rules, and relations are unique to social theory. Focusing on these themes sets research in the social sciences apart from the physical sciences, providing a fundamental basis on which to theorize about political phenomena. Rationalist, culturalist, and structuralist theories are thus embedded in strong research communities, scholarly traditions, and analytical languages.

ADVANCING THEORY IN COMPARATIVE POLITICS: AN OVERVIEW OF THE ESSAYS IN THIS VOLUME

The extraordinary range and importance of the topics examined by comparativists, the powerful and competing research schools that characterize the field, and the scholarly pedigree of its work invite periodic assessments of the state of comparative politics. In the early 1960s, Harry Eckstein and David Apter (1963) edited a collection of essays that established the field's questions. In 1970, Robert Holt and John Turner gathered together a set of contributions that raised the level of theoretical sophistication. Both volumes guided research in comparative politics.[3]

[3]Some other early studies of the relationship between the research schools and theory in comparative politics include Bill and Hardgrave (1973), La Palombara (1974), Mayer (1972), Merkl (1970), and Merritt (1971). Recent works include Almond (1991), Cantori and Ziegler (1988), Chilcote (1994), Crotty (1991), Dogan and Kazancigil (1994), Dogan and Pelassy (1984), Mayer (1989), Rogowski (1993), Rustow and Erickson (1991), Weiner and Huntington (1987), Wiarda (1990), and Zuckerman (1991).

A field advances through explicit dialogue about the relative strengths and weaknesses, successes and failures of the research traditions of which it is composed. Theory is a collective but contentious enterprise. While scholarship is the work of single scholars, knowledge accumulates as competing groups of scholars accept and reject claims about the world. We have therefore organized this volume around the theme of competing research traditions in comparative politics. Because so much analysis in comparative politics is guided by the expectations, assumptions, methods, and principles of rational choice theory, culturalist analyses, and structuralist approaches, assessments of the state of theory and prospects for advancing theory need to focus on these research schools. As the authors of the essays in this volume examine the research traditions in comparative politics, they assess knowledge and advance theory, seeking to direct research in the coming years.

Because research in comparative politics centers around distinctive topics, we have also selected four themes around which to examine the interplay between theory and the three schools: the analysis of mass politics (especially regarding electoral behavior), social movements and revolutions, political economy, and state–society relations. Why did we choose these topics? Taken together, they encompass much of the research done in comparative politics. Each displays a history of sophisticated theoretical and empirical work that stretches over several decades. The comparative study of voting behavior begins in the interwar years. Because most people who engage in political activities do so only at the ballot box, this research examines the political behavior of the largest set of people; here the study of politics moves its focus away from politicians and bureaucrats, government agencies and political parties, and the abstractions of state and society. The systematic analysis of social movements and revolutions descends directly from Marx and Weber. It also links to studies of regime transformations and the bases of stable democracies. Beginning with Adam Smith's theories, the analysis of the political economies of advanced industrial societies has become the focus of the largest segment of research on the political institutions and public policies of established democracies. As comparativists study state–society relations, they follow a path first marked by Marx, Weber, Mosca, Michels, and Pareto. As they study the formation of states, they blend abstract theorization and detailed empirical studies.

A study of these particular topics has the additional virtue of moving the analysis beyond the field of comparative politics. Examining the successes of the research schools with regard to each of these topics also casts light on the utility of various analytic techniques. Electoral analyses typically use quantitative techniques to study survey results and work on state–society relations includes the results of qualitative studies, while research on both social movements and revolutions and political economy varies in the use of quantitative and qualitative modes of analysis. Finally, these research themes also cast light on the relations between theories developed in comparative politics and those that characterize related fields in political science and the other social sciences. The research

themes thus tell us about the utility of hypotheses devised to explain electoral behavior and social movements in the United States, the value of methods and arguments drawn from economists in the study of political economy, and the significance of anthropological approaches for the analysis of state–society relations. In sum, as we analyze these four research topics, we shed light on central issues of theory in comparative politics and the social sciences more generally.

We have divided the essays into three units. The first, containing the chapters written by Margaret Levi, Marc Howard Ross, and Ira Katznelson, offers briefs for each of the research schools. The essays summarize each analytic tradition's core principles, noting variations within the approach and presenting recent work that points to new combinations. The next unit contains the chapters written by Samuel H. Barnes on mass politics, Doug McAdam, Sidney Tarrow, and Charles Tilly on social movements and revolution, Peter A. Hall on the political economy of established democracies, and Joel S. Migdal on state–society relations in newly formed states. The concluding unit contains essays by Mark I. Lichbach and Alan S. Zuckerman, returning the focus to the theme of advancing theory in comparative politics.

THE ESSAYS

Margaret Levi contends that rational choice theory displays several critical strengths. It demonstrates the potential gap between personal interest and the public good, individual behavior and collective action. It offers testable theories, providing the ability to make sense of a correlation or a set of events through a plausible and compelling story that identifies causal mechanisms and universal principles. Rationalists in comparative politics, she maintains, are committed to explanation and to generalization. Levi also sets out differences within the research school. Members of this analytic tradition differ in the extent to which they believe that the core principles can be tested directly. They vary as well in the form of explanation: Some search for covering laws and others offer causal explanations. Levi maintains that the major task confronting comparative rationalists is to offer explanations that compel both logically and empirically. To that end, she develops the method of analytic narratives, in which rational choice theory provides the principles that guide a narrative history of a political process. This method offers a bridge between rationalists and the other research schools. No matter the detail in an analytic narrative, maintains Levi, rationalists remain distinctive. They are almost always willing to sacrifice nuance for generalizability, detail for logic.

Marc Howard Ross argues on behalf of culturalist analyses. He maintains that two distinct, but not unrelated, features of culture are relevant to comparative politics. First, culture is a system of meaning which people use to manage their daily worlds, large and small; second, culture is the basis of social and political identity which affects how people stand and how they act on a wide range of matters. Culture is a framework for organizing the world, for locating the self

and others in it, for making sense of the actions and interpreting the motives of others, for grounding an analysis of interests, for linking collective identities to political action, and for motivating people and groups toward some actions and away from others. The effects of culture on collective action and political life are generally indirect, and to appreciate fully the role of culture in political life, it is necessary to inquire into how culture interacts with interests and institutions. Ross proposes that a postmodern, intersubjective understanding of politics is compatible with the belief that comparison is central to social science, no matter the complexity of social phenomena. Interpretations, Ross maintains, lie at the center of cultural analysis. The interpretations of particular political significance are built from the accounts of groups and individuals striving to make sense of their social and political worlds, and the term refers both to the shared intersubjective meanings of actors and also to the explicit efforts of social science observers to understand these meanings and to present them to others. Ross presents interpretations as a methodological tool in the comparative study of culture and politics for understanding processes like the construction of ethnic and national identities.

Ira Katznelson develops a macroanalytical mode of analysis. Katznelson presents a picture of society that is composed of important and significant social relationships, political processes, and economic interactions. Individuals are defined by these connections, as structures constrain their perceptions and choices. Katznelson believes that the most significant processes shaping human identities, interests, and interaction are such large-scale features of modernity as capitalist development, market rationality, state-building, secularization, political and scientific revolution, and the acceleration of instruments for the communication and diffusion of ideas. He offers an approach that examines the relationship of history and analytical social science; structural theory after Marxism; the special status of the state; and the question of behavioral and strategic microfoundations. He proposes a configurative approach, standing in opposition to the microanalytical and postpositivist currents that are increasingly important in political science. Finally, he offers a stirring call for a return to the world-historical vision of structuralists like Barrington Moore.

Samuel H. Barnes reviews the research traditions with regard to mass political behavior, concentrating first on turnout in national elections and then on partisan choice in established democracies. He maintains that research on the determinants of the decision to take part in an election display the strengths and weaknesses of each of the research schools. None has solved this problem, whether conceived as a question of aggregate variation across various countries and different points in time, or as the single act of casting a ballot for any one person. Barnes regards partisan choice as a more complex problem. Reviewing evidence that the mobilization of publics in established democracies has shifted from social to political to cognitive bases, he maintains that there is parallel support for the claim that rationalist perspectives have replaced structuralist arguments in this research area.

Doug McAdam, Sidney Tarrow, and Charles Tilly synthesize approaches to the analysis of social movements and revolution, denying either the need or the utility of deciding among them. Research in this area, they maintain, requires theories that join structural and rationalist factors – political opportunity and mobilization structures – with cultural factors – framing processes. Charting a research agenda, they call for comparisons across different types of contentious actions and movements and across different political settings that take into account particular national histories. Their chapter introduces a research agenda that includes the analysis of patterns that flow over time, taking seriously the metaphor of cycles and revolutions. Here, they lead comparative politics back to the theoretically informed study of a single country. Their effort joins with other process models, displaying a mode of explanation that accounts for political phenomena without offering a single general covering law or one general causal explanation.

Peter A. Hall examines theories of the political economy of advanced industrial societies that emphasize interests (drawing on rational choice theory), ideas and values (the work of culturalists), and institutions (structural approaches). In a systematic and comprehensive survey, Hall reflects on the accomplishments of each of the research schools, noting as well the lacunae present. The essay examines the potential for integrating themes, underlining exciting developments that lie at the intersections of the schools. Noting that much recent research has concentrated on explaining cross-national differences in economic policies and performance, Hall concludes by stressing the need to return to broad and fundamental themes: the relationship between the state, seen as the custodian of a general interest, and the market, seen as a mechanism for interchange among private interests, and the consequences of this interaction for the overall distribution of well-being in society.

Joel S. Migdal defends the centrality of the state against recent attacks on its analytic importance. The analysis of the state, he maintains, is unnecessarily cut off from other political phenomena. Locating the source of the problem in the overwhelming influence of Weber on the study of the state, Migdal maintains that the various perspectives – culturalist, rationalist, and structuralist alike – have tended to isolate it as a subject of study, peering into its innards and poring over its organization in order to understand how it succeeds in gaining obedience and conformity from its population. This sort of analytic isolation of the state, he claims, has led to a mystification of its capabilities and power. Finally, Migdal develops an argument on behalf of the "limited state." He seeks to accomplish this goal by blending the largely ignored culturalist perspective with the more dominant institutionalist approach, as well as shifting the analytic focus away from the state as a freestanding organization and toward a process-oriented view of the state-in-society.

Mark I. Lichbach addresses the central problem of this volume: the interpretation and understanding of the debate among the competing research traditions that characterize contemporary comparative politics. He offers a four-part thesis on improving the state of theory in comparative politics. First, if we approach theory by believing that our field consists only of a "messy center," our

search for better theory will end almost immediately. Second, if, on the other hand, we embrace creative confrontations, which can include well-defined syntheses among the strongly defined research communities in our field – the rationalists, culturalists, and structuralists – reflexive understanding of theorists and their theories will flourish. Third, contemporary comparativists can get the most out of such a dialogue by appreciating the historical context of the development of social theory. Finally, contemporary comparativists can also gain from such a dialogue by recognizing that the approaches offer a critical commentary on the challenges of modernity which, in turn, help us appreciate the significance of rationalist, culturalist, and structuralist thought.

Alan S. Zuckerman also addresses the central problem of this volume. He does so by directing attention to the relationship between theory and the standards for explanations in comparative politics. He notes that the accepted forms of explanation – covering laws and causal accounts – display significant deficiencies, providing unreasonable standards for assessing explanations. Furthermore, Zuckerman maintains that nomological and causal explanations share an ontology that includes linear and frequently determined relationships among variables, clocklike patterns, parity in the size of cause and effect, and microprocesses as determinants of structures. Both utilize point predictions as the means for testing explanatory hypotheses. The successes of theories in comparative politics that share these conceptualizations of reality notwithstanding, argues Zuckerman, there is strong reason to view the political world as also composed of nonlinear relationships among variables, probabilistic outcomes and structures, aperiodic systems, unpredictable phenomena, chance factors, and open-ended possibilities. There is reason, therefore, to propose standards for explanation in comparative politics that accommodate these complex patterns. Zuckerman maintains that changing the standards for explanation in comparative politics allows fresh combinations of ideas to appear. Assumptions, modes and levels of analysis, and theoretical principles may be drawn from more than one research school. Process models that apply to particular cases join cross-national comparisons; complex statistical techniques join methods that assume linear relationships among variables; analyses join individual and structural variables. New theories emerge, maintains Zuckerman, and the ability to explain political phenomena advances.

THE WAY AHEAD

The rationalist, culturalist, and structuralist research traditions set the agenda in contemporary comparative politics, just as they do in the study of American politics, international politics, and social science even more generally.[4] Advancing theory in comparative politics therefore requires that we understand and assess these three research schools. Absent a focus on these approaches, symposia on the

[4]This point is documented in Lichbach's essay.

state of theory in comparative politics cannot succeed.[5] We hope that as comparativists – especially graduate students and young faculty – read *Comparative Politics: Rationality, Culture, and Structure,* they will place theoretical reflection again on their field's agenda.

We also have grander ambitions. While theoretical discussions of rules, reasons, and relations appear in the literature on social theory and the philosophy of social science, this is the first set of case studies of the rationalist–culturalist–structuralist debate to appear. Hence, we also hope that the essays in this volume guide research and theoretical reflections well beyond the boundaries of comparative politics. Our intellectual forebears in classic social theory and contemporary political science would have appreciated that *chutzpah*.

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[5]See for example the special issue of *World Politics* (October 1995).

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PART II

RESEARCH TRADITIONS IN COMPARATIVE POLITICS

2

A MODEL, A METHOD, AND A MAP: RATIONAL CHOICE IN COMPARATIVE AND HISTORICAL ANALYSIS

Margaret Levi

Throughout history, rulers have reacted to political and economic constraints by establishing a wide array of institutional arrangements for both raising revenue and stimulating economic growth (Greif et al. 1994; Kiser 1994; Levi 1988; Milgrom et al. 1990; North 1981; North and Weingast 1989). Throughout the world, villagers have traditionally owned livestock privately and land in common. The Swiss of Torbel (Ostrom 1990: 61-5) are still successful in "governing the commons,"[1] but by the 1960s the pastoral Galole Orma people of northeastern Kenya no longer were (Ensminger 1992). Unions and social democratic parties (Golden 1990; Golden 1996; Przeworski 1985; Przeworski and Sprague 1986; Wallerstein 1989), religious parties (Kalyvas 1996; Gill forthcoming), and political coalitions (Kitschelt 1989; Rogowski 1989) have had varying capacities to organize and achieve political ends over time. Political officials have also differed in their abilities to effect reforms in developing societies (Ames 1987; Bates 1983; Bates and Krueger 1993; Geddes 1994; Oi 1989; Shirk 1993).

These are a small sampling of the historical and comparative macrophenomena rational choice theorists attempt to explain. The first example illustrates institutional establishment and change. The second is a case of a system of property rights long maintained and then, in some places, abandoned. The third exemplifies variations in the capacity of organizations and parties to achieve political

[1]This phrase is, of course, borrowed from the title of Elinor Ostrom's 1990 book.

ends. Although widely different in subject matter, time, and place, all of these works do what rational choice does best: reveal how intentional and rational actors generate collective outcomes and aggregate behavior. Although the choice of each actor may be intentional and individually rational, the results to all may be unintentional and socially irrational. If it has done nothing else, rational choice has done quite a lot by laying to rest, conclusively, the myths that individual interest equals collective action or that collective action necessarily produces a collective good.[2]

The strength of rational choice in comparative and historical analysis is also evident in its capacity to spawn testable theory with clear scope conditions,[3] its ability to make sense of a correlation or a set of events by providing a plausible and compelling story that identifies the causal mechanisms linking the independent and dependent variables,[4] and its universalism that reveals generalizable implications applicable to cases beyond those under immediate investigation. Rationalists in comparative politics are committed to explanation and to generalization. This does not mean that all rational choice scholars engage in exactly the same enterprise. Few would claim that the assumption of rationality is directly testable or even observable, but there are those (e.g., Diermeier 1995; Fiorina 1995) who believe it is impossible to directly observe – let alone test – the causal pathways their formal models reveal. They tend to be proponents of Hempel's covering law approach rather than of causal explanations.[5] Others, however, claim that it is incumbent upon rational choice to reveal and evaluate causal mechanisms. They tend to believe that causal explanations might be possible after all. What unifies rationalists is not their views on causation or testability but their commitment to some form of causal inference (the term preferred by King, Keohane, and Verba 1994), universalism, and empirical social science that will produce falsifiable hypotheses.

The major task confronting comparative rationalists is how to offer explanations that compel both logically and empirically. Arguably, the source of progress in empirical social science is the coupling of theory and data in a systematic fashion. The contemporary fascination with certain kinds of theory – be it of the more formal or the more interpretive variety – has combined with the backlash against behavioralism to produce a serious neglect of facts, evidence, and data. For those who believe the task of social scientists is to develop theory and then evaluate it against data that actually can mediate between competing hypotheses, both the mathematical modeler and the Foucaultian postmodernist are maddening. Too often economists are guilty of generating a hypothesis whose "validity" they "demonstrate" with a single example that makes their point. Many postmodernists fail to appeal to any facts at all or, when they do, there is no way to falsify their claims.

Good empirical theory may not be enough, however, to convince all consumers of comparative research of the advantages of rational choice. Most rational choice scholars have experienced considerable hostility from area specialists and historians, who find rational choice accounts inadequately sensitive to the historical, political, and cultural context or who believe the findings could be discovered and stated just as well without the edifice of formal theory. Other critics doubt that rational choice has yet to produce significant empirical contributions, even in American politics (Green and Shapiro 1994).

There are also those who clearly recognize the value of certain rational choice contributions (e.g., Hall this volume; McAdam, Tarrow, and Tilly this volume) but who either believe in the superiority of another approach or argue for a synthetic methodology. This chapter adopts a stance closer to those advocating some convergence. A line in the sand remains, nonetheless. Rationalists are almost always willing to sacrifice nuance for generalizability, detail for logic, a forfeiture most other comparativists would decline.[6]

THE MODEL OF RATIONAL CHOICE: NEITHER NEOCLASSICAL ECONOMICS NOR PUBLIC CHOICE

INFLUENCES

Many scholars have made significant contributions to advances in rational choice as an empirical social science. Anthony Downs's *An Economic Theory of Democracy* (1957) made spatial modeling a key component of analyses of voting and electoral processes. In the hands of William Riker (e.g., 1962, 1987) and those directly influenced by him, spatial modeling became an invaluable tool in the investigation of the origins and maintenance of such political institutions as federalism. In *The Logic of Collective Action* (1965) Mancur Olson emphasizes strategic interaction; each individual makes her decision based on the probable decision of others. His popularization of the free rider problem to account for variation in collective action and the production of collective goods reduces to a fiction models based on the automatic translation of interests into organization. Simultaneously, it stimulates systematic investigation of the conditions under which individuals will join together to influence government or each other and the conditions under which it is even possible for government and other organizations to deliver what constituents demand. The emphasis in

[2]The first paradox is Olson's (1965) contribution and the second Arrow's (1951). More recently, Bates (1991) and Hardin (1995) make these points powerfully.

[3]For an explication of this argument, see Kiser and Hechter (1991) and Kiser (1997).

[4]Others have also made this point. See, e.g., Elster (1989 and 1993), Kalyvas (1996:15-17), Laitin (1995:6), Przeworksi and Sprague (1986:181), and Rogowski (1995:469-70).

[5]This appears to be the view advocated by Lichbach (this volume). Also, see Somers (1996) for an interesting discussion of this problem.

[6]Since Popkin's book on peasants (1979), there have been numerous works in comparative politics that used rational choice to simplify. Some of the most recent are: Gambetta 1993; Firmin-Sellers 1996; Ramseyer and Rosenbluth 1993; Tsebelis 1995; and Verdier 1994.

Douglass North's *Structure and Change in Economic History* (1981) is on the combination of strategic interaction and institutions that prohibit certain options and facilitate others. His advocacy of transaction cost theory, his advances in economic institutionalism, and his recognition of the role of relative bargaining power stimulate systematic investigation of the variation in both state action and outcomes throughout history. With *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance* (1990), North emphasizes path dependence and informal institutions, thus raising issues of historical determinacy and cultural influences on action.

The underlying model that produces these pathbreaking works derives from the neoclassical economic model in which the outcome of analytical interest is the consequence of the aggregation of the decisions of many rational individuals maximizing their egoistic interests. Rational choice theory is not, however, neoclassical economics (Bates 1988). Its attention to institutions and norms, to the richness of context, to questions of conflict and power, and, on occasion, to non-egoistic motivations differentiate it sharply from the straightforward application of economics to politics that characterized the early public choice school. Moreover, its aims are empirical and explanatory rather than normative and exhortatory. Whereas James Buchanan and Gordon Tullock (1965) use their models to attack the role of the state in the economy, the practitioners of rational choice seek to explore and understand what role the state, politics, groups, and organizations have actually played in economic and political development.

When individuals operate within the framework of the free market, the result is both personally and socially efficient – or so the neoclassical claim goes. In contrast, the institutions of politics do not necessarily lead to Pareto-optimal outcomes; the combined decisions of rational individuals often generate nonrational collective choices. This was, of course, the earlier and important finding of Kenneth Arrow (1951), whose paradox was both an explicit normative critique of majority rule democracy and an implicit demand for institutional innovation. Olson and North share with Arrow a concern with the reality of paradox and inefficiency, but their goal is more empirical: to understand when such results occur and why they do not always. For Olson, the reason that optimal or more proximately optimal outcomes are sometimes achieved rests in the provision of selective incentives. For North, the reason that we can explain structure and change rests in institutions and norms that constrain or facilitate choices, on the one hand, and that increase or decrease the transaction costs, on the other. Both North and Olson give politics an important role in economic analysis; actors with distributional agendas can influence the choices rational individuals make by altering the relative prices of the options in their choice set. For example, union officials can make it more rational for potential members to join and pay dues by controlling access to employment (Olson 1965), or rulers can create secure property rights that influence where investors place their funds (North 1981).

THE MODEL OF RATIONAL CHOICE

Empirical rational choice models now take for granted the contributions of Arrow, Downs, Riker, Olson, and North. Their emphasis is on rational and strategic individuals who make choices within constraints to obtain their desired ends, whose decisions rest on their assessment of the probable actions of others, and whose personal outcomes depend on what others do. The approach is methodologically individualist, yet its focus is not on individual choice but on the aggregation of individual choices. Rational choice is, as Lichbach (this volume) notes, a model that offers the microfoundations of macroprocesses and events. It does this by means of an equilibrium analysis in which actors respond to each others' decisions until each is at a position from which no improvement is possible. Sometimes, of course, there is no such position, and the result is either cycling or chaos. However, general equilibrium analysis permits the investigator to model and explain this outcome as well as more static outcomes. Keys to the model, then, are the assumption of rationality, the forms of constraint, the nature of the strategic interaction, and the search for an equilibrium solution.

Several applications of rational choice analysis will help in the explication of the essential elements of the model. These illustrations and most of the others referred to in this chapter tend to reflect the influence of Olson and North more than that of Arrow, Downs, Riker, or Buchanan and Tullock. Although there is considerable comparative work done by rationalists using spatial models and other such tools, the emphasis here is on research that raises issues of collective action and institutional arrangements.

The first application draws from Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons* (1990) in which she compares several small communities reliant on inland fisheries. Some have been more successful than others in protecting their common pool resources, but all have escaped the imposition of a solution by centralized government. The second draws from my research on revenue production and taxation (Levi 1988) and on war and conscription (Levi 1997), which accounts for variation in government success in introducing compulsory contributions. The first example is a problem of cooperation among those who draw their livelihood from the common pool resource. The second is a problem of cooperation between government actors and citizens.

Both analyses assume that actors are making rational decisions in situations of uncertainty. They are assessing the expected costs and benefits and acting consistently with their preferences. They vary in their discount rates (how much they care about the future) and in their capacities to assess the risks they face. Thus, the appropriators of resources may or may not care about the long-term sustainability of the fishery, and they may or may not have good knowledge about how many fish there are and what natural disasters might befall them. They are uncertain about the effects of actions they and others take; they cannot even be absolutely certain about when others from within or outside their community will overfish. To Ostrom (1990: 34), this means that "the only reason-

able assumption about the calculation process employed is that appropriators engage in a considerable amount of trial-and-error learning." In the military service case, many of the men likely to be conscripted probably had very high discount rates; they were extremely young, willing to take high risks, and probably believed in their invulnerability. Nonetheless, they lacked hard information on how long or how bloody the war would be or what traumas it might cause them over time. They were, however, facing a set of decisions that, most likely, were extraordinary rather than the recurring problems faced by the appropriators of fish or other natural resources. Thus, they could not use trial and error to develop their best course of action; rather they had to seek guidance from the past, their peers, their governments, or whatever other source they felt could offer good guidance.

The assumption of rationality is the subject of much of the criticism of rational choice. Even among the practitioners, there are the serious issues of what it means to be rational and of how much it matters whether individuals are actually rational or not.[7] However, the rationality assumption most useful for comparative research is a fairly thin variant in which individuals act consistently in relation to their preferences. The trick is in defining the preferences in general, ex ante to a particular application. In many instances, this is not difficult, requiring only a fairly straightforward observation of what is of principal concern to the class of actors under consideration. For example, if they are people buying and selling, maximizing wealth seems a reasonable assumption. If they are peasants in risky environments, maximizing security has some appeal. In the case of government actors, the presumption is that they want to stay in power. The utility functions of citizens are trickier to clarify given the range of interests citizens might have; there is nothing comparable to the economics dictum of getting the most for the least for one's money in the marketplace. Thus, any maximand will lead to hypotheses that can account for a smaller part of the variation in citizen behavior than in politician or economic consumer behavior.

Rational choice is not bound by the utility or wealth-maximizing assumptions that characterize economics. Rational choice does not even require the assumption that individuals are self-interested. However, the addition of non-egoistic considerations or motivational norms – such as the community standards Ostrom stresses or the fairness principles I stress – does increase the complexity and difficulty of the analysis. The advantage of assuming utility-maximization is that it is both parsimonious and extremely general, but it can also produce tautology: Whatever people do becomes a "revealed preference." The advantage of

[7]On the meanings of rationality, Elster's work (e.g., 1979, 1983a, 1983b, 1989, 1993) provides some of the most important considerations. On the importance of the validity of the rationality assumption, see Plott (1990) reporting on experiments in which the market aggregates the decisions of seemingly nonrational individuals into exactly the outcomes one would predict from a rational choice assumption. There is, of course, also the "as if" argument made famous by Milton Friedman.

the more specific wealth-maximizing assumption is that it produces observable implications but with a narrow conception of human motivation. The advantage of an assumption in which actors consider net payoffs that include both material and ethical factors is that it may better approximate reality albeit at the sacrifice of a neater and more parsimonious model. Nonetheless, as the maximand more closely approximates reality, the more reality it should capture.

The real action in the model does not, however, come from the internal considerations of the actor but from the constraints on her behavior. Thus, Ostrom (1990: 38), following Popper (1967), "... accepts Popper's methodological advice to emphasize the way we describe the situations in which individuals find themselves so that we can use observable variables to reject our theories, rather than internal, in-the-mind, subjective variables, which are far more difficult to measure."

Constraints have two major sources. The first, derived straightforwardly from neoclassical economics, is scarcity; individuals maximize within the confines of their available resources. An individual without money cannot make the investments that would make her richer, and an individual who lacks the vote cannot directly influence who is in government, no matter how much it might be in her interest to elect a certain party.

The other important constraints are institutional and organizational. Institutions are sets of rules (and sanctions) that structure social interactions and whose existence and applicability are commonly known within the relevant community.[8] Institutions, so defined, structure the individual choices of strategic actors so as to produce equilibrium outcomes, that is outcomes that no one has an incentive to alter. In game theory, they are the rules of the game that structure the interactions among players. In legislatures they are the rules that structure the order of votes, the method of aggregation of votes, and the like. An operational definition developed by Greif (forthcoming: 7) is the "technologically determined constraints on behavior which are self-enforcing."[9] All institutions are embodiments of rules, all have a legalistic aspect, and all possess enforcement mechanisms. They are considered political institutions when the state enforces the rules, social institutions when enforcement is through mechanisms such as approval and shunning, and economic institutions when enforcement is by means of profit and loss.[10]

[8]Of course, institutions can also facilitate action. However, the emphasis in this section is on their role in constraining choice.

[9]Organizations are "groups of individuals bound by some common purpose to achieve objectives" (North 1990: 5) or, what is essentially the same thing, "collective actors who might be subject to institutional constraint" (Knight 1992). Institutions and organization are closely intertwined, and often the same term is used to describe a particular example of both, e.g., firm, Congress, family. The legal institution of the firm is not exactly the same as the actual shareholders, managers, and employees who people the firm. Nor are the informal societal rules that guide family behavior in complete identity with the choices made by the actual family. The institution regulates behavior but cannot totally determine it. The organization, that is the individuals whose fates are tightly interwoven by an overarching common purpose, may not always be regulated.

[10]Michael Lipsky helped me to perceive this distinction.

Organizations – and expectations – are "institutional components," which are not determined technologically (Greif forthcoming: 7). Whether or not institutions and organizations are as distinct as North and Knight both argue,[11] organizations not only introduce a new player into the interaction, they can also affect what information and payoffs are available to the relevant actors. For example, in the study of CPRs (common pool resources), the firm and state are organizations that operate with and within the institutional framework of the property rights system. In my recent research within the institutions of democratic decision making, governments, political parties, and interest groups interact with each other in order to design military service policies.

(3) Strategic action is the third pillar of the rational choice model. In the powerful price theory of neoclassical economics, the consumer lets the market transform the choices of others into a price and range of products that form the basis of her choice. The actor does not have to consider what others are going to do before making her choice. In most political and social situations, however, an evaluation of the behavior of other relevant actors comes prior to the choice. The decision whether to free ride, overfish, or pasture too many cows depends, at least in part, on an assessment of what others are likely to do. The vote of a legislator, the compliance of a citizen with government, the willingness to engage in collective action or even rebellion are all acts that depend on beliefs about the likely actions of others. A young man is likely to volunteer for military service if he believes he is going to be one of very few soldiers on the front lines, and an assessment that too many others will free ride may transform an opponent of conscription to a supporter. The outcome for all depends on the choice of each. In order to make a choice in a context of strategic interaction, each decision maker has to have expectations about the other players. For most purposes, the decision maker simply assumes common knowledge of rationality, that is, the decision maker assumes that other decision makers are also instrumentally rational and will thus make the same inferences from the same information.[12]

Theoretical work on strategic action, particularly in its game theoretic forms, has contributed to unraveling several puzzles in comparative politics. For example, Michael Taylor (1987 [1976]) and, later, Robert Axelrod (1984), make a strong case for the importance of the tit-for-tat strategy in iterated prisoner dilemma situations that meet certain clearly specified, and observable, criteria; by this means they extend the circumstances under which it is instrumentally rational to cooperate. Taylor labels this conditional cooperation and uses the concept to help explain both the origin of the state (1987 [1976], 1982) and the location of revolutionary action (1988; see also Lichbach 1995). Russell Hardin stresses the advantages of successful coordination in solving a variety of collective action problems (1982, 1990) as well as unsuccessful coordination in forestalling

[11]They claim that institutions are the rules of the game and organizations the players and their strategies.

[12]For a more complete explication of this assumption, see Hargreaves Heap and Varoufakis (1995: 23-8).

violent conflicts (1995). Although both Taylor and Hardin are primarily theorists, their findings have proved extremely useful for those engaged in original empirical research. Ostrom, for example, has to consider the hypotheses generated by this work in accounting for the variation in choices made by the actors she studies. I developed the concept of quasivoluntary compliance (1988) and, more recently, contingent consent (1997) to capture the fact that many citizens act reciprocally, complying if many others are and withdrawing compliance when there are expectations or evidence that they are among the few complying.

(4) The final component of the model is its assumption of equilibrium. To reiterate: This is not an assumption that all behavior is static, or even that all interactions among rational individuals produce an equilibrium. Indeed, Arrow's paradox and other important findings in rational choice rest on the opposite finding. Nor are all equilibria efficient. The research on collective action problems is an explicit recognition of the conditions under which the logic of rational action is likely to produce suboptimal equilibria and of the kinds of arrangements that make it more likely for rational individuals to produce more optimal equilibria. Ostrom points to the herders of Torbel, Switzerland and the *zanjera* irrigation systems of the Philippines as examples of long-enduring CPRs, but there are also groups – she points to cases in Sri Lanka, Turkey, and California – who have trouble finding and sustaining solutions to their CPR problems. In my work, volunteering proved an inefficient equilibrium, at least from the point of view of the military during a large-scale war, but altering that equilibrium took substantial political effort by legislators and other government officials who shared the military's view. Greif (forthcoming) offers numerous examples of institutional arrangements that, although promoting commerce, were not necessarily the most efficient means for doing so.

THE TRADITIONAL METHOD OF RATIONAL CHOICE

Rational choice theory in comparative and historical analysis is a model that has only recently begun to be explicit and self-conscious about its method, that is, what distinguishes it from neoclassical economics, what formalization can and cannot do, and how to bring in narrative material appropriately and systematically. One thing is clear: The power of rational choice lies in its parsimony and testability. Thus, although it is essential that analysts more competently address "the real world," this should not be done at too great a sacrifice of analytical rigor. This is the difficult path many are now trying to walk.

COMPARATIVE STATICS

The presumption of equilibria permits the analyst to consider what would disrupt a particular equilibrium. Recall that in an equilibrium, no one has an incentive to change her choice. However, it is obvious that choices change reg-

ularly and constantly, whether they be in the realm of consumer, political, or social decision making. To understand these changes requires a set of hypotheses concerning what exogenous shocks or alterations in the independent variables will have what effects on the actions of the individuals under study. Ostrom (1990) relies on comparative statics when she is able to identify the factors, such as population pressures or state intervention, that undermine a traditional set of arrangements for protecting common pool resources. In a very different context, Levi (1988) shows that, given the assumption that a ruler maximizes revenue to the state, the ruler will change the form of taxes and tax collection with changes in the transaction costs of collecting and enforcing certain kinds of taxes, the relative bargaining power of those likely to be taxed, and the expenditure requirements of the ruler. Moreover, particular outcomes should be predictable, i.e., there will be no income tax until the costs of assessing and collecting income are sufficiently low to make it pay for the ruler.

PATH DEPENDENCE

To capture the critical moments and actions of the particular case also requires an understanding of the constraints that derive from past actions. The sequence in which events occur is causally important, and events in the distant past can initiate particular chains of causation that have effects in the present.

Path dependence does not simply mean that "history matters." This is both true and trivial. Path dependence has to mean, if it is to mean anything, that once a country or region has started down a track, the costs of reversal are very high. There will be other choice points, but the entrenchments of certain institutional arrangements obstruct an easy reversal of the initial choice. Perhaps the better metaphor is a tree, rather than a path.[13] From the same trunk, there are many different branches and smaller branches. Although it is possible to turn around or to clamber from one to the other – and essential if the chosen branch dies – the branch on which a climber begins is the one she tends to follow.

The notion of path dependence originated to explain the persistence of socially suboptimal technologies, such as the QWERTY typewriter. This happens, according to Paul David, under three necessary conditions: "strong technical interrelatedness, scale economies, and irreversibilities due to learning and habituation (1985: 336)." W. Brian Arthur (1989) adds a fourth condition: increasing returns within a decentralized and laissez-faire market. The application of path dependence to social arrangements, such as horizontal or vertical linkages, requires specification of the political, economic, and social factors that are most analogous to David's and Arthur's conditions. The model of path dependence suggests that not only major technological changes but also major regime changes would alter other interconnected features of the society.

[13]This is what William Sewell, Jr. argued to me.

There have actually been few successful attempts at applying the concept of path dependence in comparative politics. Putnam (1993), following North (1990), turned path dependence into an overly deterministic concept in which events of the fourteenth century produced – it seems, inexorably – the "virtuous cycle" of civic engagement in Northern Italy and its "vicious cycle" of distrust in Southern Italy.[14] More compelling are path dependent explanations of party formation in Europe provided by Kitschelt (1989, 1994) and Kalyvas (1996), who do not use the concept explicitly.

One possible avenue is provided by Avner Greif (1996) in his research on the Commercial Revolution. Greif identifies various forms of expectations that coordinate action and, in some instances, give rise to organizations that then influence future economic development. The expectations arise out of the complex of economic, social, political and cultural, as well as technological, features of a society. The existence of a coordination point in itself makes change difficult since it requires considerable effort to locate and then move enough others to a different coordination point (see, e.g., Hardin 1995). When organization develops, the path is even more firmly established, for organization tends to bring with it vested interests who will choose to maintain a path even when it is not optimal.

ANALYTIC NARRATIVES

As comparative and historical rational choice develops, it has increasingly become a form of institutional analysis. Institutions clearly enter the model as constraints, but they also play critical roles in reducing the individual's information costs and in providing focal points for action. The demands of applying game theory to empirical research have only enhanced the institutional features of the model. There are two important problems posed by game theory that institutions help resolve. First, there is the unreasonably high calculative capacity assumed of the decision makers. Second, there is the folk theorem, the finding that in a majority of conceivable multiperson interactions, the outcome is indeterminate. At first, the recognition of these problems produced skepticism about the relevance of game theory to empirical analysis (see, e.g., Hechter 1990, 1992), but it simultaneously produced useful evaluations of "the games real actors play" (Scharpf 1997).

Herbert Simon won the Nobel prize for recognizing the demands rationality places on the calculative capacity of the decision maker. Strategic action increases the requirements, for individuals must figure out what others are likely to do in order to devise their own best strategy. The assumption of common knowledge among actors about each other assumes as given a considerable amount of information and fails to reckon the costs of acquiring such information. However, for many of the actors and in many of the situations of

[14]For critiques of Putnam's usage see Levi (1996) and Sabetti (1996).

interest to comparativists, institutions do much of the work of calculation and information provision. They have this effect because they convey expectations both about sanctions and about the behavior of others. This information then enables each actor to make an informed strategy choice.[15] For example, the institution of the income tax informs potential taxpayers of the nature and probability of punishments for personal evasion, but it also lets them know that most others cannot or are unlikely to free ride. The information has a deterrence role and, at the same time, encourages reciprocity as a motivation for payment (Levi 1988).

At the heart of current empirical rational choice is the folk theorem. In the more technical language of economics, the folk theorem asserts that there are often multiple equilibria in games in which numerous individuals engage in repeated play. Once again, however, institutions save the day by providing focal points[16] and other means for coordinating action. Some of the most interesting explorations of the way institutions produce relatively stable equilibria are in economic history, most notably in papers by North and Weingast (1989; also see their paper with Milgrom 1990) and Greif (1989; 1993; 1994a; 1994b; 1996; with Milgrom and Weingast, 1994). This research investigates the creation of self-enforcing institutions, often nonstate institutions, that make possible credible commitments between actors and thus expand exchange and reduce conflict.

Moving toward an even more complicated consideration of situations, institutions, and focal points makes it harder to use traditional rational choice methods, however. Comparative statics is still at the heart of research design, but to generate satisfying hypotheses and to test them requires a far more detailed knowledge of the case than was previously expected of rational choice scholars. This assessment led to the development of what a set of collaborators (Robert Bates, Avner Greif, Margaret Levi, Jean-Laurent Rosenthal, and Barry Weingast) have come to label analytic narrative (in process).[17] This approach eliminates many of the dichotomies by which both proponents and critics distinguished rational choice from other enterprises. At the same time, it makes certain tensions within rational choice the source of creativity.

An analytic narrative presumes that the outcome or event to be explained derives from the aggregation of individual choices. The analytic narrative rests on the behavioral postulates of rational choice: Individuals are the decision makers, they are rational in the sense that they act consistently on their preferences and their choices are meant to serve their ends, they are strategic in that the choice of each is affected by the likely choices of others, and the variation in choice is a function of the constraints on the actors. An analytic narrative requires the researcher to clearly identify the key actors, their strategic considerations, and the relevant technological, social, political, or economic constraints, and this specification depends on a detailed knowledge of the case.

Once the case has been mastered sufficiently to identify the key actors, their strategies, and their constraints, then it is possible to begin the process of developing explanations and testing hypotheses. Thus, the next step is to derive a specific model that indicates the links between independent and dependent variables and leads to an account of the causal mechanisms. The model can take the form of an expected utility equation, as in Mancur Olson's work, or it can derive from the logic of game theory, as in David Laitin's recent work (1992, 1995). The game theoretic approach has several advantages, for it allows one to specify not only the comparative statics and path dependence, equally available from general equilibrium theory, but also the behavior off the equilibrium path.

[15]This definition is consistent with the claim of North (1990) and others that institutions are rules that regulate recurrent interactions and, thus, reduce the uncertainty that arises from otherwise unpredictable behavior.

[16]The idea of focal points derives from Schelling (1978), of course.

[17]This is not, however, the only such effort. Also see Fritz Scharpf (1997). Sociologists have also given considerable attention to the issue of narratives and how to make them more analytical. See, for example, Abell (1987) and Kiser (1997).

WHAT'S OFF THE EQUILIBRIUM PATH, OR THE PROBLEM OF COUNTERFACTUALS[18]

In a famous essay on "Objective Possibility and Adequate Causation in Historical Explanation," Max Weber argued for the explicit and systematic use of counterfactuals as aspects of the empirical world that are contrary to fact but not to logical or "objective" possibility (1949 [1905]). Counterfactuals are indispensable in most comparative and historical work, since the possible causal factors are so numerous and interrelated and since the number of similar cases is seldom sufficient. However, Weber's efforts to formulate some general principles for evaluating the plausibility of "objective possibility" lack adequate theoretical grounds for justifying and circumscribing his counterfactual assumptions (Elster 1978: 180).

Until recently (Fearon 1991, 1996; Tetlock and Belkin 1996), there has been little effort to systematically evaluate the role counterfactuals do play and can play in social scientific analyses. Nor, until recently, has there been much success in giving counterfactual assumptions theoretical justification. However, game theory does provide a means to do just that. It outlines the range of sequential choices available to the actors. To understand why one of the paths becomes the equilibrium path, it is necessary to understand why the actors did not follow other possible paths (see, especially, Weingast 1996, Bueno de Mesquita 1996). Thus, the model generates testable hypotheses about: (1) what the beliefs of the actors had to be and what they could not have been; and (2) what the critical junctures were in the decision-making process.

[18]This discussion largely derives from Kiser and Levi (1996), who consider the role counterfactuals play in the analysis of revolution.

WHAT MATTERS IN THE PAST AND WHAT DOES NOT

While it is certainly the case that good theory often elaborates contingencies or points to the path where a different action or event may have changed the outcome, it is also the case that theory should delimit the possibilities. There is a tension in the work of most structuralists who, on the one hand, tend to make their theory extremely deterministic and, on the other hand, insist on conjunctural analysis that opens up too wide a range of possibilities. Here analytic narrative offers an important alternative approach. It facilitates both causal inference and the revelation of critical junctures or choice points. At its most successful, it can offer an account of why one path and not another is followed and then maintained. However, formal models only make sense of a revolutionary sequence of events when they can illuminate and interrogate the actual details of the case.

PROBLEM AND CASE SELECTION

Geddes (1997) offers a strong set of claims about what rational choice, and indeed any good empirical analysis, might accomplish and what it cannot. She argues against those who set their caps too high, who try to account for all revolutions or all developments; they invariably, in her view, build sand castles subject to the relentless shifts in paradigms. Rather, she argues for more modest, albeit still ambitious, projects. In her own case (1994), this involved identifying the links between electoral institutions and the kinds and timing of reform. If, as Elster (1989: 7) and Taylor (1988) claim, the best explanations are "fine-grained," this is a further impetus for defining questions in a way that enables one to spell out the direct relationship between one variable and another.

In general, Geddes has been proved right. The work that best succeeds in meeting social scientific criteria of evidence and falsifiability, the work that can be used as a solid building block rather than a sand castle, is work that precisely models a set of causal mechanisms and clearly delimits their domain of operation. Scholars can still ask big questions, but only certain kinds of big questions. For example, Rosenthal (1992) tells us a considerable amount about the relationship between the state, property rights, and economic development by means of a detailed investigation of sewage and drainage in postrevolutionary France. Bates and Lien (1985), Levi (1988), and Kiser (1994) contribute to the theory of the state and arguments about political change through studies of seemingly arcane government tax collection policies.

The kinds of problems chosen combine with the commitment to analytic narratives to produce two very different bases for case selection. The first is substantive; there is a time- and place-specific puzzle that one wishes to investigate. Thus, Barry Weingast (in his contribution to Bates, Greif, et al. in progress) is perplexed by the accounts he has read of the precipitants to the United States Civil War, and Robert Bates (1997) is eager to understand why coffee producers organize as they do. In these instances, the puzzle is embedded in a particular

case, which is obviously what is to be studied. For those concerned with unraveling a theory-driven puzzle, such as what accounts for the variation in distributional coalitions (Olson 1981), free riding (Hechter 1987), state forms (Levi 1988), or economic growth (Greif 1994b), the basis of case selection is quite different. It requires investigating a range of cases that might reveal the mechanisms at work. Thus, I considered the rise and decline of tax farming in ancient Rome, the introduction of the income tax in 1799 in England, and the problems of tax evasion and avoidance in 1980s Australia as a means of getting at different features of the theory of predatory rule.

A MAP FOR THE FUTURE OF EMPIRICAL RATIONAL CHOICE: INADEQUATELY EXPLORED TERRAIN

Rational choice cannot explain everything, nor does it unravel all puzzles equally well, but it can illuminate and advance the explanation of a wide range of phenomena in a large variety of countries and time periods. There are, however, other interesting problems, seemingly more susceptible to microanalysis but apparently harder to fathom with the tools of rational choice. The most striking are why so many people vote and why we witness so many instances of large-scale collective actions in the form of protests and revolutions.

Comparative and historical researchers who wish to combine a nuanced understanding of the complexity of a particular (often unique) situation or set of events with a general theoretical understanding demand more of rational choice than it has so far delivered. First, neoclassical economics and its increasing mathematization and formalization is powerful and parsimonious, but it tends to rely on stylized facts rather than on the observations and details that enrich both the narrative and our confidence that we have explained an actual occurrence. Second, even when a rational choice analysis offers a logical story consistent with the facts, this hardly constitutes a validation of the explanation. Third, the presumption that changes in behavior reflect changes in relative prices, that is the emphasis on tangible incentives, fails to capture some of the most interesting behavior, such as large-scale collective actions or cooperation within firms or with government. Fourth, there is the question of the extent to which the findings of rational choice can be used to inform not only our understanding but also our capacity to improve the world in which we live.

The first problem is clearly the most tractable. Analytic narrative is a label that applies to a growing number of comparative rationalists, and it has long fit some of the best work in economic history. The others are more difficult.

FALSIFICATION

Analytic narrative does not in itself eliminate all competing accounts. It provides a means to tell a "compelling tale" (Przeworski and Sprague 1986: 181), but

there might be other, equally compelling tales. At the least, what makes a tale compelling is that the causal mechanisms it identifies are plausible. The credibility of these mechanisms is enhanced significantly by demonstrating their generalizability to other cases. In the best of all possible worlds, this means applying the explanatory model to other, out of sample, cases. There is the occasional scholar who takes this maxim seriously enough to apply it. Few, however, know enough about cases other than their own to adequately analyze other cases. More often, the explanation is thrown into the marketplace of ideas where, if it is compelling enough, others attempt to use it, either to give it additional support or to disconfirm it.

Another means of subjecting the findings to the norms of falsification is through demonstration that another methodology altogether produces the same results. Survey and experimental evidence, as well as mathematical proofs of formal theorems, add weight to the findings of case studies. If the mechanisms identified in the case studies are valid, they should hold up elsewhere. Triangulation is one of the buzzwords of the day, but although many scholars will appeal to support provided by other forms of research, few actually investigate their problems with a variety of methods.[19]

Findings from elsewhere are not only an additional source of falsification; they may also be important in revealing mechanisms worth exploring in the field. Some of the recent work on trust reflects such an effort.[20]

RECONSIDERING THE BEHAVIORAL ASSUMPTION

The third problem, the narrow behavioral assumption of most rational choice analysis, is more difficult to overcome. North certainly acknowledges this problem, especially in his more recent work (1990; with Denzau 1994) and has consequently begun to explore the role of culture, norms, mental models, and other ideational and cognitive factors in decision making. John Ferejohn (1991) offers an alternative approach; he advocates supplementing the analysis generated by rational choice with an analysis generated by an interpretive approach as a means to offer a more complete explanation.

My own recent work (1991; 1997) reflects an effort to model actors as both rational and ethical beings. Although rational choice models do not necessarily assume that individuals are selfish, many rationalists have in fact made precisely that assumption or have failed to adequately consider the role that ethical concerns, such as fairness, play in decision making. Rational choice has been very successful in accounting for why so many people fail to vote, contribute, or participate in various forms of collective action. It is less successful in explaining why they engage in such behaviors when they do. To put this another way, the model predicts more free riders than there often are. It is not enough, however, to add ethical ends to the preference function; this produces tautology, not explanation, and certainly not testable hypotheses. Rather, the aim must be to specify the conditions under which more instrumental motivations are triggered, more ethical considerations dominate, and when, as I suspect is true in many cases, individuals are willing to act ethically even if it means bearing some tangible costs.

[19]Elinor Ostrom stands out in this regard, but there are beginning to be others. For example, Shane Fricks is writing a Ph.D. dissertation that combines experiments, case studies, and game theory; Toshio Yamagishi increasingly combines surveys and experiments.

[20]A Russell Sage Foundation project on "The Construction and Maintenance of Trust," coordinated by Karen Cook, Russell Hardin, and Margaret Levi, is holding workshops and beginning to produce papers and books that demonstrate this tendency.

The models that flow from an assumption of rational but ethical actors will be less parsimonious than those that flow from the simpler assumption of narrow self-interest. In many instances, the more parsimonious model may be all that is necessary. However, where there are large-scale collective actions and ideologically driven decisions to change institutions, then a more complex model may be both necessary and right.

Such an approach may have a moral as well as empirical advantage: If, as some have argued and as some experiments seem to bear out (Frank 1987), the emphasis on instrumental rationality influences how people act, then a model that also stresses the norm of ethical rationality may be superior. There is, however, always the danger of morality becoming the grounds for disregarding the interests or denigrating the moral positions of others, a danger that a focus on self-interest often avoids (Hardin 1995).

FROM EMPIRICAL TO NORMATIVE

The breakdown of communism and the recurring problems of poverty, unemployment, and ethnic conflict, even in the so-called developed world, produce a demand for theory that guides as well as informs, arguments that meet our normative as well as empirical requirements. The rational choice approach, properly understood and undertaken, offers empirically grounded theoretical work that can account for our current arrangements and suggest possible alternatives. This is because rational choice, properly understood and properly undertaken, rests on an increasingly realistic psychology of individual action and interaction, an institutional framework that accounts for what constrains and facilitates human behavior, and a powerful model of the aggregation of individual choices.

Social science is an empirical science whose central aim should be explanation. Explanations are but scholastic exercises unless they can be translated into understanding that aids in improving political, economic, and social life generally. To translate first-rate and basic social science into practical guidelines is not such an easy undertaking, and perhaps the best we, as social scientists, can do is clarify where our scholarly research might inform political decision making.

Some rational choice work is immediately appropriable. For example, Olson's *Logic of Collective Action* clearly resonated with community organizing and union building efforts. Indeed, when I read the book as an undergraduate, I

thought Olson was an advisor to Saul Alinsky, the famed community organizer and author of *Reveille for Radicals.* Another example of theoretically informed arguments with clear policy implications is Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons.*

The current interest in the new rational choice institutionalism is equally useful but not so quickly appropriable. Douglass North tells stories of disappointing those who ask him for advice about institutional designs meant to speed up growth and democracy in Eastern Europe and elsewhere; he argues that it takes a long time to build strong informal institutions, the necessary prerequisite for political and economic development. Recent work on federalism is prescriptive, as are the growing bodies of literature on trust and compliance.

There is yet another group of scholars who are fundamentally concerned about how to produce institutions that achieve fair, equitable, and just outcomes and who use explanations derived from rationalist empirical research as data in their arguments. Jack Knight (1992) and Brian Barry (1995) count among these although they do not themselves do the empirical work. Others, e.g., Frohlich and Oppenheimer (1992) and Rothstein (1992; forthcoming) do.[21]

CONCLUSION

Empirical rational choice in comparative analysis is in its relative infancy. It is still in the process of making the transition from analytics to analytic narrative. Even so, it has become one of the leading paradigms in the field and produced some major and influential work on a range of subjects, places, and periods. Although the divide between rationalists and many of those in this volume may be shrinking as rationalists become more concerned with context and nonrationalists recognize collective action problems, voting cycles, and other insights from rational choice, the divide remains nonetheless. Structuralists and rationalists are in the same conversation, but they persist in very different views of the origins and effects of institutions and preferences. Many rationalists are taking on board the concerns of culturalists with providing a more complete account of preferences and strategies, but they continue to disagree on the uses of those accounts. What divides rationalists from culturalists and structuralists is not method in the sense of mathematics versus statistics, fieldwork, observation, and archival research; there are many rationalists who rely on precisely these tools. What divides them is method in the sense of how to construct theory, organize research findings, and address the issues of falsifiability and plausibility.

Rational choice will continue to have its serious detractors in comparative politics. It simplifies the world and human psychology more than suits the tastes of many comparativists, especially those committed to area studies or interpretivist explanations. Its positivist ethic may be unpalatable to postmodernists and

[21]Rothstein is not a rational choice scholar per se, although he uses some rational choice theory in his work.

others. The very commitment of rationalists to scientific progress by means of fact-finding, testability, and partial universalism will remain repugnant to some critics and an impossible goal to others. Rationalists must continue to refine and clarify their models so as to increase their explanatory power, and they must find more satisfying means for arbitrating among competing accounts. These are the tasks incumbent on all comparative social scientists committed to explanation. Continued competition among paradigms may improve our ability to accomplish such tasks. The argument of this chapter has been more modest, however: The confrontation between deductively derived models and empirical research has already contributed to better rational choice models and explanations and holds the promise of even better theory.

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3

CULTURE AND IDENTITY IN COMPARATIVE POLITICAL ANALYSIS*

Marc Howard Ross

INTRODUCTION

In this essay I argue that two distinct, but not unrelated, features of culture are relevant to comparative politics. First, culture is a system of meaning that people use to manage their daily worlds, large and small; second, culture is the basis of social and political identity that affects how people line up and how they act on a wide range of matters. Culture is a framework for organizing the world, for locating the self and others in it, for making sense of the actions and interpreting motives of others, for grounding an analysis of interests, for linking collective identities to political action, and for motivating people and groups toward some actions and away from others. At the same time, two caveats are in order: One is that to be useful culture cannot be defined so broadly as to include all behaviors, beliefs, institutions – in short, any domain of life – although it is appropriate to consider the cultural dimensions of specific domains; two, the effects of culture on collective action and political life are generally indirect, and to fully appreciate the role of culture in political life, it is necessary to inquire how the impact of culture interacts with interests and institutions.

It should not be surprising that cultural analyses in comparative politics take many forms, for unlike rational choice theory, cultural approaches are less clear about exactly what domains of politics to examine, and there is even less of a consensus concerning the methods and tools to employ.[1] Lichbach (this volume) distinguishes between subjective and intersubjective views of culture; the subjective emphasizes how individuals internalize individual values and attitudes that become the object of study, while the intersubjective focuses on the shared meanings and identities that constitute the symbolic, expressive, and interpretive part of social life. I argue here for the merits of a postmodern intersubjective understanding of culture (with attention to subjective elements). This strong view of culture is completely compatible with the belief that comparison is central to the social science enterprise (while not denying its complexities), although this is not the position some radical interpretivists hold. In making this argument here, an important task is to situate important or exemplary works in the field in terms of crucial questions that cultural approaches to politics address. However, this essay is not a review article, and there are many additional studies that would be included if reviewing the field were my goal.

This essay offers an opportunity to emphasize (even advocate) what an intersubjective cultural approach can contribute to comparative polities. In contrast to rational choice approaches, which are well entrenched in the discipline, and institutional approaches, which have dominated the field in one form or another since its inception, cultural contributions to political analysis are relatively rare and far less developed. Few graduate students take culture very seriously, and if one peruses the annual list of dissertations in comparative politics over several years, it is difficult to place cultural analyses in the trinity of comparative politics, as the editors of this volume have done.

It is not hard to identify the reasons why studies that give culture a central role are rare in comparative politics. Most basically, culture is not a concept with which most political scientists are comfortable. For many, culture complicates issues of evidence, transforming hopes of rigorous analysis into "just so" accounts that fail to meet widely held notions of scientific explanation. Culture violates canons of methodological individualism while raising serious unit of analysis problems for which there are no easy answers. Culture to many, neo-Marxists and non-Marxists alike, seems like an epiphenomenon offering a discourse for political mobilization and demand-making while masking more serious differences dividing groups and individuals. Finally, employing the concept of culture puts political scientists into a series of controversies over which proponents of cultural analysis in anthropology themselves are deeply divided.[2] Each of these objections is more or less addressed in this essay, and while I do not argue that they are unimportant, I do not view them as sufficiently damaging to warrant throwing the baby out with the bath water.

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[1]It is possible to identify differences within culturalist approaches to politics in terms of methods, levels of analysis, substantive questions, and willingness to compare and generalize across cases. In this essay, other than distinguishing between what I call weak and strong cultural understandings, I emphasize what I view as the useful core of the approach much more than differences within it.

[2]Among the issues that divide anthropologists are relativism, the importance of searching for generalizations, the possibility of comparison, and the role of psychological mechanisms in cultural explanations.

Cultural analysis of politics takes seriously the postmodern critique of behavioral political analyses and seeks to offer contextually rich intersubjective accounts of politics that emphasize how political actors understand social and political action (Merelman 1991). In cultural analyses, for example, interests are contextually and intersubjectively defined, and the strategies used to pursue them are understood to be context-dependent. Central to cultural analysis is the concept of interpretation. The interpretations of particular political significance are built from the accounts – stories if one prefers – of groups and individuals striving to make sense of their social and political worlds, and I use the term to refer both to the shared intersubjective meanings of actors[3] and to the explicit efforts of social science observers to understand these meanings and to present them to others (Taylor, 1985). Shared interpretations of actors – worldviews – are important in any cultural analysis as they offer an important methodological tool, along with an examination of rituals and symbols, for examining both systems of meaning and the structure and intensity of political identity.

This essay has four parts. The first discusses five contributions that the concept of culture defined as a system of meaning and identity makes to comparative political analysis: culture frames the context in which politics occurs; culture links individual and collective identities; culture defines the boundaries between groups and organizes actions within and between them; culture provides a framework for interpreting the actions and motives of others; and culture provides resources for political organization and motivation. The second part examines five central themes (some might say approaches) in cultural analyses of politics: culture and personality studies; the civic culture tradition; culture and political process (an approach that originated in anthropology); political ritual; and culture and political violence. Third, I identify five critiques of cultural studies of politics: unit of analysis issues; the problem of within-culture variation; the difficulty of distinguishing culture from social or political organization; the static nature of culture and explaining political change; and the need to identify underlying mechanisms that suggest "how culture works." The fourth section examines the role of interpretation in cultural analysis as an effort to link the contextually rich political details found in particular political settings (be they small communities or countries) to general domains of political life such as authority, community, and conflict. I discuss the concept of psychocultural interpretations and their methodological relevance in the comparative study of culture and politics for understanding processes such as ethnic and national identity construction. I conclude that culture is too often ignored as a domain of political life and that cultural analyses can enrich the way we conceptualize areas such as political economy, social movements, and political institutions in a number of useful ways, often complementing the insights derived from interest and institutional approaches.

[3]Taylor uses the term "common reference world" (1985:38) to refer to what members of a culture share.

CULTURE AND CULTURAL ANALYSES OF POLITICS

CULTURE

Culture, a central concept in anthropology, has been defined in a wide variety of ways that variously emphasize culture as social organization, core values, specific beliefs, social action, or a way of life (Kroeber and Kluckholm 1952). Most contemporary analyses, however, begin, as I do here, with Geertz's definition of culture as "an historically transmitted pattern of meaning embodied in symbols, a system of inherited conceptions expressed in symbolic forms by means of which men communicate, perpetuate, and develop their knowledge about and attitudes towards life" (1973b: 89)[4] This view emphasizes culture as public, shared meanings; behaviors, institutions, and social structure are understood not as culture itself but as culturally constituted phenomena (Spiro 1984). Culture from this perspective is a worldview that explains why and how individuals and groups behave as they do, and includes both cognitive and affective beliefs about social reality and assumptions about when, where, and how people in one's culture and those in other cultures are likely to act in particular ways (see also Berger 1995).[5] For purposes of political analysis, I want to emphasize that shared understandings occur among people who also have a common (and almost invariably named) identity which signals distinctions between the group and outsiders. Culture, in short, marks "a distinctive way of life" characterized in the subjective we-feelings of cultural group members (and outsiders) and is expressed through specific behaviors (customs and rituals) – both sacred and profane – which mark the daily, yearly, and life cycle rhythms of its members and reveal how people view past, present, and future events and understand choices they face (Berger 1995). Cultural metaphors have both cognitive meaning, which describes group experience, and high affective salience, which emphasizes the unique intragroup bonds – almost like a secret code – that set one group's experience apart from that of others.

It should be pointed out that in a shared meaning and identity system the fact that different individuals and groups understand each other does not imply agreement that widely held meanings are necessarily acceptable to all. Rather, meaning and identity, control over symbols and rituals, and the ability to impose one interpretation rather than another on a situation are frequently bitterly contested (Scott 1985). In this same vein, Laitin (1988) contends that culture highlights points of concern to be debated (1988: 589) and not just areas of agreement. Sharing a culture does not mean that people are necessarily in agreement on specifics, only that they possess a similar understanding of how the world works.

[4]D'Andrade (1984: 88) points out that the radical shift from the view of culture as behavior that could be understood within a stimulus-response framework to culture as systems of meaning is found in a number of fields. For a more complete discussion of culture as meanings and symbols see the excellent discussions in Schweder and LeVine (1984).

[5]I use worldview to include affective elements, whereas often the concept of social schema only emphasizes cognitive elements. Anthony Wallace's concept of mazeway is a parallel to worldview (1970).

Placing the concept of culture at the center of analysis affects the questions asked about political life (Brysk 1995; Merelman 1991: 45). For example, an interest in distinctive worldviews and identity leads to questions about how differences in worldviews might explain such phenomena as the emergence of certain leaders and reactions to them, the organization of political decision making, social movement mobilization, or perception of external threats. At the same time, an interest in culture and cultural difference discourages inquiry into the role of rational self-interest in political choice making, for such questions presume that interest maximization is more or less invariant across cultures and does not need a theory of cultural variation to explain what is viewed as constant (Wildavsky 1987).

My goal is to suggest how cultural analysis enhances our understanding of politics, not to comprehensively review the field, which defined broadly, could include every study that includes a cultural variable in a regression equation on the one hand to the most hermeneutically informed textual analysis on the other. Here I emphasize work that gives a central role to the concept of culture as a system of meaning and identity, and in the next few pages I suggest core questions in comparative political analysis that profit from attention to the concept of culture. Underlying my presentation is the belief that most political scientists have not thought a great deal about culture; that many consider it an epiphenomenon to be explained away rather than to be incorporated into theories and explanations; and that many who do invoke culture define it so thinly that they do not develop analyses of cultural dynamics that are terribly insightful.[6]

Culture Frames the Context in Which Politics Occurs

Culture orders political priorities (Laitin 1986: 11), meaning it defines the symbolic and material objects people consider valuable and worth fighting over, the contexts in which such disputes occur, the rules (both formal and informal) by which politics takes place and who participates in it. In doing so, culture defines interests and how they are to be pursued. For example, anthropologist Napoleon Chagnon (1967) invokes the cultural importance of the value of fierceness (*waiteri* complex) to explain the prevalence of high warfare among Yanomamo communities; political scientist Edward Banfield (1958) explains the absence of political participation and civic society in southern Italy in terms of a cultural pattern he calls amoral familism; and political scientists Gabriel Almond and Sidney Verba (1963) explain differences in political attitudes and patterns of participation among the United States, Great Britain, Germany, Italy, and Mexico in terms of differences between participant, subject, and parochial political cultures. To understand the cultural framing of politics, consider how culture influences beliefs about, and the organization of, community, authority, and conflict (Ross 1988).

[6]Laitin (1986; 1988) describes "the two faces of culture," referring to culture as a system of meaning on the one hand and culture as a resource for instrumental action on the other. While I find the distinction useful and his analysis very consistent with my own, this twofold distinction is too brief for my purposes here.

Cultural understandings are at the core of the definition of political communities since people in a community share, in Geertz's (1973b) words, "schematic images of the social order," common meanings which Taylor says are the basis of community (1985: 39). Communities are distinct, but also nested, entities. People are invariably part of more than one community and develop multiple loyalties whose interrelationship can take a variety of forms. Authority in any political community is culturally constituted and consists of regularized procedures that members of a community consider more or less legitimate – meaning that they have been arrived at by a procedure they consider fair, although the issue may continue to be highly contested – for distributing tangible and symbolic goods. The establishment of legitimate authority is a historical process for a community (Arendt 1958) and a psychological one for individuals, linking people through a sense of common fate captured in the historical accounts people in a community share. The establishment and maintenance of political authority is often explained in cognitive and cost–benefit terms and threats of coercion but also involves ritual activity, including religious action, which connects people's everyday experience and anxiety to those of the collectivity (Edelman 1964; Kertzer 1988; Shils and Young 1953; Turner 1957, 1968). Conflict occurs in virtually all communities, and all cultures have norms about what is reasonable to fight about and how conflicts are to be managed. Cultures shape conflict, defining what is appropriate social action, how the motives of others should be understood, and what is worth fighting about (Ross 1993a). Thus, at the same time, culture constitutes the social order and is a tool for domination, and conflict over the nature and make-up of the political community and authority within it are regular features of political life.

Culture Links Individual and Collective Identities

Culture offers an account of political behavior that makes particular actions more or less likely and connects the fate of individuals and the group. The crucial connection at work is that of identification, which renders certain actions reasonable and removes alternatives that on other grounds might be equally plausible. Individual and collective action, this view suggests, are motivated, in part, by the sense of common fate people in a culture share and involve two distinct elements: the strong reinforcement between individual and collective identity that renders culturally sanctioned behavior rewarding and the sense that outsiders will treat oneself and other members of one's group in similar ways.

Identification dynamics involve the construction of internal images of the external world out of the developmental and historical experiences group members share. Many objects of identification are associated with primary sensations such as smell, taste, and sound that acquire intense affective meaning and only later acquire a cognitive component. People sharing cultural attachments have common experiences that facilitate the developmental task of incorporating group identity into one's own sense of self. Anderson (1991) writes of imagined communities, which can link the person and collective identities.

The process of within-group identity formation overemphasizes what it is that group members actually share. It gives greater emotional weight to the common elements, reinforcing them with an ideology of linked fate. It overvalues the uniformity within groups, emphasizing both affectively and cognitively the common elements individuals share, and exaggerating differences with outsiders (Turner 1988). Deviations from the norm are selectively ignored or negatively reinforced as incompatible with group solidarity and its myth of shared historical experiences.

It should be stressed that culture is only one basis for linking individual to social identity. It can be a particularly powerful one, however, in situations of threat and uncertainty because cultural attachments are connected to very primary feelings about identity. While much of our language, in western thought generally and psychoanalysis in particular, emphasizes an inherent conflict between the group and the individual, an emphasis on identity draws attention to ways in which social attachments are an integral way of strengthening individual identity (Turner 1988).

Culture Defines Group Boundaries and Organizes Actions Within and Between Them

As culture defines identity groups, it also specifies expectations concerning patterns of association within and between groups. Consider such basic questions as who lives with whom, who spends time together, to whom one is most attached emotionally, who controls scarce resources, how property is transferred between generations, and how work is organized. The world's cultures provide very different answers to each of these questions, but most important the evidence shows that how any group answers any of these questions has significance for how people act and expect others to behave (Levinson and Malone, 1981; Naroll 1970).

Cultural definitions of social groups – whether they are defined by kinship, age, gender, or common interests – entail clear expectations about how people are to act, even when these definitions are continually contested (Greif 1994; Scott 1985). How such social categories and groups are defined and the rules that regulate their behavior vary cross-culturally. Cultural norms regarding intergroup relations (here we can consider relations between groups in the same culture such as age or ritual groups, or groups from different cultures) can be highly elaborate. Cultures differ in how and when they restrict (and how they enforce such restrictions on) relations, but few are silent on these questions.

People don't often think about the social origin of groups with which they identify, for most groups are seen as natural, often biological in character, when in fact they are cultural and political constructions whose "reasonableness" needs to be regularly reasserted and taught to succeeding generations (Anderson 1991). Weber, for example, shows how the nineteenth-century French state, through the institutionalization of a national education system, investment in transportation, and universal male military service, created a sense of national identity out of a

myriad of regional loyalties (1976).[7] All cultures, of course, provide specific, but not always explicit, socialization regarding in-group and out-group distinctions. Cultural learning involves messages about groups' motives, their behavior, and how one is to act toward members of each category.

Cross-culturally, the rigidity of social distinctions is highly variable, and variation in the permeability of boundaries means that functioning categories are both contextual and changing over time. This is clearly seen in the literature on "situational ethnicity," which shows how distinctions among groups can depend upon what other groups are in a social environment and what the particular political stakes are in a conflict. In East Africa, for example, speakers of *Kiluhya,* whose homeland is in western Kenya, gradually developed a political and social identity as Luhya people through contact with other ethnic communities in Nairobi, Mombasa, Kampala, and other urban centers since 1900. Earlier, however, their identity was primarily as Marigoli, Busia, or Samia, more localized Baluhya subgroups.

Culture Provides a Framework for Interpreting the Actions and Motives of Others

Actions, like words, are highly ambiguous, and making sense of them requires a shared cultural framework to assure that the message that is sent is similar, if not identical with, that which is received. Few behaviors are so universal that they require little or no interpretation. The work on the cross-cultural (and even cross-species) interpretability of specific facial gestures (Ekman, Friesen, and Ellsworth 1972; Masters and Sullivan 1989), while fascinating, is also testimony to how few domains of human action are coherent outside of a shared cultural framework. Because most political and social action is complex, a capacity to decode only facial and other obvious physical gestures doesn't get one very far in understanding political life. It also provides little assistance in placing action in a broader context – one that includes motives, which offer an account of what someone has done but, in addition, says why they acted as they did.

Motives are central to cultural analysis because they offer a mechanism to link individual action to a broader social setting (D'Andrade and Strauss 1992). This contrasts with Geertz's focus on "inspecting events" and making sense of actors' interpretations of them but his rejection of the idea that we should examine mental structures (1973a: 10-12). D'Andrade's (1992) cultural analysis of motives develops the notion of a schema (not unlike what I am calling worldviews), "a conceptual structure which makes possible the identification of objects and events" (1992: 28). Schemas, he argues, are culturally acquired and produce "motivational strivings." He emphasizes the importance of understanding the context-dependent nature of schemas as interpretive devices and the need to spell out

[7]Certainly the comparative analysis of state-building has long recognized the role of cultural practices and political control over them, as well as the role of political leaders who become cultural icons, linking previously disparate groups in a single state and in the process defining newer, broader identities.

how they are acquired. Both D'Andrade and Strauss argue that we need to see cultures as "both the public actions, objects and symbols that make shared learning possible ... and the private psychological states of knowledge and feeling without which these public things are meaningless and could not be recreated" (Strauss 1992: 6).[8]

In many ways motives in cultural analysis are much like interests in rational choice theory. In statements such as "They were motivated by fear of their ancestors and so they sacrificed half of their livestock" or "The blips had an interest in weakening the military capability of their enemy," both motives and interests offer a "reasonable" account of why individuals or groups behave in a certain way. Yet there are also significant differences in the use of motives and interests as explanatory mechanisms that are central to the difference between cultural and rational choice explanations. Most basically, while interests are assumed to be more or less transparent (some would say given) and universal, motives are knowable only through empirical analysis of particular cultural contexts.[9] As a result, while turning to interests suggests that more or less any human group would behave the same way in a certain situation, an emphasis on motives focuses on explaining variation in behavior across groups. Wildavsky (1987) argues that rational choice theorists make a serious error in taking interests as given. In fact, he says, an empirically based cultural analysis reveals systematic variation in interests across cultures.

In an analysis of intracultural behavior, the difference between motives and interests is not always consequential, for in fact when interests are shared they can operate like motives, offering a readily available account of why people behave as they do. However, when we consider cross-cultural encounters, the difference between interests and motives can be more significant. Consider the statement above that a group of people motivated by fear of their ancestors and therefore sacrificed half their domestic animals. To people in another culture in which such fears are unknown, they are not plausible motives for action, and such behavior is not comprehensible. Trying to transform such an explanation into an interest statement ("They had an interest in not making the ancestors angry") still begs the question of why the group understands the world in terms of "fear of the ancestors." Only an analysis that seeks to explain why this motive is important in one culture but not another is adequate here.

Interest accounts of political action are imperialistic, dominating other explanations and insisting in what is often a tautological fashion that whatever action occurs can be understood in terms of individual (or group) interest maxi-

[8]This sort of rich understanding of culture is not one that it is possible to develop exclusively from survey data. Although such data can make a significant contribution to what I have called subjective cultural analysis, the data by themselves are insufficient for building an intersubjective cultural account.

[9]There have been efforts to identify a fixed number of human motives such as Murray's (1938) and McClelland's (1961) work on three particular motives – achievement, affiliation, and power. It is important to recognize that in both of these cases – especially McClelland's – the relative importance of any single motive varied both cross-culturally and across individuals.

mization. The power of interest explanations lies in their hypothesized connections between thought and action; their weakness, however, is that they begin with actor's action and then identify interests that are consistent with the pursuit of such action. All too infrequently is there an effort made to see if actors themselves make the same connections. More interesting from a cultural perspective is the almost complete absence of concern with the nature of specific interests in interest theories.[10] To the extent that groups and individuals are seen as having invariant interests, such as the maximization of wealth or political power, this question is somewhat uninteresting. However, to the degree to which important interests vary from culture to culture, the matter of what constitutes crucial political interests for groups or individuals is worthy of serious empirical study. Cultural explanations, as a result, do not deny the relevance of interests but see them as contextually defined and one motive among many. Even though it views interests as cultural constructions rather than objectively identifiable universals, cultural theory can complement rational choice and other interest theories. Its different emphasis does not necessarily lead to competing propositions that put the two theories in conflict with each other; rather, cultural theory's concern with the construction of interests addresses an issue about which interest theories have little to say.

In cross-cultural encounters people most often make sense of other groups' behavior, i.e., attribute motives to them, by drawing on their own cultural worldview. However, it is worth pointing out that cultural worldviews provide two contrasting strategies for encounters with outsiders. One is to apply the rules of one's own culture because they are, after all, what is best known (and often all that is known), believing that outsiders will respond as insiders do. The second is to search for different rules, assuming that outsiders share few motives with people in one's own culture, hence will respond in "heathen" ways and are likely to take advantage of any weakness shown to them – for they will not follow what are viewed as "civilized norms." The first strategy is that of generalization, whereas the second is one of differentiation.[11]

Few people ever subject shared cultural frameworks to self-conscious analysis, since most people deeply internalize cultural assumptions and hence rarely articulate them consciously or view them as problematic. Yet even in times of stress

[10]However, see Levi (this volume) and her recognition of early rational choice theory's lack of interest in this question and current attention to it, including an interest in the role of culture as a source of interests (e.g., Greif 1994).

[11]An important question is the extent to which any culture characteristically exhibits generalizing or differentiating behaviors in encounters with outsiders, at least in certain domains. In a cross-cultural study of internal and external conflict and violence, I found that in some cultures the levels of internal and external conflict are quite similar (generalizers) while in others they are highly differentiated. The differences between the two groups of societies are quite clear: Differentiating societies are characterized by many ties that link diverse groups in the society and that clearly mark them off from outsiders, while generalizing societies are those without strong mechanisms of internal integration. Probably a key reason why insiders and outsiders are treated somewhat the same is because whether one is an insider or outsider vis-à-vis a group is defined contextually and not in absolute terms (Ross 1993a: Chapter 7).

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there is a widespread (if not universal) ethnocentric tendency to suggest that "there is something wrong" with a person who fails to offer or misreads an obvious cultural signal and to take such behavior as evidence that something is "wrong" with that person or of the inferiority of the other group. For the most part, culturally shared worldviews are protected, and people will go to great lengths to resist changes that challenge their core elements.

Culture Provides Resources for Political Organization and Mobilization

Culture offers significant resources that leaders and groups use as instruments of organization and mobilization (Brysk 1995; Edelman 1964; Kertzer 1988; Laitin 1986). For example, Tilly has developed the concept of repertoires of collective action referring to "a limited set of routines that are learned, shared, and acted out through a relatively deliberate process of choices. Repertoires are learned cultural creations" (1995: 26; also see Tilly 1986; Traugott 1995; McAdam, Tarrow, and Tilly this volume). Anthropologist Abner Cohen (1969; 1974; 1981) spells out more generally the political uses of culture, emphasizing the importance of cultural organizations (formal or informal groups organized around specific cultural practices such as a religious or age group) as a political tool in situations where "normal politics" is not possible for one reason or another; in fact, the theory is much more widely relevant. In Cohen's analysis of Hausa traders in Ibadan (Nigeria) and Creoles in Freetown (Sierra Leone), the two were small minorities, so that using electoral strategies to pursue their economic and political goals would have likely resulted in massive defeats. Instead, the two groups organized around cultural issues – a religious revival focused on the Tijaniyyi brotherhood in the case of the Hausa, and Freemasonry for the Creoles. In each case these cultural responses to changing political situations provided intense within-group interaction and social exchange that prevented the loss of control over long-distance trade in the case of the Hausa and protected the Creoles's domination of the state's administrative elite.

Frequently groups use cultural organizations (not always consciously, as Cohen points out) to achieve goals that cannot be pursued directly. Cohen identifies six political problems addressed by cultural organizations that bolster group solidarity and effective mobilization (Cohen 1969: 201-10). (1) Such organizations help define a group's distinctiveness, meaning its membership and sphere of operation within the context of the contemporaneous political setting, through myths of origin and claims to superiority; descent and endogamy; moral exclusiveness; endo-culture; spatial proximity; and homogenization (201-4). (2) Cultural organizations meet the political need for intense internal communications among the group's constituent parts (205). (3) Cultural organizations offer mechanisms for decision making involving some formulation of general problems confronting the group and taking decisions about them (206). (4) They provide authority for implementing decisions and for speaking, where appropriate, on behalf of the group (207). (5)

Cultural organizations can provide a political ideology often rooted in the language of kinship and ritual, which gives legitimacy to power and converts it into authority (208-10). (6) Finally, cultural organizations meet the need for discipline, through ceremonials and rituals that connect the ideology to current problems of the community (210-11).[12]

In discussing religion, the prototypical cultural basis for political organization, Cohen points out that:

> Religion provides an ideal 'blueprint' for the development of an informal political organization. It mobilizes many of the most powerful emotions which are associated with the basic problems of human existence and gives legitimacy and stability to political arrangements by representing these as parts of the system of the universe. It makes it possible to mobilize the power of symbols and the power inherent in the ritual relationship between various ritual positions within the organization of the cult. It makes it possible to use the arrangements for financing and administering places of worship and associated places for welfare, education, and social activities of various sorts, to use these in developing the organization and administration of political functions. Religion also provides frequent and regular meetings in congregations, where in the course of ritual activities, a great deal of informal interaction takes place, information is communicated, and general problems are formulated and discussed. The system of myths and symbols which religion provides is capable of being continuously interpreted and reinterpreted in order to accommodate it to changing economic, political and other social circumstances. (210)

Although Cohen's analysis is about the coping strategies of small cultural minorities, it is clearly relevant to understanding how leaders of large ethnic groups (often, but not always, majorities) have come to, and held onto, political power. African politics since the 1960s provides many examples of mobilization around cultural symbols and fears, and so do European settings such as Northern Ireland, France with a strong antiimmigrant, antiforeigner party, and Germany with its numerous outbreaks of antiforeigner violence. It is, however, in Eastern Europe and the former Soviet Union where we perhaps have the most to learn about the political manipulation of cultural symbols and rituals and their sometimes disastrous consequences. Here we must ask why the appeals to Serbian, Armenian, or Hungarian identity are all so powerful. However, as Campbell (1983) has suggested, any such answer that relies on mechanisms of individual benefit only makes sense if we can also account for the strength of individual attachments to groups such as those defined in cultural terms.

[12]Cohen's analysis is quite compatible with the one resource mobilization theorists offer in their discussion of social movements, especially in their willingness to consider cultural as well as material resources (McAdam, Tarrow, and Tilly this volume).

CULTURAL ANALYSES OF POLITICS

Although one could make a cogent argument that cultural analyses are among the oldest works of political analysis, here I discuss a selected number of more recent studies that illustrate key concepts and methods associated with a cultural approach in comparative politics. My focus here is on approaches that give a central role to the concept of culture, not ones in which one or two cultural variables appear but are neither theoretically significant nor well developed. I discuss five different (but not necessarily mutually exclusive) approaches that are important because of their widespread influence within comparative politics and/or because of their potential to provide important insights. Under each I discuss a few important studies that illustrate the approach, without suggesting they are the only, or best, examples of it.

Culture, Personality, and Politics

The merging of the theoretical perspectives of psychoanalysis and cultural anthropology in the 1940s and early 1950s provided a framework linking macro- and micro-level phenomena to explain cross-cultural differences in behavior. A popularized branch of this work, national character studies, combined Ruth Benedict's (1934) view that cultures were highly patterned with psychoanalysis' stress on the importance of infant and child socialization to offer profiles (some would say caricatures) of large countries, such as Japan, Russia, and the United States, to explain, among other things, their political institutions and political styles (Benedict 1946; Gorer and Rickman 1946; Mead 1942). Emphasizing (often with weak data) the link between socialization (defined in terms of a country's modal patterns), personality (often not directly measured), and political behavior, these studies offered sweeping generalizations about American individualism, Japanese militarism, and Russian totalitarian rule. Within a few years, a wide range of critiques emerged emphasizing problems in these works, including assumptions of within-country homogeneity, lack of evidence linking key elements in the theory, and its inability either to account for political change or to speak to the zigs and zags in political life in the countries under study. Clearly, transferring culture and personality theory and methods from small-scale preindustrial societies to the largest modern, industrial nations was not successful on either theoretical or methodological grounds.[13]

However, two political scientists, Lucien Pye (1962) and Edward Banfield (1958), found sufficient merit in the approach that they borrowed from it in two widely read, influential studies, while trying to address some of the most trenchant critiques of national character research. Pye, in an ambitious study of Burma in the 1950s, sought to explain the country's search for national identity. Keenly aware of the criticism that the personalities of political elites might be significantly different from those of the mass public and the need to study personality directly, Pye produced data on the crucial psychological variables through in-depth psychoanalytic interviews with Burmese elites. Emphasizing identity issues in an Eriksonian framework, Pye developed the link between the problems of individual identity among the elites he interviewed and Burmese nation-building. Development, he concluded, was not just about economic policies and institution-building but was intimately linked to the worldviews and psychological capacities of a country's elites.

Banfield developed a far less psychoanalytic framework to examine the absence of collective social or political action among peasants in a town in southern Italy where on self-interest grounds an outsider might expect to find it. His answer was that amoral familism, the rule that one can only trust and cooperate with the members of one's immediate family, is taught from an early age and supported in a variety of domains of daily life. Wider cooperation fails to gain a toehold because no one can imagine that cooperation will be reciprocated or sustained. Consequently, the culture of amoral familism is a powerful configuration (as Ruth Benedict might have used the term) and difficult to overcome despite the likely benefits from doing so.

[13]Much of the critique of national character research was also relevant to studies in small-scale societies typically studied by anthropologists. For example, Wallace (1970:152-54) argued that while culture and personality theories would predict that a large proportion of the people in a small society would exhibit a similar personality profile, when he administered standardized tests to a community of Tuscarora Indians only 37% fit the modal pattern. Also see Inkeles and Levinson (1968) and LeVine (1973).

The Civic Culture Tradition

Without a doubt, when most political scientists think about cultural analysis of politics, Almond and Verba's *The Civic Culture* (1963) quickly comes to mind. Utilizing data collected from large national samples in five countries – the United States, Britain, Germany, Italy, and Mexico – the authors sought to explain different levels of support for, and participation in, democratic political practices. Almond and Verba identify three distinctive political cultures – the participant, subject, and parochial – which differ in the attitudes citizens express toward the political system, trust in political authorities, beliefs concerning the efficacy of individual and collective political actions, and levels of political involvement. Thus, individual subjective attitudes and behaviors are the basis for assigning individuals to patterns, and the distribution of a country's individuals determines where the country is categorized in Almond and Verba's scheme. As a result, Almond and Verba's indicators of political culture cohere far more loosely than the constituent parts of culture do for Benedict, Geertz, and most anthropologists (Merelman 1991: 52; see also Almond 1980).[14]

Although the civic culture data are more or less consistent with the authors' theory, there are large questions that remain from a study using individual level

[14]An additional criticism of the civic culture tradition is the impoverished, generally implicit, unilineal view of the world's political cultures on a single continuum with the United States at the high end, rather than a multidimensional, more complex image of cultural difference.

survey data to discuss national political patterns, such as how to explain the sometimes large numbers of people who do not fit a country's dominant pattern, the role of political institutions, the weak conception of culture that emerges from their individualistic approach, and the relationship between political and other domains of culture (Verba 1980). The relatively low correlations among attitudes, the very small number of respondents who fit ideal-typical patterns, and the subjective, but not intersubjective nature of survey data mean that survey evidence alone is insufficient to describe the existence and significance of cultural meaning systems. In contrast, Merelman's (1991) comparative study of political culture in the United States, Canada, and Britain is based on a richer view of culture as a system of meaning and includes intersubjective cultural data derived from television programs, corporate publications, textbooks, and magazine ads along with survey data.[15]

Nonetheless, survey research in literally dozens of countries has produced hundreds of studies in the civic culture tradition, including another large-scale study in which Verba and his colleagues examined political participation in seven countries (Verba, Nie, and Kim 1978). Perhaps, however, Inglehart (1977; 1988) is the political scientist who has most faithfully carried out work in the civic culture tradition, emphasizing culture in interpreting cross-national survey data using the yearly Euro-Barometer surveys. For example, he has explained in cultural terms the strong political and life-style differences between individuals who emphasize what he calls materialist and postmaterialist values, i.e., emphasis on order and the economy versus participation and free speech. Arguing that political scientists often develop explanations that give short shrift to cultural factors, Inglehart links the strength of a syndrome of attitudes he calls civic culture – personal life satisfaction, political satisfaction, interpersonal trust, and support for the existing social order – to democratic stability and economic development (1988).

Finally, although it does not rely on survey data as exclusively as Almond and Verba or Inglehart, Putnam's work on the political differences in the civic cultures in northern and southern Italy is also squarely in this tradition (1993). To the survey evidence he presents, Putnam also adds data on governmental performance, aggregate economic and political participation data, and interviews with political elites. Using these different data, Putnam argues that democracy and democratic innovations are most effective where there is a strong tradition of civic participation. When he examines alternative explanations for the relative success of Italian regionalization in 1976, he argues that those regions in which civic participation has flourished for perhaps the past 800 years are most likely to be those in which effective regional governments developed, whereas in regions without such cultural traditions (such as the one Banfield studied), the governments are less effective.[16]

[15]In another interesting example using a cultural indicator of collective political orientations, Regan (1994) relates sales of war toys and popularity of war movies to U. S. militarization.

[16]There has been extensive discussion of Putnam's (1993) work and its relevance beyond Italy, which is not my focus here. For two critical views of his theory pertinent to my discussion of culture, see Laitin (1995b) and Tarrow (1996).

Culture and Political Process: The Extended Case

Although political anthropology has existed as a field for decades, only a few political scientists have found its theoretical insights or methods of great interest (Barkun 1968; Bates 1983; Easton 1959; Friedrich with Horwitz 1968; Laitin 1986; Masters 1964). Much of this is probably due to the field's emphasis on documenting variations in political structure in human communities. Among these works one finds Fortes and Evans-Pritchard (1940), who provide detailed descriptions of eight African states and stateless societies in which kinship forms the basis of political organization and who argue strongly that politics does not require a state with a monopoly over the means of legitimate force, as Weberians have argued. Others illustrate the complex ways in which different societies deal with leadership succession, political decision making, and conflict management (Goody 1966; Kuper and Richards 1971; Pospisil 1971). Cross-cultural studies in this tradition examine patterns among political variables and relations between them and social, economic, and ecological factors (Murdock 1949; Ross 1986, 1988). From the point of view of cultural approaches to comparative politics, most structural studies in political anthropology, while documenting differences among societies, do not pay much explicit attention to culture per se.

In contrast to structural studies, works that put political process at their core have greater theoretical and methodological relevance for comparative politics. Initially developed by Max Gluckman and his followers in field research in southern Africa (and later known as the Manchester School), these studies focused on explaining how and why particular political outcomes occur, providing rich details about political conflict in which culture's role is at center stage (Gluckman 1942; Mitchell 1956; Epstein 1958; Turner 1957; 1968; Cohen 1969; 1974). These studies, which particularly influenced Africanists, offered a deeply contextualized account of particular events or problems to develop broad middle-range theory that is especially useful in comparative political analysis.[17] For example, in one study, Victor Turner (1957) analyzed how the Ndembu of Zambia cope with the strong conflicting structural demands between their norms of political succession and postmarital residence. He argued that strong cross-cutting ties in their society provide the basis for the extensive use of ritual, which emphasizes what members share and integrates a group that often finds itself bitterly divided on other grounds. Abner Cohen, whose work was discussed in detail above, argues that culture provides a strategic, although not necessarily conscious, basis for political mobilization of groups whose positions cannot be defended through more conventional political means. An examination of ethnic mobilization in the last decade in Eastern Europe (and elsewhere) shows the power of his analysis, which few political scientists have examined, and offers a theoretical context for explaining the behavior of political leaders whose ability to survive in multicultural contexts is uncertain.

[17]Gluckman, for example, wrote about the importance of studying what he called "trouble cases" in his work on African law, but it is clear that he saw this as a much more general methodological strategy as well.

The extended cases of interest here are those that use culture to explain why and how a political conflict takes the course it does. For example, Scott (1985) analyzes the responses to irrigation and the institutionalization of double cropping in Sedaka, a village in Malaysia, in terms of how the richer and poorer rice farmers understand the demands of traditional norms and obligations in light of new opportunities and challenges. His study includes several detailed cases, one concerning the village gate and another involving a politically motivated village improvement scheme, that are especially effective at showing how the competing interests are manifest within a culturally homogeneous village. Scott demonstrates that it is only because the villagers' shared understandings are so great that small actions that an outsider might easily miss can contribute to the continuing battle over access to resources.

Political Ritual and Identity

Before Murray Edelman published *The Symbolic Uses of Politics* (1964), few political scientists gave much serious thought to issues of political symbolism and ritual. Since then, comparativists ignore it at their peril. Edelman's core argument was simple but important. Politics, he said, is a passing parade of symbols to which we react on two levels: the cognitive, which involves the information any symbol communicates; and the affective, which consists of powerful feelings political symbols can invoke. The ability of leaders to provide symbolic reassurance to the masses allows organized groups to take the lion's share of material benefits for themselves. Edelman and the many people he influenced more indirectly have made the study of political symbolism and ritual central to analyses of political institutions and dynamics. For our point of view here, this work is crucial because it shows how cultural frameworks render political symbols and rituals significant in a wide range of settings and to a wide number of political dynamics (Brysk 1995).

Whereas earlier analyses, for example, emphasized elections as citizen choice making, a more cultural analysis would also pay attention to how political parties and candidates, in their quest for power, use culturally shared metaphors and culturally rooted fears in their appeals to citizens. Policy positions or candidate choices, we now understand, are not just about the issue preferences of individuals; we also must ask how such orientations are or are not consonant with shared cultural understandings and identities. The invocation of symbols and use of rituals do not just indicate points of consensus; they are also efforts to overcome contradictions in situations of disjunction (Kurtz 1991: 149).

This richer understanding of politics' cultural roots has produced an interest in how political rituals create (rather than just reflect) meanings and shape actions (Gusfield 1966). There is attention to high-visibility political rituals such as the torchlight marches in East Germany in the waning days of the old regime in 1989, and how participation in these events provided the courage for citizen participation under a regime that earlier made such action

unthinkable. More generally, political transitions, such as the changes in Eastern Europe or in South Africa between 1990 and 1994, can only be explained effectively when we make sense of the interaction between substantive change and ritual action.

An even stronger position is that political rituals are particularly critical to constructing political reality for most people (Edelman 1988; Kertzer 1988: 77-101) and that the power to control ritual is important.

> Indeed, ritual is an important means of influencing people's ideas about political events, political policies, political systems, and political leaders. Through ritual, people develop their ideas about what are appropriate political institutions, what are appropriate qualities in political leaders, and how well the world around them measures up against these standards. (Kertzer 1988: 79)

In short, rituals are important instruments of control and from a Gramscian point of view are central mechanisms for obtaining and maintaining power. Detailed analyses of meaning-construction rituals would examine social movements as well as the mass media, which increasingly for citizens of mass democracies provide not only access to core knowledge but also the framework for making sense of it (Dayan and Katz 1992).

Political rituals offer meaning in ambiguous, uncertain situations and are crucial to the dynamics of identity construction and maintenance, particularly in periods of change. In bringing certain people together, culturally rooted rituals simultaneously exclude others. Powerful political rituals are those that utilize culturally rooted metaphors and meanings to offer a vision of reality; often this involves pitting one group against another by raising fears and threats to the point that people are all too ready to undertake strong action in the name of the group.

Culture and Political Conflict

In many analyses culture plays a central role in explaining the level and form of political conflict and violence. Culture in these analyses provides a system of meaning to make sense of the actions and motives of opponents and a mechanism for building and maintaining identity. Within-group worldviews are reinforced as groups increase in-group solidarity and out-group hostility increases. Not all cultural mobilization in conflict situations leads to violence, however, and one important comparative question concerns when this turn to violence occurs and when it does not.

For example, Laitin (1995a) offers a controlled comparison emphasizing culturally constituted differences in social organization to explain the high use of political violence in the Basque protest in Spain and its relative absence in nearby Catalonia. He identifies as a significant difference between these subcultures the relative importance of autonomous male groups with strong norms of honor in the small towns in the Basque region and their relative absence in Catalonia.

When these small, local male groups engage in protest that produces some limited and mainly symbolic successes, violence becomes self-sustaining.[18] As a result, the differences in the use of violence between the regions are not a function of objective differences or relative deprivation within them but of the cultural organization of each community, which affects the likelihood that the ethnic revivals in each community will turn to violence.

Ross (1993a) provides a more general cross-cultural analysis to explain differences in levels and targets of conflict and violence. He finds that psychocultural variables – low warmth and affection in child rearing, harsh socialization, and male gender identity conflict – were excellent predictors of a society's overall level of violence, while social structural factors, such as the strength of cross-cutting ties or the presence of exclusive male groups, determined whether targets were within the same society, in another society, or both. He goes on to argue that cultural worldviews determine how groups see outsiders and the motives attributed to them. In addition, the culture of conflict is a crucial determinant not just of a group's level of conflict but also of how conflict is managed when it occurs (Ross 1993b).

Raymond Cohen (1990; 1991) demonstrates how culture provides a framework through which political leaders understand the actions and words of others in his examination of how cultural assumptions complicate the task of diplomatic negotiations. First through an analysis of Egyptian–Israeli negotiations over time (1990), and then through an examination of how cultural miscommunication has affected U.S. negotiations with Mexico, Egypt, China, India, and Japan, Cohen (1991) suggests that differences in time frames and in the importance of context, language, and individualistic versus collectivist ethos all are important in either inhibiting or facilitating negotiated efforts to deal with international issues. Focusing only on "substance," he contends, leads to serious missed opportunities and failures where successes might have emerged.

Finally, culture is central in the ethnic and identity disputes that have seemingly proliferated in recent years. In intransigent conflicts between groups with very different systems of meaning and distinct identities, cultural factors easily become the focal point of many conflicts when they are central to the parties' definition of the dispute (Ross 1997). In such situations, each group readily sees itself as a threatened minority whose very existence is precarious (Horowitz 1985). Frequently, in conflicts such as the one in Northern Ireland, differences are framed so that central elements of one culture are seen as powerful threats to the other; in these cases one can only imagine a resolution that addresses these culturally rooted fears head-on (Mulvihill, Ross, and Schermer 1995).

[18]In many ways his argument is similar to fraternal interest group theory in anthropology, which says that in the absence of centralized authority, coresident related males are likely to defend what they see as their core interests through organized violence (Paige and Paige 1981; Ross 1993a).

CRITIQUE OF CULTURAL ANALYSES OF POLITICS

Cultural studies of politics have been subject to a number of important criticisms about which proponents cannot remain silent. Perhaps the most significant problems arise over methodological issues such as the vagueness of culture as a unit of analysis or the issue of within- versus between-cultural variation. Others are concerned with the vagueness of the concept of culture and the difficulty in distinguishing culture from related concepts such as social organization, political behavior, and values. Some are worried that, since culture suggests relatively fixed, unchanging patterns of behavior, it is not terribly useful in accounting for changes in behavior and beliefs, a key feature of most contemporary political systems. Finally, there is concern that cultural analyses are not sufficiently explicit concerning the mechanisms linking culture and political action. Each of these criticisms is worth some brief comments. However, it should be clear that my view is that none of these problems is fatal and that in the cultural approach to comparative politics, like those rooted in interests or institutions, the best way to address the conceptual and methodological problems is through a multimethod search for convergence rather than abandonment of the theory.

Unit of Analysis Issues

Defining the unit of analysis precisely – be it voters, states, wars, or international organizations – is one of the first lessons of most methods seminars in political science. "What is a culture?" some political scientists ask, meaning "How do I know one when I see one?" since culture is not a unit of social or political organization with readily identifiable boundaries. Furthermore, the imprecision of common language use makes it very unclear what are a culture's key properties. As a result we hear references to western culture, French culture, Breton culture, rural Breton culture, etc. Where does the parsing stop? Conceptually the best answer is that the appropriate level of analysis depends on what one wants to explain. However, this is not always an easy-to-use methodological guide in empirical research.

Huntington offers a similar answer when he describes a range of what he calls cultural entities starting with villages and moving to regions, ethnic groups, nationalities, religious groups, and civilizations. Each has distinct cultural features that distinguish it from similar units in other cultural entities. The key for him is that the civilization is "the highest grouping of people and the broadest level of cultural identity people have short of that which distinguishes humans from other species" (1993: 24). Following Horowitz (1985), he says that the level of cultural identity that is the most salient at any moment depends upon where someone is and what they are doing with whom.

The unit of analysis problem is about what constitutes the core of a culture and also how to identify its edges (Barth 1969). Where does one culture stop and another begin? Since cultures, unlike states or political parties, are not formal units of organization, treating them as independent units of political analysis can

be troubling indeed. While this may seem like a devastating critique to some, it is just as true that neither states nor voters are as independent as our political and methodological theories lead us to believe. For purposes of most analyses we emphasize the independence of all these units. What is probably more useful is to be more sophisticated about interaction effects and the influence of one unit upon another.[19]

Probably the best answer to these methodological problems is to begin with the recognition that cultural identity is layered and situationally defined.[20] People hold multiple identities, some identities partially overlap, and the group boundaries can shift across issues. Despite the methodological problems this can present, we cannot ignore culture if we think it is important, and we should make decisions about units of analysis based on what we are trying to explain rather than on abstract criteria intended to identify a set of cultural units akin to a list of all UN member states.[21] In addition, there are a number of other procedures we can use to define cultural units in particular pieces of research. For example, we can use operational criteria such as asking people how they identify themselves and others and use social consensus about particular cultural groups and their boundaries. The point is that the task for research is to identify relevant groupings in whatever situation is under study. The fact that people can have multiple identities or that identities can change over time does not invalidate such analysis, it just makes the research more complicated. Good longitudinal data on socially defined cultural identities might be of real importance, for example, in understanding the breakdown of Yugoslavia and its recent civil war.

Political culture research in the Almond and Verba tradition ought to solve the problem by defining culture as the aggregate of individual orientations. Almond and Powell, for example, define political culture as "the pattern of individual attitudes and orientations towards politics among members of a political system" (1966: 23). Reducing culture to the sum of individual attitudes is hardly

[19]Galton's Problem refers to the fact that in cross-cultural (and cross-national) samples, assumptions about the independence of units are often inappropriate and that substantive correlations among culture traits can reflect diffusion and borrowing rather than functional association. The most useful response is not to ignore this problem but to build diffusion hypotheses into models to test the relative power of each pattern (Ross and Homer 1976).

[20]Another answer comes from Thompson, Ellis, and Wildavsky (1990), who argue that culture is seen in distinct ways of life, which they define in terms of Mary Douglas's grid-group analysis. Group refers to the extent to which an individual is incorporated into bounded units, whereas grid refers to the degree to which a person's behaviors are circumscribed by externally imposed restrictions. Different individuals or states can, in their view, exhibit different degrees of each of the five combinations they identify over time. However, viable social units, they argue, are not characterized by the presence of only one culturally defined way of life. While I find much of their analysis of the interaction between values and social structure quite useful, it is less evident to me that making the way of life the unit of analysis provides a guideline easy for researchers to use, since they say multiple orientations can exist in the same culture or subculture and that individuals may have different orientations across time and situations.

[21]This does not mean that such a list of societies that represent the world's cultures, such as one of the samples developed in cross-cultural research, is not useful in many research situations.

adequate, however, ignoring both the context in which particular attitudes are held and the shared understandings that organize clusters of intersubjective orientations (Merelman 1991). Culture, as a result, is no longer a system of meanings and identity; rather, it is simply a frequency distribution on a set of single attitude items – a kind of machine with totally interchangeable parts. While studying individuals is one way that we can understand culture, as both Taylor (1985: 37) and Geertz (1973a) argue, culture is not the property of single individuals, for it is rooted in social practice and shared understandings, and survey data alone cannot build a rich understanding of political culture. This explains why survey data alone are inherently limited as a tool for studying political culture; they must be used in conjunction with other data to provide a coherent portrait of any single culture or comparisons between cultures.

Within-Culture Variation Can Be Substantial

It often seems easy to say what members of formal groups have in common. But what exactly do people of a given culture share? My answer is shared meanings and a common identity. Operationally, this can be ambiguous, however, for we know that people who themselves identify with a culture (or any organized group) may also differ in terms of values, lifestyles, political dispositions, religious belief and practice, and ideas about common interests. In addition, Strauss cautions that while there may be some variation in schemas (what I have been calling worldviews) across individuals in the same culture, even those with very similar schemas may not internalize exactly the same things, and that the ambiguity of metaphor produces variation in responses (Strauss 1992: 10-11). However, this is not necessarily any more a problem in dealing with culture than with other units (or even intra-individual variation in behavior or attitudes over time). LeVine argues that emphasizing culture as common understandings of the symbols and representations they communicate does not mean there is necessarily a problem with within-cultural variation in thought, feeling, and behavior (1984: 68).

A second answer is that often what is more crucial politically than agreement on content is that people share a common identity, although this still leaves open the question of different degrees of identification and differences in the actions people are willing to undertake in the name of that identity. Shared identities mean that people see themselves as similar to some people and different from others and are open to potential mobilization on the basis of these differences. What an emphasis on identity stresses, once again, is that the relevant critical aspects of cultural similarity and difference are defined in specific political contexts. It is also the case that often what people believe they share may be at odds with reality because perceptions of cultural homogeneity overemphasize what is actually shared, minimizing within-group while stressing between-group differences. In this dynamic, in-group conformity pressures will lead people both to selectively perceive greater within-group homogeneity on critical characteristics than actually exists and to generate greater actual homogeneity and group conformity in situations where perceived threats to the culture are great.

Distinguishing Culture from Other Concepts

Some uses of the concept of culture, such as much of the early work on national character, defined culture so broadly as to include society, personality, values, and institutions. In fact, nothing was excluded.[22] The very broad use of the concept of culture is also seen among social scientists emphasizing culture as a source of the social integration of a society. This perspective, probably clearest in functional theory in British social anthropology, would use culture to refer both to distinct elements of social organization and to the "fit" between different parts of a cultural system and the integration of the whole. The problem here is not the concept of culture but the way it is used. As noted above, the current anthropological focus is on culture as meaning systems distinct from social structure and behavior. D'Andrade makes this particularly clear in his description of culture "as consisting of learned systems of meaning, communicated by means of natural language and other symbol systems, having representational, directive, and affective function, and capable of creating cultural entities and particular senses of reality. Through these systems of meaning, groups of people adapt to their environment and structure interpersonal activities" (1984: 116). I find Spiro's (1984) clear distinction between culture as a system of meaning, and what he calls "culturally constituted elements," referring to social structure, behaviors, beliefs, rituals, etc., particularly helpful here.

Spiro's (1984) distinction between culture and culturally constituted elements allows us to distinguish between cultural meanings and identity on the one hand and structure, behaviors, and individual beliefs on the other. Structure, from this perspective, is reflective of (and to some extent derived from) culture, but it is independently measurable, and an important empirical question concerns the conditions under which the correspondence between culture and various culturally constituted elements is high and when it is not. We also can examine hypotheses about change and examine how culture, structure, and other phenomena do and do not shift in patterned ways. Last, the distinction makes it feasible to compare societies in which the correspondence between culture and social structure are high and those in which they are low to test hypotheses about the impact of consistency on such things as citizen satisfaction with government, political involvement, and political stability.

Culture and Change

Cultures are commonly viewed as slow-changing entities. How, then, can the concept of culture help comparativists deal with issues of political change, especially relatively rapid developments such as the end of military rule in many Latin American states during the 1980s or the breakup of the Soviet empire?

[22]Pye says that national character analyses tended to treat "personality and culture as opposite sides of the same coin. Culture for them was the generalized personality of a people, in the sense that the modal personality of a people was their culture, and thus culture and personality were essentially identical factors shaping behavior" (1991: 494).

Three points are worth making. First, cultural analyses are no better than any other partial theories, such as interest or institutional ones, available in comparative politics. There are some phenomena for which each is most powerful, and some aspects of change are not best explained in cultural terms. Second, and interestingly, while it is not clear that cultural theories would have explained the fall of the Soviet empire very well (many other comparative political theories share this feature), a political cultural analysis is probably a good deal better at accounting for the ebb and flow of politics in the region since 1989 than many of its rivals (Fleron 1996). Particularly in unstructured, changing settings, cultural interpretations and assumptions about the motivation of others can be especially important in accounting for political processes in which there are few or no institutionalized procedures to guide action. Third, few contemporary views see culture as a static, unchanging phenomenon marked by fixed beliefs and unalterable practices (Eckstein 1988). Rather, emphasis on the interactive, constructed nature of culture suggests a capacity to modify beliefs and behaviors, and for important shifts in the salience of particular cultural understandings and their connections to other cultural elements (Goode and Schneider 1994; Merelman 1991).

Culture can play a significant role in political change despite the fact that culture itself does not change rapidly, if, and when political demands are articulated through culturally meaningful accounts, which sharpen goal articulation and mobilize supporters. Defining culturally legitimate possible alternatives both builds support and can challenge a regime. Brysk argues that this is particularly powerful when it involves reframing elements of identity in a way that mobilizes supporters, produces agenda change, and challenges the legitimacy and authority of existing policies and institutions (1995: 580-2).

The Mechanisms Underlying Cultural Explanations

Asking "how culture works" raises two different questions: (1) How does the organization of any particular culture produce the specific effects attributed to it? and (2) why are appeals to cultural identity so powerful that people are willing to take high risks in their name? The first is about the organization of culture and the second about its mobilizing power.

Theories that give culture a central explanatory role must specify how the effects attributed to culture come about. It is not good enough to simply say, "They did it because they're Germans." While this statement implies that non-Germans (such as the Japanese or French) would have behaved differently, adding a clause to this effect doesn't really enhance the explanation a great deal. Only when one starts to say why Germans are likely to behave in a certain way that is different from how Americans behave (in what is presumed to be an equivalent situation) do we begin to have an adequate explanation that pays attention to the content of culture and also says something about how it is learned and reinforced

(Andrade, 1992; Strauss, 1992D).[23] Indeed this was a central concern of early political culture research, although few were very impressed with the adequacy of explanations it provided. Learning and reinforcement involve institutional contexts in which a person (child or adult) practices, and then masters, key behaviors, infusing them with emotional significance.[24]

Social experiences within institutions such as schools, religious organizations, kin groups, and later in work and leisure settings all provide cultural messages about values and expectations that are selectively reinforced. It certainly is the case that the messages from different domains are not always fully consistent. Sometimes there is a difference in emphasis; at other times there is an outright contradiction, e.g., peer groups and families don't necessarily give adolescents the same messages. However, what are most important from a cultural perspective are the beliefs, customs, rituals, behaviors, expectations, and motives that are internalized by individuals and widely shared among people in a culture even though they may also, at the same time, be highly contested. For example, Scott's (1985) study of a small rice-growing village in Malaysia shows how people can share meanings while at the same time compete over how specific elements are to be weighted and in what situations specific cultural elements are most relevant. Culture is about what is held in common and regularly reinforced; there is a reward for "getting it right" and a cost – which most people are willing to pay at times – for not doing so. Finally, it should be noted that cultural learning is not necessarily very conscious, occurring when individuals in institutional roles pass on culturally sanctioned beliefs and behaviors to others. Through these experiences culture prepares people to make sense of – to interpret–the world and act "effectively" in it.

The power of culture – the ability to mobilize action in its name – requires explanation, for it is not always the case that people can or will exhibit solidarity around cultural identity just because a leader (or anyone else) asserts that there is an external threat. Cultural mobilization builds on fears and perceived threats that are consistent with internalized worldviews and regularly reinforced through high in-group interaction and emotional solidarity. Such worldviews are expressed in daily experiences as well as significant ceremonial and ritual events that effectively restate and renew support for a group's core values and the need for solidarity in the face of external foes (Kertzer 1988). In potentially threatening situations, the ability of a group to organize collective action, which can range from unified voting to political demonstrations and violent action, is tied to the plausibility of a specific worldview – although the view itself does not produce direct effects. Rather, these must be mediated through institutions (Laitin 1986; 1995a). The resonance between the definition of a situation and group-based action is often not explicit, as Abner Cohen's (1969) analysis points out. Nonetheless it is effective when group members act in unified ways in the face of perceived threats. Closer examination of the dynamics of psychocultural interpretation in the next section suggests additional specific mechanisms at work.

[23]The point here is similar to Przeworski and Teune's (1970), that comparative political analysts should strive to replace proper names with variable names. While some interpretivists only want to consider the uniqueness of each culture and context, others are comfortable making comparisons while recognizing the potential problems inherent in any comparison and the generalizations derived from it.

[24]Beatrice Whiting (1980) discusses the importance cross-culturally of the placement of individuals in particular contexts, e.g., girls take care of younger siblings more than boys and boys are more likely to take care of animals in all the cultures for which she has data. Her data also show that cultures vary in the settings they "make available" to individuals, and she distinguishes between behaviors seen as "mundane" and those domains that are "projective" and infused with great emotional significance.

THE CENTRALITY OF INTERPRETATION IN CULTURAL ANALYSES OF POLITICS

At the core of contemporary intersubjective approaches to culture and politics is the concept of interpretation. Culture in the Geertzian, postmodern view is a system of meaning and identity that accounts for why and how people in any particular setting act as they do, in contrast to the idea of culture as a set of norms or behaviors that directly shape action. This culture-as-meaning-and-identity perspective gives a central role to interpretation, the making of meaning from the ambiguous and fragmented elements of daily life (Darnton 1985; Taylor 1985). While there is widespread agreement that a subjective, meaning-centered conception of culture is richer than more mechanistic or material views, there is also fundamental disagreement concerning the goals of cultural explanations of politics. More humanistically oriented political (and other social) scientists emphasize the role of particular contextual and historical forces that shape meaning for actors. Their concern is with the uniqueness of each context as actors understand it, and they have little interest in accounting for patterns of similarity and difference across settings. This emphasis on the uniqueness of each cultural context and its particular meaning for actors readily leads to the conclusion that any search for generalization is pointless, for the only generalizations that might be offered are uninteresting. At the same time, this radical interpretivist view denies the value of any comparison at all and is not the one I develop here (Edgerton 1992: 23-45).[25]

[25]In anthropology where this debate has been particularly heated, two issues – evaluation of different cultures (cultural relativism) and comparison of cultures – are often fused. The relativism debate concerns the appropriateness of evaluating cultures other than one's own, while the comparison question turns on the issue of whether it is possible to compare cultures and develop meaningful generalizations. Edgerton describes the anti-comparison position as "asserting far more than the self-evident point that people in different societies live in somewhat different worlds of meaning. They are claiming that each of these worlds is truly unique – incommensurable and largely incomprehensible – and that the people who inhabit them have different cognitive abilities ... [and] various postmodern relativists and interpretivists postulate fundamental differences from one culture to the next in cognitive processes involving logic, causal inferences, and information processing" (Edgerton 1992:28).

In contrast, more social scientifically oriented investigators, while accepting the intersubjective and subjective character of culture, seek to identify the mechanisms that link culture and action, and to identify regularities in cultural behavior across settings. One approach found in psychological anthropology draws on both psychoanalytic and cognitive theories to explain how culture affects behavior (e.g., D'Andrade 1992; Spiro 1987). It emphasizes, for example, how individuals absorb, process, and modify cultural knowledge (information, affect, images) to develop images of the world, and how these images affect collective and individual action.

Here I discuss the conceptual and methodological importance of interpretations, arguing that they are key tools for understanding culture and politics. The rich accounts found in the images of the world's people point to key concerns, assumptions about how social and political relations are organized, and views about the possibilities for political action. These images of the world are obtainable, in part, through public and private accounts. However, simply presenting the transcripts of individuals' stories is insufficient for a number of reasons, including the important one that texts do not speak for themselves and without an intermediary they often make no sense to an outsider (Scott 1985: 138-41). Rather, the comparativist needs to frame accounts in both a cultural and comparative context and highlight the crucial elements (Kohli et al. 1995: 44-5).[26] Laitin (1988) says that connecting culture and action requires detailed local, ethnographic knowledge and experience. Without a rich contextual understanding, it is too difficult to derive much significance from the detailed, highly contextualized interpretations of the world that hardly ever speak for themselves.[27]

The interpretations of interest here are accounts of the world that people within a culture widely share (or at least easily understand).[28] Elsewhere I use the term psychocultural interpretations to describe how shared interpretations are acquired through individual-level psychological (and social-psychological) mechanisms that are widespread in a culture (Ross 1993a; 1995).[29] Psychocultural interpretations are the basis on which people in a culture understand the world and link specific worldviews to political action, offering rich data for comparative political analyses.

[26]Here the subjectivity of different social scientists and varying theoretical interests will certainly produce variation in the accounts that are rendered. Often this will reflect differences in emphasis. This is not necessarily a sign of the method's failure but of its complexity; as with other methods, efforts to obtain inter-subjective reliability among observers are important.

[27]This is the same claim that many students of the U. S. Congress have made over the years.

[28]Taylor proposes an interesting test of the utility of an interpretation when he writes, "We make sense of action when there is a coherence between the actions of the agent and the meaning of his situation for him" (1985: 24).

[29]The term psychocultural brings together the psychological processes central to the construction of these interpretations and cultural dynamics, emphasizing that these orientations are not just personal but, rather, are nurtured and socially reinforced, linking individuals in a collective process, amplifying what is shared, and emphasizing differences among groups (Mack, 1983).

Psychocultural interpretations offer plausible accounts of the world, emphasizing the motives of different actors and reinforcing those features that distinguish one's own group from others. When supported by one's social world, these plausible accounts offer psychic and social protection from the ambiguities and uncertainties of existence, reinforcing social and political bonds within groups. The power of psychocultural interpretations lies in their shared social character, not those idiosyncratic features that distinguish one person's account from another's. As Taylor writes, "They are not subjective meanings, the property of one or some individuals, but rather inter-subjective meanings which are constitutive of the social matrix in which individuals find themselves and act" (1985: 36).

At the core of psychocultural interpretations are internalized, shared orientations rooted in the earliest social relationships that help people in a culture make sense of the inherently ambiguous, highly charged events that characterize their lives (Ross 1995). Psychocultural interpretations draw attention not just to what people do to each other but also to what one group of people think or feel that another group of people are doing, trying to do, or wanting to do. In a context of suspicion and uncertainty, not only actions but also presumptions about the intentions and meanings behind the actions (or inactions) play an important role. This is crucial, for in few political situations do external events provide clear explanations for what is occurring; to develop these, individuals turn to internal frameworks which then shape subsequent behavior.

While participants in any dispute can often tell someone "just what the conflict is about," this precision is often illusory, and political scientists often see this as evidence of flawed decision making and/or faulty information processing. However, it is more useful to view these "errors" as important data about the social dynamics. In many situations, different parties don't always agree about what a conflict is about, when it started, or who is involved, for they operate from (but are not aware of) alternative frames of references that shape their actions. Many disputes, whether they are between families in a community or nations in the world, involve parties with a long history, which, of course, includes long lists of accumulated grievances that can be trotted out and appended to newer ones as political conditions shift (Scott 1985). In many situations, complex conflicts are about a range of issues that are not of equal interest to all parties. For example, Hager (1995) offers a particularly clear case in her examination of conflict in West Berlin over energy policy, which she examines in terms of both the public policy considerations and the democratization issues concerning the legitimation of citizen roles in decision making on technologically complex matters. Decision makers saw the issues as technical ones needing conflict management, while citizen groups emphasized the legitimation of citizen participation in decision making.

The same factors that push actors to make sense of a situation also lead to cognitive and perceptual distortion, because the desire for certainty is often greater than the capacity for accuracy. Not only are disputants likely to make systematic errors in the "facts" underlying interpretations, but the homogeneous nature of most social settings and cultural amplifiers reinforces these self-serving

mistakes. What is most crucial, however, about interpretations of politics is the compelling, coherent account they offer to the parties in linking discrete events to general understandings. Central to such interpretations is the attribution of motives to parties. Once identified, the existence of such motives seemingly makes it easy to "predict" another's future actions, and through one's own behavior to turn such predictions into self-fulfilling prophesies. In this sense, it is appropriate to suggest that rather than thinking about particular objective events that cause conflicts to escalate, we ought to be thinking about the *interpretations* of such events that are associated with escalation and those that are not.[30]

Psychocultural interpretations are found in the stories parties recount about past experiences, present difficulties, and future aspirations. These accounts are valuable for revealing how participants think about and characterize their political worlds. In fact, as we listen to them it is important to consider the extent to which stories from different groups or factions differ without necessarily directly contradicting each other, as each selects key events in its effort to gain supporters and to make sense of its actual experience (Scott 1985).[31]

This can be seen vividly in stories about long-standing ethnic conflicts that contain the culturally rooted aspirations, challenges, and deepest fears of communities. Volkan (1988) uses the term "chosen trauma" to refer to a specific experience that comes to symbolize a group's deepest threats and fears through feelings of helplessness and victimization (1991: 13). Volkan and his collaborators provide many examples of such events including the Turkish slaughter of Armenians, the Nazi holocaust, the experience of slavery and segregation for African Americans, and the Serbian defeat at Kosovo by the Turks in 1389.[32] If a group feels too humiliated, angry or helpless to mourn the losses suffered in the trauma, Volkan suggests that it then incorporates the emotional meaning of the traumatic event into its identity and passes on the emotional and symbolic meaning from generation to generation.[33] In escalating intergroup conflicts, the key metaphors, such as the chosen trauma, serve both as a rallying point and as a way to make sense of events that evoke deep fears and threats to existence (Horowitz

[30]While there is no room to develop the point here, it is important to understand that in contemporary society, the media become politically significant as creators and interpreters of events (Dayan and Katz 1992: 83).

[31]For example in Northern Ireland, Protestant Unionists find great meaning in the story of William of Orange and the Battle of the Boyne in 1689, while Catholic accounts really say little about King Billy or the battle. In contrast, Catholic Nationalists emphasize the meaning of the 1916 Easter Uprising, which for Protestants is far less significant than their sacred pact committing themselves to resist Irish self-rule four years earlier. Even when an event enters into the stories of both sides, such as the Hunger Strikes of Nationalist prisoners in 1980–81, the metaphors and meanings associated with them can be so different that it is hard to realize one is hearing about the same events in two different ways.

[32]See the special issue of *Mind and Human Interaction* (1992) devoted to the question of ethnic and nationalistic traumas, and Volkan (1996) for a discussion of the meaning of Kosovo for Serbs.

[33]The flip side is the *chosen glory* in which a group perceives triumph over the enemy; this is seen clearly in the Northern Irish Protestant celebration of the Battle of the Boyne in 1689 every July 12 (Cecil 1993).

1985; Kelman 1978; 1987). Only when the deep-seated threats these stories represent are addressed, he suggests, is a community able to begin to formulate a more peaceful future with its enemies.

Psychocultural interpretations reflect but also strengthen the boundary between in-groups and out-groups. The process of telling and listening to – validating[34] if you will – stories of past traumas and glories strengthens the link between individual and group identity and emphasizes how threats to the group are also threats to individual group members. In long-term intransigent conflict, strong threats to identity are an essential part of the conflict dynamic, and any efforts to defuse such a situation must take seriously the stories that participants recount, and the perceived threats to identity. The point, after all, is not whether participants' accounts are true or false from some objective point of view but that they are meaningful to the parties involved.

Interpretations play a central role in the construction of ethnic and national identities (Anderson 1991; Brubaker 1996; Gellner 1983; Hobsbawm and Ranger 1983; Smith 1986; Tambiah 1986). The examination of interpretations over time is a tool for understanding the contested nature of history and for discerning how one account comes to be accepted as "what really happened" while other plausible stories of the past are rejected. Interpretations of the past are found in how people talk and write about it but are also found in the public rituals and myths built around key events in the national (or ethnic) past. The rituals and myths are significant because of the meanings and metaphors surrounding a group's history that they communicate and reinforce, and because of the political mobilizing potential they have in the hands of political entrepreneurs.

Interpretations As a Methodological Tool

At the core of cultural analyses of politics are people's accounts of their daily worlds. Comparative researchers of all persuasions easily recognize many of the forms in which such accounts appear, such as formal written materials, historical documents, public discourse, government records, law cases, systematic observations, and survey data. In addition, the rich accounts often needed in cultural analysis can only be obtained through ethnographic field research (Laitin 1988; Ross and Ross 1974); in-depth interviews and life histories; structured interviews; extended case analysis of trouble cases; popular culture (Merelman 1991); and public and semipublic myths and rituals. Certainly the process analysis Migdal, Tarrow, and Zuckerman all advocate in their chapters (this volume) is central to cultural analysis with its emphasis on interpretations.

The central goal of the culture as a meaning and identity perspective is to understand from the point of view of actors in a particular context why certain

[34]What is validated is the meaning of a story to participants on each side. This does not necessarily mean the acceptance of such accounts as accurate. The notion of empathy is useful here. It suggests an acceptance of the account as meaningful to the recounter without necessarily implying agreement on the part of the listener.

actions are undertaken and others are not. What this entails is developing a plausible account – and in the process examining rival accounts of action and showing why they are not as good. There can be a huge gap, however, between the elements in the stories actors offer and how a comparativist understands political action, just as there is a great difference between the content of a patient's dreams and the psychoanalyst's interpretation of how the elements fit together and the dreams' overall significance. Bridging the two requires calling on cultural understandings and building interpretations that both make sense to cultural insiders and can be appreciated by outsiders.[35]

With a few rare exceptions, the most successful work linking culture and politics will not rely on only one source of data or a single tool for data analysis. Our most interesting theories are complex and highly contingent and cannot be simply accepted or rejected on the basis of one crucial piece of evidence, as is the case in some natural sciences. Instead, we need to obtain areas of convergence between independent data collected using a wide range of methods in order to have confidence in a set of findings, as Campbell and Fiske (1959) advocated. Exclusive reliance on one type of data to study the interplay of culture and politics, as is found in some survey researchers such as Inglehart (1988), inevitably produces a thin, almost content-free sense of culture and points to few dynamics of how culture produces the political effects it does. Instead, a more useful approach is one such as Scott's (1985) or Laitin's (1986; 1995a) in which a range of evidence is marshaled to explain a phenomenon that is not self-evident: the presence of everyday, but not overt, resistance among third-world peasants; the absence of bitter conflict between Christians and Moslems in western Nigeria; or why in Spain, the Basque revival has been violent while under very similar circumstances, the Catalonian one was not. Another successful instance of bringing together a range of data is Merelman's (1991) comparison of liberal democratic cultures in the United States, Britain, and Canada, which analyzes television programs, corporate publications, textbooks, and magazine ads along with survey data.

CONCLUSION

Culture is a worldview offering a shared account of action and its meaning and providing people with social and political identities; it is manifested in a way of life transmitted (with changes and modifications) over time, and embodied in a community's institutions, values, and behavioral regularities. Politics, I have argued, occurs in a cultural context that links individual and collective identities,

[35]Carol Hager (personal communication) suggests that critical theory provides a set of guidelines for the empirical study of interpretations in political research with its attention to communication processes and concerns with the problems of mediating between a researcher's own interpretations and those of the people being studied.

defines the boundaries between groups and organized actions within and between them, provides a framework for interpreting the actions and motives of others, and provides resources for political organization and mobilization. Cultural accounts of politics emphasize how, through shared intersubjective meanings, actors understand and act in their daily worlds. Beginning with context-dependent accounts – worldviews – cultural analysis constructs plausible interpretations of political life that both seem reasonable to local actors and make sense to outsiders.[36]

I have argued for a "strong" view of culture and against the notion that it can be more simply approached in terms of specific values that people in a community hold. In fact, the significance of the presence or absence of consensus on any single item is often unclear without an analysis of the context. Culture as a system of meaning is not at all incompatible with strong disagreement on particular attitudes (Laitin 1988), and it is often those points of disagreement that are of real political significance and shed light on "tough" problems facing a society. For example, the bitter divisions in some European countries over questions such as the treatment of immigrants or further European political or economic integration are powerful points of tension involving complicated, alternative cultural constructions of what it means to be French or German or British. As a result, a cultural analysis might utilize survey data to document the nature of divisions in a country on these questions, but it would go a good deal further, trying to make sense of why and how they are important to people, the connections between these issues and political and personal identity, and the significance of bitterly contested political meanings and actions within a common cultural framework.

In principle, cultural analysis can enhance our understanding of politics in a number of domains. McAdam, Tarrow, and Tilly (this volume) describe important cultural contributions in the field of contentious politics and offer a model of how structural, interest, and cultural perspectives can complement each other in explaining significant political phenomena. Seeing social movements as both carriers and makers of meaning, they suggest, enriches older, more developed structural and resource mobilization perspectives. Cultural analyses emphasize framing of action and increase our understanding of the definition of political opportunities and the repertoires of action that are found in different settings. A focus on narrative structuring and symbolic politics expands our capacity to explain collective action in terms of changing preferences, changing identities, and changing responses to resources (Brysk 1995: 567)

[36]The issue of how local actors react to an interpretation has several components. One is the extent to which they or the social scientist have provided it. If it is the latter, to what extent do they see it as plausible? Another issue is how local actors react to a social scientist's interpretation. For example, Nancy Scheper-Hughes (1982: v-xi), writing about the severe personal and social dysfunctionality associated with the very high rates of schizophrenia in rural Ireland, reports how upset villagers were with her book describing this pattern. Interestingly, they didn't say she was wrong; rather, they chastised her for making public what were regarded locally as private matters.

Attention to culture would certainly address one of the most widely cited weaknesses of rational choice theory, its inattention to context-specific interests and cross-cultural differences in how interests are conceptualized and articulated. More broadly, political economy might be an area that would benefit from more explicit attention to cultural questions, as Hall (this volume) suggests. For example, political economists have long documented differences in equality of resource distribution across countries, noting places like Scandinavia and Sri Lanka where inequalities are relatively low. While there is a certain amount of lip service paid to "cultural differences" in these cases, a more profound analysis would inquire into cultural conceptions of social justice, linked fate, and perhaps the relationship between the individual and the collectivity. Similarly, there are probably strong cultural factors involved in explaining cross-national differences in the locus of decision making and control over the economy. Where economic theory would emphasize efficiency, it may be that culture is much more salient in determining not only how a country resolves such an issue but also how it implements economic and political programs.

Political institutions are another obvious candidate for more culturally oriented research, although such studies are certainly not totally absent. Many students of American legislatures, for example, have found culture particularly helpful in explaining their internal operation (Matthews 1962; Muir 1982). The "folkways" of the U. S. Senate that Matthews identifies to explain its functioning in the 1950s are both specific norms affecting any individual senator's behavior and also a system that cannot simply be understood in terms of its individual elements or the degree to which any senator thinks a particular norm is appropriate. Similarly, as Crozier (1964) demonstrated so effectively, culture can shape the behavior of both public and private bureaucracies, and a cultural model sharply contrasts with explanations derived from a more universal, rational-actor, bureaucratic routinization model.

Finally, conflict is cultural behavior, since culture shapes what people fight about, how they fight, with whom they fight, and how the conflict ends (Avruch 1991; Ross 1993b). Both group goals and group actions are linked to cultural notions of appropriate behavior in the development and pursuit of goals. As a result, culturally shared rules can guide behavior even in the absence of strong institutions to enforce them. Conflict involves both the pursuit of culturally defined competing interests and the parties' divergent interpretations and threats to identity. These interpretations offer alternative metaphors about what is at stake in a conflict and the intensity of the dispute. Only when we examine the cultural meanings from the point of view of the participants can we make sense of why any conflict took the particular course it did.

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4

STRUCTURE AND CONFIGURATION IN COMPARATIVE POLITICS

Ira Katznelson

By 1968, the year *Comparative Politics* was founded, the subfield had begun to change beyond recognition. The new journal marked, and sought to promote, this transition by promising to advance comparative politics as a constitutive part of behavioral political science. Taking note of the "reorientation of the discipline" since the Second World War, the editors explained they were motivated to transcend the older "country-by-country approach whose conclusions are discrete rather than cumulative." Announcing "skepticism about the value of institutional and legal analysis," they bemoaned the insufficient application of "the scientific method" and the neglect of such analytical tools as structural functionalism and political systems analysis and of such concepts as consensus, role, and socialization (Brown, Herz, and Rogow 1968: 1).

In 1986, *Studies in American Political Development,* a journal devoted to "the revival of scholarship on American institutions and the related turn by political scientists to history," arrived on the scene. The inaugural issue's preface explained that history is "the natural proving ground for the claim that institutions have an independent and formative influence on politics" and that history also "provides the dimension necessary for understanding institutions as they operate under varying conditions" (Orren and Skowronek 1986, vii). With the exception of this last phrase, there was no explicit mention of what was, in effect, the journal's central goal: to promote constructions of the American case via the pathway of historical institutionalism as a unit in the study of comparative politics. Long segregated as if epistemologically distinctive, American political studies, the editors clearly hoped, now would become part of a broader comparative enterprise. Though there

had been important exceptions such as the deployment of the United States as one of the five cases in Almond and Verba's analytic study of political culture and chapters by Huntington on America's Tudor polity and by Hollingsworth on American political development in the last volume of the Comparative Politics series, by and large the American case had been excised from the universe of comparative political studies (Almond and Verba 1963; Huntington 1968; Hollingsworth 1978). After all, most students of American politics at least tacitly accepted as givens Hartz's portrait of liberal nondevelopment and "the relative statelessness of the United States" (Hartz 1955; Nettl 1968: 561).

But the editors of *Studies* did not seek to affiliate with the variable-centered comparative politics of the earlier journal. As their own work made clear (especially Skowronek's *Building a New American State,* which had demonstrated a close affinity with the state-centered project of the Social Science Research Committee on States and Social Structures) and as the title of the new publication itself signified (deliberately echoing, one assumes, the name "Studies in Political Development" of the nine-volume series sponsored from the early 1960s to the mid-1970s by the earlier SSRC Committee on Comparative Politics), the editors were particularly drawn to a more structural, historical, and macroanalytical style of comparative politics capable of discerning and explaining regime characteristics and jumbo changes, the kind of historical macroanalysis Charles Tilly was then calling "big structures, large processes, huge comparisons" (Tilly 1984). Equally clear was the editors' desire to reestablish political, especially state, structures and institutions at the center of research.

This influential attempt to cross subdisciplinary boundaries had rather more in mind than the behavioral revolution in comparative politics, especially when it was clothed in antiinstitutionalist garb. If the editors of *Comparative Politics* saluted "the ready availability of a stock of analytic categories developed primarily by sociologists" (Brown, Herz, and Rogow 1968: 1), the editors of *Studies,* looked mainly to a different sociological lineage. During the 1960s and 1970s, a remarkable group of audacious comparative-historical investigations, mainly written by political sociologists who grounded their work in the structural, historical, and organizational materialism of Karl Marx and Max Weber, constituted a research program and convened a bounded epistemic conversation that utterly had transformed the potential scope, ambition, and content of comparative politics. Turning the study of postfeudal modernity away from the realms of description and metaphysics, the treatments of immense historical change by scholars including Perry Anderson, Reinhard Bendix, Shmuel Eisenstadt, Samuel Huntington, Barrington Moore, Stein Rokkan, Theda Skocpol, Charles Tilly, Louise Tilly, and Immanuel Wallerstein, for all their considerable differences of theoretical genealogy and emphasis,[1] shared in the effort to elaborate on those locations where large-scale processes (including differentiation, state-building, war, capitalism, industrialization, urbanization, and cross-border flows of ideas, people, capital, and goods) and institutions (understood both as congeries of rules for cooperation, commitment, and conflict resolution and as formal organizations) actually meet (Anderson 1974a, 1974b; Bendix 1964, 1978; Moore 1966; Rokkan 1970; Skocpol 1979; Tilly, Tilly and Tilly 1975; Wallerstein 1974). Though hardly unitary in theoretical terms, the main contributors to this effort did promote a broadly common mode of structural and macroanalytical inquiry combining ontological and methodological commitments geared to account for the origins and character of postfeudal modernity and to the specification of macrofoundations for human action and social change.

[1]Their work was influenced by and overlapped in a nontrivial way with the more behavioral and process-oriented projects of *Comparative Politics* and the publications of the SSRC Committee on Comparative Politics; but their conceptual orientation, analytical foci, and ways of working nonetheless were distinctive.

The power of this body of work derived from its rejection of the main alternatives in the more than century-old debate between methodological collectivists, whose favorite term is society, and methodological individualists, whose preferred locution is action. The macroanalytical turn of the 1960s and 1970s spurned both frames as inadequate to the problem of ontology. They refused "society" in the sense associated with (overly simple) readings of Durkheim: as a distinct, unitary, comprehensive, integrated, lawful patterning of social relationships and cultural understandings contained inside defined spatial borders that overweeningly limit individual cognition and behavior. They insisted, by contrast, that social life and action in particular places is shaped by processes, relationships, and forms of interaction whose scale is both greater (as in global trade or the cross-border circulation of ideas) and lesser (as in patterns of kinship or regional cultures) than any single societal container can hold. In turn, they resisted the decomposition of social relations and processes into a congeries of undersocialized individuals whose cognition and choice motors their behavior without a consideration of how structured and relational situations constrain and enable human action.[2]

Instead, the macroanalytical scholars developed a probabilistic approach to structure, wagering that the most significant processes shaping human identities, interests, and interaction are such large-scale features of modernity as capitalist development, market rationality, state-building, secularization, political and scientific revolution, and the acceleration of instruments for the communication and diffusion of ideas (Daston 1988; Hacking 1990). "Society" in this orientation is replaced by the structured concatenation of processes. These, while not determinant of behavior in any strict sense, establish in specific times and places a calculus of cognitive and behavioral probabilities by creating situational orders within which individuals think, interact, and choose. Persons, in this view, are embedded agents operating within relational structural fields that distinguish the possible from the impossible and the likely from the less likely.

[2]Put differently, they refused the choice between sociological and economic theory Brian Barry so incisively posed in *Sociologists, Economists, and Democracy* (1970).

The ambitions, achievements, and advantages of structurally directed macroanalysis based in these conceptual orientations clearly inspired the new Americanist initiative. But not without a degree of irony concerning timing or a touch of credulousness regarding epistemology and method. After all, not many years later when Princeton's Center for International Studies gathered a group of leading comparativists to consider "The Role of Theory in Comparative Politics" (Kohli et al. 1995),[3] the capacity of this kind of macroanalysis to define the commanding heights at the center of the enterprise had come into question. The symposium's main problem was defined, as Peter Evans put it, by whether the "center that has constituted the traditional core of the study of comparative politics is in danger of being overrun" (Kohli et al. 1995: 2) by two assertive initiatives, each apparently unfriendly to the field's structural, historical, and institutional legacy: the strong methodological individualism of rational choice theory imported from microeconomics and game theory; and the postmodern turn to signification that called the field's organizational and social structural materialism into question and, even more radically, debunked causal accounts as pseudoscience. At just the moment some Americanists sought to associate their scholarship with comparative historical and institutional analysis, the theoretical energy in comparative politics was being seized, or at least claimed, by just those scholarly trajectories that had already achieved a good deal of effect within American studies, both in the social sciences and the humanities. Though the large majority of publications in comparative politics continues to be located between the poles of choice theory deductivism and antiscience interpretivism, the energy, imagination, and leadership deployed by the macroanalytical orientation in the 1960s and 1970s have dissipated to a considerable degree. Even the most novel and interesting recent works in this genre – such as Silberman's epic comparison of the rise of rational bureaucratic states in the nineteenth century, de Swaan's innovative consideration of the rise of modern welfare states (both of which incorporate the United States in their comparative ken), Downing's return to Moore's themes of the origins of democracy and dictatorship via a consideration of alternative medieval configurations and military modernization in early modern Europe, Ertman's rich but parsimonious account of variations to state-building in medieval and early modern Europe, and Luebbert's coalitional analysis of the origins of liberal, social democratic, and fascist regimes in interwar twentieth-century Europe – have attracted far less attention and have proved to date a good deal less influential than the books of the earlier generation (de Swaan 1988; Downing 1992; Ertman, 1997; Luebbert 1991; Silberman 1993). Yet just these texts, considered together with key works written under the rubric of American political development (Bensel 1990; Skocpol 1992; Skowronek 1993), actually promise step-wise advances to macroanalysis and an integration of this tradition with more finely focused scholarship by historical institutionalists. Their relative advantage lies in their combination of the kind of configurative macroanalysis pioneered by Moore with the deployment of institutions as middle-level mediations between large-scale processes and the microdynamics of agency and action (Tarrow 1987).

[3]The meetings took place during 1993–94.

Put differently, though I identify with the new historical institutionalism which mainly has focused on comparative interest representation, public policy, and political economy and has been the most visible successor to the grand macroanalytical scholarship of the 1960s and 1970s, I want to push back against what I think has been its not an entirely welcome substantive and conceptual retrenchment. Compared to the work of their predecessors, institutionalist scholars in comparative politics have shortened their time horizons, contracted their regime questions, and narrowed the range of considered outcomes. Such a constriction, of course, is not necessarily a bad thing. The comparative historical analysis of how transactions between states and citizens and between states and economies are contingently shaped within specific assemblages of institutional legacies and arrangements (Hall 1986; Immergut 1992; Pierson 1994; Samuels 1994; and Steinmo 1993) has successfully turned policy studies away from the mundane and aseptic temptations of the overly technocratic and ahistorical policy sciences and has effectively linked empirical work to basic normative questions in the liberal tradition, above all those concerned with interest representation (Berger 1981; Schmitter and Lehmbruch 1979). The focus in these studies has turned to the manner in which the contours of institutions shape the formation and aggregation of individual and group interests as an alternative both to less mediated versions of marxist class analysis that hinge on expectations of an ineluctable shift from classes in themselves to classes for themselves and to simple behavioral stories about how action makes preferences evident and how private preferences add up to a public edifice. Unlike the postpositivist impulse of postmodernism, historical institutionalism has refused to reduce reality to signification; and unlike rational choice, it has disallowed the reduction of agency to effectively utilitarian individuals in worlds where both the content and means of rationality vary by organizational, cultural, and historical configurations.

However, whereas both rational choice and postmodernism pose insurgent alternatives to mainstream practices in comparative politics, smaller-scale historical institutionalism has proved stronger as a skeptical response to their respective atomistic and anything-goes orientations and has functioned more effectively as a motivating and persuasive, though underspecified, set of claims that institutions and history matter than as a sharply etched project of the kind the earlier and more adventurous macroanalytical scholarship appeared to propel (Immergut 1996; Koelble 1995; Robertson 1993; Steinmo, Thelen, and Longstreth 1992). In some measure, this is the healthy result of taking another look at the implicit assumptions embedded inside marxist, and marxisant, historical materialism. It also is the consequence of shifting attention from extraordinary moments of regime creation and transformation to the routinized contours of normal politics in different democratic capitalist regimes. But this relocation runs the risk of detaching the two kinds of enterprises and of recusing historical-institutional work from its more assertive ambitions to create not only a historically grounded social science but a social science history capable of working with, and exploiting, the tensions inherent in their joining.

The relative empirical and theoretical restraint of recent comparative historical institutionalism has been characterized by a cautious construction of comparable cases, a continuing reliance on John Stuart Mill's method of agreement and method difference (Hammel 1980; Mill 1852; Skocpol and Somers 1980),[4] a reduction in historical sweep, and a certain disconnection with the grand macroanalytical tradition. The result has been something of a loss to the élan and potential of comparative politics, especially at the core of the enterprise. The Princeton symposium, after all, reaffirmed that what Evans called "work that draws on general theories wherever it can but also cares deeply about particular historical outcomes" and what Katzenstein described as the "thick" version of the new institutionalism "concerned with both states *and* social structures" which "looks at social sectors, political coalitions, political institutions, and ideological constraints," remains at the very heart of the most compelling efforts in the field. In her spirited defense of this "middle way," Skocpol regretted that as compared to rational choice theorists and postmodernists, "those of us who do comparative-historical social science often do not explain adequately ... the methods we use for investigation and for the presentation of results." In particular, she had in mind the connection between analytical choices and the construction of narratives as well as the manufacture of cases to make them susceptible to systematic comparison, whether empirical or counterfactual (Kohli et al. 1995: 4, 12, 44). In part, she thus claimed, the crisis of macroanalysis is a crisis of poor exposition.

Would this were so. This defensive posture is reminiscent of politicians who blame their lack of public standing on failures of communication. The slippage of historical macroanalysis from its critical hegemonic positioning in the 1970s is, rather, more the result of a certain lack of theoretical and methodological self-consciousness and clarity especially at a time when marxism, which in fact had done much of the intellectual work for macroanalysis, has been called into question by global events and by challenges to its essentialism, functionalism, and teleology. Marxism's integrated material, historical, and macroanalytical account of epochal change in western history; its analysis of the logic and dynamics of class structures and modern capitalism; and its attempts at holistic social theory capable of inventing causal stories about specific capitalist societies understood in their entirety and not just as economies in fact, had provided (either as a goad or in some cases as a foil) the main themes, tools, and motors for the earlier macroanalysis, much of which had taken the form of extending or revising classical marxism's hierarchical delineation of structures, processes, identities, and interests. Divorced from these resources and the analytical work they had performed, and in the absence of comparable, content-rich, structural theory, the less well-specified orientation of historical institutionalism has come to bear more theoretical weight than it can be expected to hold. As a consequence, today's historical-institutional scholarship confronts choice theory and postmodernism as dual threats rather than as sets of useful tools and criticisms it might confidently engage, appropriate, and incorporate.

[4]Skocpol and Somers' rich essay fails to remember that Mill not only proposed methods of agreement and difference but also of residues and concomitant variation, to which I return below. His work also contains an illuminating discussion of a plurality of causes to similar outcomes.

The result has been an unfortunate, and unnecessary, abdication. This essay takes up a number of key problems that must be addressed if structural macroanalysis is to reclaim its place at the core of comparative politics; not as what Evans describes as "an eclectic messy center" (Kohli et al. 1995: 4) but as a methodologically self-conscious research program.

The most important problem is that of cases and of comparison itself (Ragin and Becker 1992). "As I see it," Skocpol avers, "comparative politics people ... should *compare* – a startling idea! – and not simply study places in the world that are not America" (Kohli et al. 1995: 38). But compare what, and how, in light of the difficulties, even inappropriateness, of experimental and quasi-experimental designs given the small number of often deeply incommensurable cases with which we work? Comparativists have presented four principal answers to this question: what might be called the global or large-process, case-comparative, variable-comparative, and relational answers. The first, as in Wallerstein's work on the world system, Charles Tilly's and Hendrik Spruyt's competing accounts of European state-building, or Michael Mann's multivolume study of social power (Tilly 1990; Mann 1986, 1993; Spruyt 1994), endeavors to transcend the problem of cases by focusing on the larger relations and processes of which they are a part. The second seeks by a variety of more or less self-conscious efforts to justify the selection of cases and maneuver to overcome the problem of too many variables and too small an *N* by mustering soft versions of experimental and multivariate approaches, making particular cases place markers for variables (the United States for democracy or Nazi Germany for totalitarianism, for example) (Lipjhart 1971; Collier 1991). The third, by contrast, decomposes cases into variables that are analyzed and compared via a strong application of multivariate techniques (Barnes et al. 1979; Bartolini and Mair 1990; Dalton, Flanagan, and Beck 1984; Lipset, 1960, 1983; Lipset and Rokkan 1967). The fourth incorporates the gains of especially the first two inside what might be called a relational and configurative form of analysis. I proffer the advantages of such an approach, drawing primarily on the model of Tocqueville's *Democracy in America,* Weber's *The Methodology of the Social Sciences,* and a fresh look at Mill's *System of Logic* (Mill, 1852; Tocqueville 1966; Weber 1979). Configurative macroanalysis, I argue, can profit from the challenges of rational choice and postmodernism without sacrificing its distinctiveness; it can effectively deploy without overburdening the tools of historical institutionalism; and it can reclaim the normative dimension that both weberian and marxist theory placed, albeit differently, at the center of comparative political studies.

The core of the essay thus takes up issues central to this fourth approach. These include: the relationship of history and analytical social science; structural theory after marxism; the special status of the state; and the question of

behavioral and strategic microfoundations. The value of a configurative comparative politics can best be assayed, at least implicitly, against the counteroption considered, in effect, by the *World Politics* symposium: the colonization of comparative politics by the microanalytical and postpositivist currents increasingly important to mainstream studies of the United States, a prescription echoing the one tendered by the editors of *Comparative Politics* in 1968 who had sought to advance their subfield by making it a variant of American political studies.

THE MACROANALYTICAL HEYDAY AND ITS AFTERMATH: REMARKS ON MOORE AND SKOCPOL

The subject matter of the historical macroanalysis of the 1960s and 1970s was vast. It is not too much of an oversimplification, however, to observe that this body of work was animated by a main theme, a dominant problem, and a primary elaboration. The theme was the systematic and comparative charting of diverse trajectories from a premodern to the modern Eurocentric world fashioned between the sixteenth and nineteenth centuries and the implications of these routes for the formation of social classes and political regimes. The problem was the intertwining of state and class. The elaboration, as noted, was of marxist theory, in particular its consideration of class as history's motor and its focus on the problem of the transition from feudalism to capitalism.

The breakthrough book that transformed the objectives and aspirations of comparative historical macroanalysis undoubtedly was Barrington Moore's *Social Origins.* Though he began his comparative analysis of routes to modernity in Britain, France, the United States, China, Japan, and India with deceptively bland language – "In the effort to understand the history of a specific country a comparative perspective can lead to asking very useful and sometimes new questions. There are further advantages. Comparisons can serve as a rough negative check on accepted historical explanations. And a comparative approach may lead to new generalizations" – he set to sea fishing for a very large substantive and methodological catch (Moore 1966: xiii). His effort to chart three distinctive routes to the modern world (via bourgeois revolution, abortive revolution, and communist revolution) did far more than hold in tension "the detailed investigation of specific cases" and the attempt to construct generalizations resembling "a large-scale map of an extended terrain." It linked extraordinary moments to the subsequent contours of normal politics. It demonstrated how class analysis could unlock secrets of political regimes. It treated Asian and European cases drawn from the "developing" and "developed" worlds as comparable units of analysis. Though peopled by many kinds of agents, the book was motored primarily by structural relationships whose powerful logics shaped and constrained the identities, aspirations, and actions of the actors. It made normative questions about the role of the social sciences in quests for truth and for a less oppressive

world constitutive of its analytical questions. Moore's main goal, after all, was that of identifying the unusual braiding of circumstances capable of producing relatively free and decent versions of modernity (Moore 1965: xiv).[5]

The notion of "configuration" was located at the core of this effort. Moore aimed at "specifying configurations favorable and unfavorable to the establishment of modern western democracy" (Moore 1966: xiv). He did not slice and dice his cases into variables which themselves would be compared as if they were not enclosed and entwined inside cases of dense and distinctive complexity.[6] He considered each case with sufficient detail to stand alone as an analytically constructed, historically recognizable case study. Though deployed to a comparative purpose, each also was written as a coherent (and deliberately provocative) single-country investigation. Nor did Moore treat "revolution" and "class struggle" as processes independent of time and place. Rather, he constructed and deployed a limited repertoire of developmental configurations (Lasswell 1935)[7] as the means to avoid becoming hostage either to historical detail or to rather too simple stories about historical trajectories even with respect to complex questions of historical change on a very large scale. He achieved this goal by constructing his cases to show how each was dominated by a particular configuration of class, revolution, and political regime, yet how each also contained subordinate combinations and arrangements that became primary elsewhere. The product of a great and erudite mind working on a broad but bounded canvas, *Social Origins* advanced scientific inquiry by way of an aesthetic triumph.

It would not be easy to overstate the significance of this book. First, it demonstrated that the impulses of classical sociology and traditional moral and political theory to tame and make sense of large-scale social and historical change had not been destroyed by the overbearingly specialized and fragmented qualities of "normal" social science. Second, in no small tension with the volumes being produced by the Committee on Comparative Politics which focused "on conceptualizing political systems, identifying their universal functions, and describing the processes of political modernization and development" by parsing what it called "the developmental syndrome" into concepts (equality, capacity, differentiation) and crises (identity, legitimacy, participation, penetration, distribution), Moore's configurative orientation exhibited both more hubris and less

[5]The language of "truth" and "configuration" is Moore's.

[6]Thus avoiding the false science noted by Zolberg in his astringent remarks directed at the work of Lipset on working class formation ("Radicalism or Reformism"): "Albeit suggestive, Lipset's approach – shared by Rokkan as well – is marred by an attempt to apply multivariate techniques to macroanalytic materials and by the imprecise and questionable character of the variables themselves. The result is a historically ridiculous universe, in which pre–World War I Britain, Germany, France, and Russia are equated as having 'rigid' and largely 'feudal' patterns of social class, as against 'nonrigid' patterns in the United States, the Low Countries, and Switzerland; and in which Britain, where one cannot speak of a mass electorate before 1882, is equated with the United States as having achieved political citizenship 'early' while the Low Countries and Russia are equated as having done so 'late'" (Zolberg 1986: 450).

[7]Too rarely is credit given to Harold Lasswell for the notion of "developmental constructs" within a configurative social science.

(Pye 1971: vi-vii). More because his historical social science was leaner, wagering on fewer central variables; but less because he insisted on a tighter fit between concepts and situations. Third, the clearly marxist character of *Social Origins* was at odds not only with the main thrust of work by authors of the SSRC "Studies in Political Development" who had sought a conceptual/behavioral foundation for macroanalysis and who had underplayed the state as an institution in order to escape the arid formalism of early twentieth-century political science (which had taken a particularly desiccated character in the comparative study of "foreign governments"), but also with two other important currents: the realist and organizational weberian orientation such émigré scholars as Reinhard Bendix had brought to the task of analyzing early modern European state formation, and the market exchange models of power and participation increasingly dominant inside political sociology and political science at the time. The effect was to empower colleagues and students to emulate and promote the kind of enterprise Moore had pursued, to provide an alternative to mainstream approaches, and to convene a variety of efforts to build up and out from the edifice of *Social Origins*.

Though *Social Origins's* identification of multiple trajectories rather than a single pathway was not marxist in any orthodox sense, it remained embedded in a mode of production historical materialism. It broke neither with marxism's focus on class struggle as the basic datum of political life nor with its causal emphasis on economic rather than cultural, political, or ideational causes (Skocpol 1973). But like other key marxist works written in this structural and comparative macroanalytical vein – especially the volumes of Anderson and Wallerstein – Moore sought to connect a materialist class analysis to alternative types of states and regime outcomes. The considerable works of 1960s and 1970s historical macroanalysis thus sought to extend from marxism to what manifestly was, together with capitalism, the second great macroprocess of modernity, the creation and development of the sovereign state and the post-Westphalian system of sovereign states. Like another important current grounded in German realism, especially Hintze and Weber, represented most notably by Bendix's *Nation-Building and Citizenship,* the more dominant marxian work also came to grapple with the dualism Bendix identified (the "system is broken up by the twin revolutions of the West – the political and the industrial") and with the conjoining of problems of class and state he pursued ("In the emerging nation-states of Western Europe the critical political problem was whether and to what extent social protest would be accommodated through the extension of citizenship to the lower classes." (Bendix 1964: 67)).

But it was Theda Skocpol, first in a powerful critique of Moore written when she was his graduate student and then in her dissertation on comparative revolutions, who most successfully created a strong *structural* macroanalysis with one foot in marxian class inquiry and another in weberian state analysis. Her work displayed the virtues of structural macroanalysis in full efflorescence, yet its tilt away from agency also projected toward a subsequent narrowing, bifurcation, and dispersion of the comparative macroanalytical impulse. It was not so much *States and Social Revolutions* that produced this set of developments but the manner in which some of its core ideas and tendencies were followed up, not least by Skocpol herself. By contrast, as we shall see, the "polity-centered" perspective of her recent *Protecting Soldiers and Mothers,* a contribution to the effort inaugurated by *Studies in American Political Development,* helps point us toward a recrudescence of the macroanalytical impulse in a more configurative mode.[8]

The gist of Skocpol's spirited critique of Moore was the insistence that an autarchic marxism, however rich and elaborated, can take us only so far. She argued that Moore's emphasis on the structures and processes of class domination and relations left underspecified the political mechanisms any social class requires but which are not reducible to class interests and control. "Every property system, indeed every market," she wrote in a Polanyian vein, "requires political backing. The significant question to ask is not whether such support is present or absent, but rather *who controls the political mechanisms and how they are organized.*" (Italics in original.) Marxist political sociology, she insisted, too quickly conflates class interests and class capacities and treats as a closed rather than an open question whether state organizations and political leaders might not act against the interests of a given dominant class or mode of production. In short, without leaving class analysis behind, Skocpol sought to introduce the possibility of an independent state both in support of and in tension with class relations. Further, she sought to extend our span of attention beyond the boundaries of the nation–state itself. Unlike Moore, she insisted that modernization entails structural changes both to economic institutions and to integrative political ones, including bureaucracies and parties; and that "both occur under the impetus of foreign as well as domestic pressures." Unlike Bendix (and Huntington), she insisted that the potential autonomy of the political does not provide warrants for neglecting "the interrelationship or state institutions and class structures" or "class constraints on political elites' freedom of action." Yet unlike Wallerstein, who introduced the international dimension via the notion of a world system, she resisted the reduction of state forms and strength to the role they perform within the modern world capitalist class structure and division of labor (Skocpol 1973: 16, 30, 31).

In *States and Social Revolutions,* Skocpol sought to surpass her mentor in two main ways. Like Moore, her work stressed "a structural perspective, with special attention devoted to international contexts and to developments at home and abroad that affect the breakdown of state organizations of old regimes and the buildup of new, revolutionary state organizations." And like Moore, she stuck with the nation–state as her unit of analysis and treated historical agents as motivated rather unproblematically by their structural locations, thus eliding the issue of microfoundations as an independent problem. By contrast to Moore,

[8]Note that in his essay for this volume, Mark Lichbach deploys *States and Social Revolutions* as exemplary of structuralist analysis. For reasons I indicate below, I think Skocpol's recent work, particularly *Protecting Soldiers and Mothers,* better indicates the direction in which structural and configurative scholarship is, and should be, moving.

however, she argued that marxist class analysis is insufficient to account for outcomes and variations. Her strategy was additive. Turning for intellectual sustenance to the tradition of German realism and to contemporary scholarship on early modern European state-building and state theory (Nettl 1968; Tilly 1975), she developed a template for analysis that yoked marxist and weberian strands of theory together, insisting that marxists "face more directly the questions of what states are in their own right" by taking "the state seriously as a macro-structure." The state, she argued,

> Properly conceived is no mere arena in which socioeconomic struggles are fought out. It is, rather, a set of administrative, policing, and military organizations headed, and more or less well coordinated by, an executive authority. Any state first and fundamentally extracts resources from society and deploys these to create and support coercive and administrative organizations.

Unlike Moore, she insisted on the value added by this approach to states as macrostructures treated independently of their place in "abstractly conceived modes of production" or as "political aspects of concrete class relations and struggles" (Skocpol 1979: 28, 29).[9]

If a shift to the state in tandem with class analysis represented the first key revision to Moore's orientation, the second concerned a nuanced but significant alteration to the mix between "scientific" comparison and the place of distinctive historical instances. In a methodological paper she wrote with Margaret Somers just after the publication of *States and Social Revolutions,* Skocpol explained that three distinct logics of analysis and exposition were being deployed in comparative history: (1) the "parallel demonstration of theory" aiming to reveal how a general theory holds for diverse instances; (2) the "contrast of contexts" directed at showing how the particularity of cases affects and modifies more general social processes; and (3) "macro-causal analysis" which "uses comparative history primarily for the purpose of making causal inferences about macro-level structures and processes." She persuasively identified both her own book and Moore's with the third tendency, arguing that while they share a suspicion of theories that generalize at too great a remove from specific cases (implicitly recognizing that relations among variables cannot be consistent from case to case), they also seek to use historical comparisons as the means to test more general propositions and causal hypotheses about large-scale change. The method deployed to grapple with the tensions inherent in the relationship between such propositions and specific historical instances is that of a continuous oscillation "between alternative explanatory hypotheses and comparisons of relevant aspects of the histories of two or more cases" (Skocpol and Somers 1980: 175, 181, 182).

Though both efforts were located in this zone of macroanalysis, Skocpol argued that they differed in their relative emphasis on the scientific and the historical. Moore, she observed, was rather more interested in the "historical analysis of causal sequences specific to individual countries" than in reproducing in a qualitative mode the approach of multivariate analysis aimed at testing causal hypotheses about large-scale phenomena. By placing her work and Moore's in the same broad category, Skocpol avoided over-stressing their differences, but I believe, as she did, that these were important (though I draw different conclusions about their relative merits). Whereas Moore sought primarily to construct specific cases in their complexity as configurational historical constructs, Skocpol put more emphasis on distinguishing variables and their effects within specific cases. Deploying Mill's method of difference, she claimed it is possible to overcome the problem of lots of potential variables and a small number of comparable cases and thus achieve scientific status for macroanalysis. I believe this to be an instance of wishful thinking which, if pushed hard, inevitably produces distortions to the integrity of cases without achieving the vaunted goal of systematic social science.

To be sure, Skocpol's widening of the scope of historical macroanalysis to include modern states and state-building as potentially autonomous and constitutive domains of modernity conjointly with capitalism and class marked an important step beyond Moore's more autarchic if revisionist marxism, but her strong tilt in the direction of variable-testing promised a good deal more than macroanalysis can deliver persuasively. In seeking to move beyond configurative analysis of the type promoted by Moore, Skocpol soon sought in work focused on the comparative study of welfare states to affirm that state and state-related variables more powerfully account for interesting outcomes, including the success or failure of various policy initiatives by social groups and classes, than what she claimed are competing economy- or society-centered possibilities (Skocpol and Finegold 1982; Skocpol and Ikenberry 1983; Orloff and Skocpol 1984). When such stylized causal accounts actually are deployed, however, they do violence to the integrity of the cases by forcing an artificial choice between key factors, when what matters is the terms of the relationships governing their transactions. After all, no state-centered account can make sense of the presence or absence of social democratic outcomes unless it locates them in interaction with the dispositions and collective actions of groups and social classes just as, in turn, society-centered explanations cannot possibly be compelling if they avoid grappling with the specificity of the modern state. Unlike Moore, who approached his cases in their configurational complexity, Skocpol, especially after *States and Social Revolutions* but before her *Protecting Soldiers and Mothers,* labored to justify mannered alternatives between clusters of variables.

Her structural macroanalysis, like Moore's, advanced historical research well beyond the typical causal indistinctness of too many historical narratives, but her pursuit of a causal hierarchy elided the problem of microfoundations. Moore's marxism had solved this problem by theoretically specifying the important historical agents and by making their dispositions and preferences immanent to their positionality. Skocpol had rejected his privileging of class relations, but her

[9] At the core of this shift was her representation of the state as "Janus-faced, with an intrinsically dual-anchorage in class-divided socioeconomic structures and an international system of states" (Skocpol 1979: 32).

disapprobation was accompanied by an even more radical downplaying of the independent causal status of agents and agency. In stressing how structural relations place agency well beyond intentionality, she pushed limitations on voluntary action so far as to recommend that scholars should "emphasize objective relationships and conflicts among variously situated groups and nations, *rather than* the interests, outlooks, or ideologies of particular actors" (Skocpol 1979: 291; italics added). The resultant portrait of revolutions without revolutionaries not only left her macroanalysis without microfoundations virtually as a matter of principle, but it implied that there were no plausible alternative outcomes to those history had dealt, thus suggesting that history unfolds without human discretion and decision (Sewell 1985; Laitin and Warner 1992). When the main actors are structures and institutions rather than group or individual anthropological subjects, meaning, action, contingency, and negotiation, not to speak of the surprises of history, unfortunately recede (Trevor Roper 1980).

The best of the recent historical-institutional policy studies on health, taxation, labor relations, and other substantive arenas[10] has been premised on the three main moves Skocpol made when she revised Moore's legacy: the transcendence of a marxian materialism by a more cross-sectional and static organizational materialism; a very strong tilt in the direction of structure as an alternative to a focus on agency; and a shift from configurative comparative strategies to case comparative research strategies.[11] These shifts became the attributive grammar of the new scholarship, giving it coherence and power but also constraining its reach and range. For a more expansive configurative comparative politics to thrive again, albeit differently than for Moore, these three predicates must be reexamined. Any such review must begin with a consideration of the degree of theoretical conceit with regard to history appropriate to historically oriented social science.

REVIVING MACROANALYSIS: HISTORY AND THEORY, STRUCTURE AND CONFIGURATION

To simplify: For behaviorists, history is variable-specific and variable driven. It is imagined as sets of time-series. The materials on which they work are long-term data sets of opinion, war, voting, and the like (Page and Shapiro 1992). For rational choice theorists, history provides material with which to illustrate the capacity of deductive theory and it provides targets of explanation based on a small number of axiomatic assumptions about human motivation, the possession of in-

[10]Much of this scholarship has been written by Skocpol's students, coauthors, and close colleagues.

[11]Inside Perry Anderson's *Lineages,* we can see at work a contrast between an exclusively structuralist macroanalysis and a configurative, process-orientated marcroanalysis. His treatment of Eastern Europe is entirely structuralist in contrast to the more configurational treatment of Western Europe (Anderson 1974a).

formation, and the patterning of interactions under conditions of scarcity. It also becomes an object of explanation shaped by the play of actors seeking to efficiently secure preferences and by the endogenous creation of institutions as byproducts of this action under conditions of strategic interdependence.[12] For postmodernists, history, though lacking an architecture or a telos, presents multiple sites of repression and resistance best understood in terms of the constant flux of identity formation and reformation (Mitchell 1988).

Historical macroanalysts have no a priori grounds on which to rule out any of these moves as ways of illuminating human structures and agency, but they are suspicious of the degree of simplification required by each. History is more than context, raw material, or a site for the play of the microdynamics of power. As the protean record of the human experience, history's thick inexhaustibility defies the taming instincts of historians but especially those of social scientists. It should not surprise that for most historians gaining a kind of demonic control of sources and constructing narrative interpretations (even if the causal stories are murky) are the considerable achievements for which they strive. Social science in its various modes, by contrast, willfully distorts for the purpose of ascertaining patterns, meaning, and truth in history by deploying often timeless analytical tools and by asking theory- and concept-driven questions (Cohn 1980). Though their styles of knowledge creation vary enormously to include various strategies of experimental design, postulation, hypothetical modeling, probabilistic analysis, and historical derivation (Crombie 1994), social scientists share in common a tendency to shift between the mediation of history by strong theory and the mediation of strong history by concepts (Bonnell 1980).

Now it is possible to argue, as, say, the late sociologist Philip Abrams and the anthropologist John Comaroff have, that there ought to be no "relationship" between history and social science "since there should be no division to begin with"; that all social science is historical and all history to be explicable must be analyzed utilizing tools of social science; that, as Eric Hobsbawm has averred, "the social sciences are trivial unless they come to terms with ... the way men get their living and their material environment ... [and] their ideas, since their relations with one another are expressed and formulated in language which implies concepts as soon as they open their mouths." Comparative historical macroanalysts perforce have no choice but to agree with these various calls for the mutual constitution of history and social science because they know, as Hobsbawm has insisted, that a small number of principles are essential to this craft: History has chronology and thus must be concerned with what actually happened; the history of society consists of "specific units of people living together and definable in sociological terms"; and the researcher "must have a hierarchy of assumptions

[12]Thus, for example, Levi asserts as a hypothesis rather than as a conclusion based on the deployment of evidence that predatory motivations with regard to the extraction of revenue are characteristic of history's rulers, the chief executives of state institutions, in spite of enormous variation in time and place (Levi 1988: 3-4).

about what counts." The making of histories on these terms thus represents a "collaboration between general models of social structure and change and the specific set of phenomena which actually occurred" (Abrams 1982; Comaroff 1982: 144; Hobsbawm 1974: 4-5, 9-10).

Perhaps, in principle, there is, or should be, no distinction between history and social science because each is essential to the constitution of the other, but in practice this is far too simple and seductive an elision. For every effort to assert the absence of a distinction, there is another that can strongly argue for their incompatibility.[13] After all, there is a considerable divide distinguishing, say, histories of war from histories of specific wars. I think a third position is more compelling. Though separate, history and social science cannot be constituted meaningfully without each other; hence what matters is the *terms* of their inescapably tension-ridden connections. These cannot be fixed by rule. Necessarily they shift in aim and method depending on scales of time,[14] the character of cases, the content of concepts, and, above all, the level of explanatory ambition (Knapp 1990).

The configurative position does not lack assertive objectives, but these are tempered by the modesty history and its variety demand. At stake is a particular kind of narrativity: less than the metanarrativity of presuppositional narratives about such grand concepts as progress and enlightenment or such commanding but general processes as the creation of mass society and class struggle, but more than the emplotment of the many stories history offers up. Rather, a configurative macroanalysis aims at an analytical narrativity that deploys spatial and temporal concepts "to reconstruct and plot over time and space the ontological narratives and relationships of historical actors, the public and cultural narratives that inform their lives, and the crucial intersection of these narratives with other relevant social forces" (Somers 1992: 604-5). It is by the selection of tools for the construction of cases as analytical narratives that even single-country case studies become accessible to comparison. This consideration requires that case research be informed by an explicitly posed analytical agenda that can be applied to interrogate quite distinctive instances with the goal not of flattening but of illuminating differences. But it also stipulates a deeply inductive approach to inquiry as the

[13]When this kind of effort by some historians goes to excess, a battle for objectivity can ensue. Though we have become used to social scientists claiming the mantle of objectivity against the more slack mode of interpretation by historians, it is worth remembering these shoes can fit on other feet. Thus, in his inaugural lecture as Regius Professor of History at Cambridge University, Geoffrey Elton observed and exhorted, "But we, as historians, do not write history for the use of the moment; we are guardians and distributors of the truths of history and should at least try to make sure that when current partisans plunder history for their own purposes they have a non-partisan and real history to stand over them." To make clear who these partisans were, he promptly inveighed against the very practice of social science (Elton 1984).

[14]On history and time, Koselleck has "tried to show historiographically that temporalization was at the beginning of modern history which today is being studied from a historical angle with regard to general change ... theoretically that we depend on the distinction between different time levels in order to be able to work within social history ... [and that] historical time itself can be made empirically transparent" (Koselleck 1982: 126).

tools deployed to examine cases stick close to the ground while seeking to explain big events and cognate developments without being concerned as a main focus with the production of cross-case generalizations. The heuristics of comparison, from this perspective, are vital to the practice of a configurative social science rightly skeptical about too many regularities of motivation and action.

The greatest instance of such an effort remains the pioneer structural-configurative text, Tocqueville's *Democracy in America.* This remarkable analytical narrative treats the United States both as a complex configuration of elements and as an elaboration of the archetype of equality as the dominant model for the future more generally. America is treated simultaneously as a highly distinctive, even exceptional constellation of elements, yet also as a harbinger of things to come. Though the United States is Tocqueville's only case, it always is constructed against empirical (especially French) and conceptual counterfactuals. Further, the United States is situated in place and time not as a hermetically sealed "case" but as a relationally inscribed instance in three senses: First, its own history and special qualities of institutions, values, and demography are composed in relationship to the experiences of other countries and to global flows of information, ideology, and people. Second, its development is situated in relation to larger trends and processes that affect the modern, western world more generally, especially those of social and political equalization. Third, America, as the first egalitarian regime for white males, is presented as the most important cause shaping the prospects, choices, and trajectories of other countries by way of the effects of a visible demonstration.

Though *Democracy in America* contains a strong causal story about liberal and egalitarian political culture and the construction of particular kinds of agents and their associational ties under determinate structural conditions, it also underscores variation and complexity, especially with respect to questions of race and the confrontation of civilizations. The text carefully distinguishes levels of causation – those specific and limited to the American milieu; those shared broadly by the larger thrust toward social equality and the movement of masses into politics; and those of political culture deeply imbricated with the patterning of institutions like the law, religion, the press, and secular voluntary associations. Throughout, individual and group dispositions and collective actions are shaped by and reshape large-scale structural and ideological arrangements and trends. Human nature is not fixed either as benevolent or as interest-seeking; rather, human behavior is conditioned on the structural and institutional shaping of values and mores which, in turn, remake contextual conditions for action. Structures and actors make democracy and democracy remakes structures and actors. Motivated by broadly liberal values and fears in a revolutionary world, Tocqueville combined classification and typological thinking with the dense historical, sociological, and political depiction of a single, complicated, dense case. He understood that out of context the factors deployed in his analysis would lose their relational quality; yet he insisted that a configurative study of the United States contained deeply comparative lessons. As Raymond Aron has noted, Tocqueville

"wanted to make history intelligible, but he did not want to do away with it," and he rejected vast and transhistorical syntheses which claimed either to tame or predict history's vagaries (Aron 1968: 232).

There is a close affinity between Tocqueville's mix of modesty and assertion and Max Weber's guidelines for historical configuration in the essay he published on objectivity in the social sciences on the occasion of the appearance of the new *Archiv fur Sozialwissenschaft und Sozialpolitik,* which he edited. Social science, he argued, should aim to construct situations so that individuals can ascertain the possible, either in the past or the present; that is, what they or other actors can, as opposed to what they must, do. This orientation, like Stretton's later restatement of it, considers ethical imperatives not as independent motivators or explanations but as only operative inside determinate situations analytically ordered by social and political analysts who reveal "constellations of norms, institutions, etc." (Weber 1979: 64) by focusing on the conceptually organized interconnections of elements in conjunction with narratives of events. Understanding that our values condition our interest in particular problems and in specific analytical narratives, Weber argued the case for a configurative macroanalysis. Such a social science, he wrote,

> seeks to transcend the purely *formal* treatment of the legal or conventional norms regulating social life. The type of social science in which we are interested is an *empirical science* of concrete *reality (Wirklichkeitswissenschaft).* Our aim is the understanding of the characteristic uniqueness of the reality in which we move. We wish to understand on the other hand the relationships and the cultural significance of individual events in their contemporary manifestation and on the other the causes of their being historically *so* and not *otherwise*.... It too concerns itself with the question of the *individual* consequence which the working of these "laws" in an unique *configuration* produces, since it is these individual configurations which are *significant* for us. Every individual constellation which it "explains" or predicts is causally explicable only as the consequence of another equally individual constellation which has preceded it. As far back as we may go into the grey mist of the far-off past, the reality to which the laws apply always remains equally *individual,* equally *undeducible* from laws (Weber 1979: 72; italics in original).

The approaches of Tocqueville and Weber to which I am partial cannot be contained within the methods of agreement and difference proposed by John Stuart Mill, for under the conditions of comparing large and complex instances these cannot satisfy conditions of proof or discovery. Indeed, we would do well to recall that Mill himself introduced two "elements of complexity" into his attempt to turn qualitative analysis into an experimental method. The first of these was what he called the "Method of Residues" which understands that any specific situation in which factors interconnect in a constellation can only be apprehended by understanding its often tacit and sometimes hidden presumptions and antecedents. This method, he insisted, though inevitably uncertain as to the surety of its claims, "is the most fertile in unexpected results; often informing us of sequences in which neither the cause nor the effect were [sic] sufficiently conspicuous to attract themselves to the attention of observers" (Mill 1852: 230). Louis Hartz's contentious claim about the hidden but powerful status of liberalism in the American experience took just this form (Hartz 1955).

Even more significant was Mill's final move: an insistence on the significance of concomitant variation in specific historical constellations "because it by no means follows when two phenomena accompany each other in their variations, that the one is cause and the other effect" (Mill 1852: 233). Both may have a common antecedent cause and both may be mutually constitutive. Such situations, he points out, make it impossible to apply the method of difference; what matters is not the causal relation of variables in such circumstances but the configuration of the constellation of elements. Indeed, by way of a profound irony, it was the development of just those statistical tools in the nineteenth century that aimed to elucidate causal relations with certainty which, by introducing the notion of probability into social analysis, had the effect of shattering certainty and of making a configurative historical social science appealing, even compelling, especially in the face of our circumstances as analysts who are inside the very world for which we seek objective, though not neutral perspectives.

Read together, Tocqueville, Weber, and Mill point to a distinctive way of constructing cases for comparative analysis, focusing less on the causal importance of this or that variable contrasted with others but more on how variables are joined together in specific historical instances. They do so by wagering on key factors, deployed as ideal-types, in interaction with others, but not on ideal-types too distant from situations on the ground. Running the risk of selection bias (Lustick 1996), this orientation to comparison prefers ideal-types that are realist and concrete rather than nominalist and abstract, preferring theory to guide investigations, say, about Catholicism and Protestantism rather than religion or about class relations within capitalism rather than structures of inequality.

Unlike the approach to comparison that identifies a given case with a given type, in this approach cases are understood to be combinations of elements rather than manifestations of one or another theoretically derived instance in a typology. In Moore's work, for example, each country contains a hierarchical combination of ideal-types, and the definition and complexity of each case are shaped by the quality of their combinations.

The analytical narratives he composed were geared to establish the interconnections and play of these elements over time. None was freestanding. Each was the product of the trajectory of a nonrandom set of ties linking past, present, and future; each exists inside a larger pattern of trends and processes of which it is a part.

Utilizing a configurative compass with structural bearings to guide comparison points to and locates the significance of other modes of comparison. It situates cases inside the common elements stressed by the global or large-process point of departure. Its cases become names for analytically established categories that can be compared one to the other within a given epoch or at structurally

equivalent times. It can even borrow, albeit skeptically, from variable-centered research by carefully reembedding the results of multivariate analysis in order to test propositions in thick context.

The role of theory in such circumstances, Hugh Stretton has observed, "may thus be seen as an organization of possibilities." The kind of theory he advocates for historical case studies like *Protecting,* where strict verification is precluded by the nature of the material and by a refusal to parse it too finely into isolated variables, is the kind that "leaves open the question whether people are doing what people would invariably do in these uniquely complicated circumstances, or are doing one of the comparatively few things which people (usually free) choose to do in such circumstances" (Stretton 1969: 326-7, 215). The product of such theorizing is a social science of guarded generalizations in situations where there can be no true universal hypotheses and where the number of discrete factors and actors is too small for statistical statements to secure any purchase.

But theory, after the hegemony of marxism in macroanalytical scholarship, of what kind? Quite simply, we possess no full-blown equivalent either to classical marxism or to post-Gramscian twentieth-century neo-marxism; nor, in light of the limitations of any such inclusive, autarchic, and holistic theory should we seek to find a replica. But we also pay a steep price for its absence; how is it possible to minimize the costs? By availing ourselves, I think, of what might be called the strategies of oscillation and of raising the level of abstraction which I identify, respectively, with Albert Hirschman and Ralf Dahrendorf.

In his Marc Bloch lecture of 1982, Hirschman addressed competing interpretations focused on the economic and noneconomic dynamics of market societies. He contrasted four theses: the *doux commerce* argument focusing on the beneficent gentle and civilizing features of markets as tamers of passions; the self-destruction proposition stressing how market-capitalist societies necessarily undermine the moral foundations of society; the feudal shackles thesis claiming that remnants from the past undermine positive market features by making market penetration of society too incomplete; and a feudal blessings thesis stressing, as Louis Hartz did for the United States, the hazards attendant on having been deprived of a feudal past. These alternatives, Hirschman shows, have developed as intellectual constructs in near-total isolation from each other. He sought to bring them together, transcend the question of which one is right, and demonstrate that when this is done we can see they compose a coherent ideological tableau. "However incompatible the various theories may be," he argued, "each might still have its 'hour of truth' and/or its 'country of truth' as it applies in a given country or group of countries during some stretch of time." He claimed, further, that accounts of particular times and places are most powerful when they combine these elements and hold them in tension. Thus, Hirschman observed by way of an illustration, not only is it possible for the *doux commerce* and self-destruction theses to hold at the same moment, but by a strategy of configuration we can see that modern capitalist society simultaneously is self-reinforcing and self-undermining as its moral basis is consumed and filled up at the same time. In his rendering, the focus of analysis shifts from tests of the relative truth value of competing propositions to the analysis of how apparent alternatives delineate mutual relations. "An excess of depletion over replenishment and a consequent crisis of the system is then of course possible, but the special circumstances making for it would have to be noted, just as it might be possible to specify conditions under which the system would gain in cohesion and legitimacy." He concluded, "is it not in the interest of social science to embrace complexity, be it at some sacrifice of its claim to predictive power?" (Hirschman 1982: 1481, 1483) Within such an oscillatory approach, marxism would have a continuing role to play as the generator of hypotheses and as the basis for claims to privilege of the analysis of social class and the logic of political economy, but only as one among other sources of claims about the elements to which we must attend in analytically constructing particular cases.

Though different, Dahrendorf's attempt to rescue the kernel of marxist dynamics and the capacity of its focus on structure from the sins of teleology and reductionism and from the narrowing traps of political economy likewise suggests how macroanalysis might continue to profit from its marxist (and marxisant) heritage. His *Class and Class Conflict in Industrial Society* (1959) sought to rescue marxian doctrine from the particularities of the historical moment in which it was founded. He did so both by lifting the level of abstraction, substituting a more general language of social structure and conflict groups for capitalism and social classes, and preserving marxism's analytical focus on social change and on the formation of groups in conflict. He superseded class conflict by subsuming it within a more inclusive category of authority conflict which unfolds within the hierarchical structures of society, including those of industry and the state. In designating the motor of social change as that of the presence of a structured and unequal distribution of authority, Dahrendorf insisted that the seats of such authority, hence of conflict, are multiple. They do not exclude property relations and class, of course, but these are given no a priori place of privilege. Their relative importance hinges on a historically distinctive arrangement and positioning of elements. In stressing this position, and in aiming to construct what Robert Merton had called theories of the middle range linking general theory capable of interrogating situations with concrete observations and specific cases (Merton 1949), Dahrendorf also embraced the normative quest, pursued by Moore, to discover a decent democratic modernity based on the recognition, rather than the suppression, of conflict.

What Hirschman and Dahrendorf, separately and together, demonstrate is that it is possible to pursue a relational and structural research program of considerable range and ambition even after marxism loses the hegemonic status it enjoyed in the work of Moore, Wallerstein, Anderson, and other pioneering figures in the macroanalytical revolution in comparative politics; and, moreover, that it is feasible to do so without making the shifts to cross-sectional comparison, to structure at the expense of agency, and to case compar-

ative in lieu of configurative research strategies that Skocpol counseled after her critique of Moore.

It is important to underscore, alongside Hirschman and Dahrendorf, that the revival of a configurative comparative politics does not imply or require commitment to a particular theory, marxist or otherwise, but to an orientation to theory characterized by a cluster of ontological and methodological commitments; most prominently the claim that action and identity must firmly be placed inside structural macrofoundations that are not constantly in flux. Relations among collectivities and individuals are characterized by strong and quite persistent relations. Of course, structures themselves are the products of human agency, but in a wider scholarly division of labor it makes sense for configurative comparativists to focus mainly on the obverse–that is, on how structures constitute and cause identities and actions by tilting and organizing probabilities. The linkage between structure and agency in this perspective is primarily institutional, in the sense of institutions both as composing rules and as formal organizations that are loci for human interaction under conditions of differential power and authority.

INSTITUTIONS AS LIGATURES

In 1925, Harry Elmer Barnes convened an important symposium on "The History and Prospects of the Social Sciences" (which included papers devoted to history and biology). Walter James Shephard's essay on political science took note of the movement away from the state as a central object of analysis: "Metaphysical, deductive, and analytical studies of the state have not entirely disappeared, but they have been definitely pushed into the background." Instead, there had been a turn to investigations that "have provided a vast mass of facts regarding the structure and function of every political institution." Not quite a decade later, Frederick Watkins, then a graduate student of Carl Friedrich but later Professor of Political Science at Yale, published a brilliant historical and analytical consideration of "The State as a Concept of Political Science" in which he strongly urged a turn away from the state in particular to associations in general, and away from a determinate institutional analysis to a focus on behavioral power. As a senior scholar, Watkins contributed the entry on "The State" to the 1968 *International Encyclopedia of the Social Sciences.* He declared victory. The idea that political science begins and ends with the state or should treat the state as a distinctive kind of political association, he wrote, "no longer corresponds to the theory and practice of contemporary political scientists" (Shephard 1925: 425; Watkins 1934; 1968: 155).

The very same year, J. P. Nettl, starting from much the same observation ("The concept of state is not much in vogue in the social sciences right now"), drew a radically different conclusion, the imperative of "integrating the concept of state into the current primacy of social science concerns and analytical methods." Like other scholars who soon sought to "bring the state back in" on the

grounds that the state's monopoly claims to sovereignty over people and territory, its uniquely inclusive and coercive ensemble of institutions, and its nation-defining normative qualities distinguish it from all other modern organizational forms (Evans, Rueschemeyer, and Skocpol 1985),[15] Nettl refused the reduction of the state to just one association or institution among many. The state, he told (and inspired many of) us, "summates a set of functions and structures in order to generalize their applicability," represents an irreducible "unit in the field of international relations," "represents an autonomous collectivity ... as a distinct *sector* or arena of society," and is also what he called "a sociocultural phenomenon." Each of these elements, he insisted, is configured distinctively in specific locations and times (Nettl 1968: 559, 562, 564, 565).

The most important works in macroanalysis in the period just before and after the publication of Nettl's landmark essay either reflected or built on this turn to the state, treating it either as a companion macrostructure to modern capitalism or as an alternative focus competing with the social determinism of marxist class analysis (at just the moment marxism itself was discovering the relative autonomy of the state). But like all such counter-to-trend intellectual revolutions, the turn to the state and to state-centered explanations quickly became the obvious thing to have done. Who really would wish to deny the significance of the triumph of the sovereign state in early modern Europe as the most important political form against such competitors as the Hanseatic League or Italian city-states, or dispute the significance of this political form for the international arena after Westphalia, or gainsay its diffusion so that today virtually every person on the face of the earth is enclosed within a sovereign state that is a member of the international community of states (and equipped with all its cultural paraphernalia)? Quite soon, however, the state-focused research community found itself tightly constrained by a very bulky conceptual elaboration of Nettl, which tended to reduce his rich and complex array of dimensions to simple distinctions between weak versus strong, and federal versus unitary, states; to sneak normative preferences in by the back door (these typically were social democratic, preferring strong states to counter the capacities of capital) without sufficiently examining their assumptions or grappling with the deep illiberality of states as condensations of coercion; and to focus on the explanatory power of statist analysis as opposed to those of other scholarly traditions.

As a counter to these tendencies, the new historical institutionalism has come to a welcome rescue. Narrower than the older macroanalysis, this body of scholarship shifted away from the macrostuctures of the state, the economy, and civil society to focus on institutions understood both as rules of transaction between these sites and as the actual array of formal organizations inside each macrostructure and astride their interactions. Institutions emerged as ligatures fastening sites, relationships, and large-scale processes to each other. What came

[15]The volume was sponsored not only by the SSRC Committee on States and Social Structures but by the Joint Committees on Latin American Studies and West European Studies.

to distinguish historical institutionalism was an insistence that these bonds, though constructed of similar tools across instances, are configured distinctively in particular locations. It is these configurations, perforce, which must become our units of analysis. Further, the new institutionalism demanded that agents always be understood as embedded in institutional milieus; that causal relations of elements and variables always are patterned by context and circumstance; and that historical developments are contingently shaped by choices taken by actors about the content of the institutional links connecting state, economy, and society at key moments of historical indeterminacy (Immergut 1996).

The power and promise of this kind of institutional analysis lies not only in its ability to shift attention from macrostructures to transactions across macrostructural boundaries (after all, that is what the new institutionalism's main subjects of public policy, political economy, and interest representation are all about), but in the manner it connects institutional design to the formation and existence of political agents who possess particular clusters of preferences, interests, and identities. Unlike rational choice, which takes preferences as the point of departure, or behavioralism, which treats action as the site of revealed preferences, historical institutionalism has been vitally concerned with how particular configurations of preferences, interests, and identities come to be politically salient at particular times as products, not just causes; but as causes as well as products.[16] The institutionalist epistemology thus is relational, crossing the divide between structure and agency without seeking to eliminate the heuristic distinction between them.

An outstanding, but vastly underattended, contribution to institutionalist thinking along these lines is the 1986 series of lectures on "how institutions think" by the anthropologist Mary Douglas (Douglas 1986). These focus on how institutional milieus, both normative and organizational, shape human cognition and the dispositions of historical subjects to form solidary groups and to cooperate. Since, as methodological individualists rightly argue, only individual persons can think and act, at issue are the conditions under which thinking and feeling come to be sufficiently cognate to compose collective units of action. This, Douglas argues, is the contribution of institutions. They, in turn, are shaped and reshaped by individuals and groups whose thought and sentiments themselves have been fashioned in institutional contexts. The weak form of an institution is a convention that does not quite seem natural; institutions take strong forms when they appear as if part of the inevitable natural order of things. Early nineteenth-century markets, Polanyi reminds us, took the first form (Polanyi 1944); but late twentieth-century markets have achieved the second. Much the same might be said about state formation. From weak to strong, institutions confer identities by assigning properties to categories, by polarizing, excluding, and grading, and by

[16]In this orientation, it is closer to the approach to rationality drawn from cognitive science focusing on actors seeking to reduce uncertainty under conditions of incomplete or distorted information, associated above all with the bounded rationality perspective of Herbert Simon (Simon 1986).

distinguishing the visible and the obvious from the less visible and the murky. Institutions name and classify. They shape the very categories of plausible and possible thought. But institutions themselves are not natural; they are caused (Wildavsky 1987).

Douglas's text pushed key historical-institutionalist assumptions harder than many who work in this vein find comfortable (especially problematical is her affinity for Durkheim's functionalism and the abstract, at times contentless, quality of her presentation), but its value lies in its crystallization of the kind of work an institutional focus can perform for macroanalysis, not least by refusing an overly aseptic and rationalistic individualism as the only basis specifying microfoundations.

Just this, in part, is what makes Skocpol's *Protecting Soldiers and Mothers* (1992), a revisionist study of welfare state history in the United States, a significant advance on her earlier work. Most comparativists have failed to attend to this book, treating it as belonging to another subfield. This neglect is regrettable. More than any recent text explicitly belonging to comparative politics, *Protecting* revivifies large-scale macroanalysis on terms Skocpol herself once sought to obscure or ignore. The book's configurative approach contrasts with the fool's gold of the earlier multivariate tilt Skocpol first had introduced by way of a critique of Moore's work; and it diverges from her earlier excessive structuralism by tightly linking the organizational forms and identities of key political actors. Unlike the artificial dichotomy between explanations oriented either to the state or to society, what Skocpol now calls her "polity-centered" approach is explicitly and genuinely relational in quality. Moreover, the new book is profoundly interested in political identities, dispositions, and action. *Protecting* is a volume dedicated to understanding the manner in which political institutions and policies shape two-way exchanges between the state and civil society. In making these moves, the text joins the style of the grand macroanalysis of the 1960s and 1970s (with a tilt toward the configurative style of Moore that Skocpol once sought to revise) with the nuance and detail of fine-grained recent historical-institutionalist work in political economy and public policy.

Like the more general project of scholarship in American political development, Skocpol sought to set aside versions of American exceptionalism so strong that they invite consideration of the American case as simply *sui generis.* She did so by making three key moves. Via the route of periodization, she insisted the United States was not the welfare state laggard it often is portrayed as being. Well before the New Deal, it had deployed an extensive system of Civil War pensions (which soon transmuted into a dense and expensive system of transfers) and programs at the federal and state levels aimed at the well-being of children and their mothers. Via the route of an institutionalist analysis both of key characteristics of the federal American state and of the networks of groups and organizations in civil society seeking to influence policy outcomes, she argued there is an elective affinity between policy success and the fit between the form of interest organization and the form of the state. Marshaling this kind of argument, she

continued her very first project aimed at transcending a too-simple class analysis, but now she performed the task without eliding issues of agency and identity or fabricating an affected competition between state- and society-focused variables (substantively, she sought to show why in the early decades of the twentieth century, cross-class coalitions led by professional women proved more effective in securing policy goals than those put together by organized labor). Finally, and most important, via the route of a theory of interaction and transactions, she constructed a dynamic configurative approach to the relationship between public policy, state capacity, and the political goals and capabilities of social groups. There were two central elements to this effort: first, the "fit" and terms of exchange between politicized social identities and group political orientations and capacities, on the one side, and governmental institutions, systems of partisan and interest representation, and the rules (in this case, liberal) of the game, on the other; second, the feedback effects of policies on politics (both on the organization of the state itself and on the identities and proclivities of social groups) (Skocpol 1992: 41-62).[17] This relational and configurative form of analysis made negotiations between the state and civil society the centerpiece of its analysis of specific areas of public policy. Not surprisingly, some historians are made nervous by the systematic qualities of this type of analysis, while some social scientists think its deeply historical qualities are purchased at the sacrifice of analytical elegance and rigor. Actually, these anxieties are the hallmarks of success for a configurative macroanalysis at the junction of history and social science.[18]

What is particularly heartening for the future of a configurative and institutional macroanalysis is that Skocpol's turn to microfoundations in tandem with this type of institutional analysis is hardly unique. Thus, for example, de Swaan (1988) has demonstrated how growth in the scale of both civil society and the state from the sixteenth to the nineteenth centuries radically altered the terms of their interaction, and how this alteration created new kinds of collective action that produced modern welfare states. Silberman (1983), drawing on notions of bounded rationality under conditions of imperfect information, has shown how leaders faced with different institutional conditions of uncertainty about succession and regime change acted to change institutions to make their circumstances

[17]This approach, though novel for Skocpol's corpus, displays a strong continuity with her rejection of simple socially determinist lines of explanation. As before, she continues to reject explanations that begin with socioeconomic situations and that treat the generation of demands by social groups as derived from those circumstances entirely prior to their deployment within a political milieu. For a discussion, see the section on "The Shared Limits of Existing Theories," pp.38-40.

[18]Yet somewhere between *States and Social Revolutions* and *Protecting Soldiers and Mothers,* Skocpol seems to have lost some of her taste for hortatory theoretical invocation. Perhaps because of its Americanist audience and ambitions, *Protecting*'s larger implications are masked as its theoretical and methodological discussions are presented, appropriately enough, only to the extent required to allow its author to quickly turn to the task it focuses on over some 600 printed pages: the calling into question of much received wisdom about the history of the American welfare state. The result is a surprising reticence about theorizing just those issues *Protecting* makes central to its account, including puzzles of comparison and the challenge of microfoundations.

less equivocal. Padgett and Ansell have established how the factional networks in renaissance Florence produced parties and identities: "rules induce roles, which induce interests, which induce strategic exchanges, which lock in patterns of collective action that depend on the rules" (Padgett and Ansell 1993). These various moves inside macroanalysis were uncommon before the new institutionalist impulse took flight.

And yet, though the tools for striking advances are now available, there are no grounds for complacency. Ironically, at a time when most of the best historical-institutionalist scholarship inside the subfield of comparative politics has limited its scope while deepening its power, studies in American political development happily have refused this choice. Though primarily limited to the single case of the United States, it is not just Skocpol's study of social policy but other considerable texts like Bensel's story of the emergence of a one-party state after the Civil War and Skowronek's analytical treatment of the presidency (Bensel 1990; Skowronek 1993) that have recovered much of the audacity of the project of macroanalysis characteristic of the sweep in the scholarship of Moore and Skocpol on revolutions while also inserting the connecting tissue of institutions linking structure and agency within determinate and contingent historical configurations. Like the great texts of old, these works suggest playful periodizations (Skowronek rejuggles presidential administrations, the oldest organizing feature of studies of American politics, into categories shaped by what he calls political time) and propose fresh bases for comparison (thus Bensel argues that post–Civil War nineteenth-century America had more in common with the one-party twentieth-century developing states of Mexico and India than with the European instances usually treated as foils for American history). Having stood just to the side of the elaboration of European macroanalysis when it rushed headlong into structure at the expense of agency and toward state-centered analyses at the expense of relational and configurative accounts, these American studies may well be our richest current source of nourishment for the growth of comparative macroanalysis. Such configurative American political studies, inscribed by the new institutionalism but undogmatic about their ties to behavioralism, rational choice, and the turn to signification, may well do far more than originally intended by the editors of *Studies in American Political Development* a decade ago. Located at the periphery of both American and comparative politics, this genre of work has begun to recover the dimensions of invention and surprise that attracted many of us to political science and to comparative politics two and three decades ago.

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PART III

THEORY DEVELOPMENT IN COMPARATIVE POLITICS